

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Also by Post Peleos

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book One: Hazel Academy

Book Two: The Resistance

Book Three: The Weight of the Source

— — —

Writing adult fantasy romance as

SØREN STROMBERG

A Bond of Scale and Silver

A standalone romantasy of dangerous devotion and the price of being seen. Written for adult readers (18+) — not part of the Saeren Chronicles, and not intended for the same shelf.

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book One: Hazel Academy

Post Peleos

Copyright © 2026 Post Peleos

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the author, except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

ISBN 979-8-2409-9043-4

First Edition

Post Peleos

*For my daughter Raelynn —
may she have all the happiness she deserves.*

CHAPTER ONE

The Path to Hazel

The last ordinary morning of Viridia's life smelled of scorched bread and her mother's tea.

She went down the stairs still half inside a dream, socks loose at the heels, and found the kitchen already awake. Her father stood at the stove in his work shirt, sleeves shoved past his elbow, scraping at a pan with the hopeful determination of a man losing a fight to his own breakfast. Smoke curled thin and grey toward the window. He waved it away with his big hand.

"Don't tell your mother," he said without turning around.

"Tell me what," Bella said.

Her mother was at the table with the newspaper creased into quarters and a cup of tea going cold beside her. She didn't look up. Somehow, she always knew. Viridia slid into the chair across from her. Her mother held a particular stillness, not the stillness of rest, but of deep water. There had never been a word for it. She only knew it did not mean her mother's head was empty.

"Leon invented a new color," Bella said, turning a page. "I believe it is called toast."

"It's character," her father said. He set the plate in front of Viridia with a flourish, dark crusts and all, then kissed the top of her head as he passed. He smelled of soap and machine oil, and of the cold morning he already half walked

through to fetch the milk. "Eat the character. It builds character."

Viridia ate the character. It was terrible. She said so, and her father pressed a hand to his chest as though she had run him through. Her mother laughed, a short, surprised sound, there and gone, the laugh of someone who did not give them away cheaply.

For a moment, the three of them simply existed in the small warm room as the kettle ticked while it cooled. Her mother reached across the table and tucked a loose strand of silver-blond hair behind Viridia's ear instinctively, confirming it was still there.

"You'll do something with all that quiet someday," Bella said. "All that watching. You see more than you let on." She held Viridia's gaze a beat longer than the moment asked for. "Just be careful who you let see you do it."

Viridia thought it was an ordinary thing to say.

For a while, it was.

* * *

Viridia stared at the building that was meant to be her home for the next four years.

The Hazel Preparatory School sat behind a high iron gate and a run of hedges trimmed so precisely they looked less grown than manufactured. The brochure her father had been so proud of called it an impressive institution, founded in 1735 by Hazel Greenwich. It looked like the sort of place designed to make you feel small before it had spoken a single word to you. It was built with grey stone, the flat, colorless grey of a sky that has not decided whether to rain. Its tall windows gave nothing back, only the dull shine of morning light. Somewhere beyond the gate, a bird sang two notes then stopped.

She had been excited, once. Three days ago, a lifetime ago, she had torn open the letter with the Hazel sigil pressed into the wax and felt something lift in her chest for the first time in weeks.

Now she stood at the gate and felt nothing she could name.

Her hand found the stone at her throat without asking permission. Her mother's stone, the smooth dark-blue weight of it, the carved symbols that held a faint light even out here in plain sun. She closed her fist around it and the edges pressed into her palm, steadier than anything else she had. For a moment it warmed under her fingers. The carved lines glowed a shade brighter as her pulse climbed, and under the warmth came a thin taste of cold metal at the back of her tongue. She had known it before and never told anyone. It answered her own feeling, she thought, warming when her pulse climbed and cooling when she did, as though it ran on whatever she was holding down. No one else, she was fairly sure, tasted the gate they walked through. Then it was cool glass again, the taste gone. The sun, she told herself.

She had let her silver-blond hair hang loose this morning; braiding it had felt like more than she could manage. She was slight and fine-boned, the sort of girl grown-ups wanted to feed, and she stood with her shoulders curved inward, not slouching so much as drawn in, making herself a smaller target. Her green eyes had fixed on nothing at all.

Beside her, Aleric Porter had not stopped talking since the motorcar.

"You'll do well here, I'm sure of it," he was saying, hands clasped behind his back, rocking slightly on his heels as he surveyed the school like a landlord pleased with a property he had personally arranged to exist. "They've trained the top

light mages in this country since the doors opened. The very top. The fact that they selected you. Well. That's an honor, Viridia. A genuine honor."

"Yes," Viridia said.

"Four years here, then on to a proper specialty school. Healing's the prestigious route, of course. But there's intelligence work, therapy, the building disciplines. A great many doors are about to open for you. That's the thing to hold on to."

A great many doors. Viridia thought of two that had closed three days ago, her mother and father, three days dead, and would not open again no matter how she stood in front of them. She did not say this. Grief made other people uncomfortable; the kind thing was to keep it where they could not see it.

"I know it's a great deal of change," Aleric went on, and for one moment his voice dropped out of its bright register into something gentler, almost careful. He glanced down at her. "Especially with everything that's happened. But it really is for the best. You believe me, don't you?"

He wanted her to. She could see that he wanted her to, the way a man wants reassurance that the heavy thing he has carried was worth carrying.

So Viridia looked up at him and tried to smile.

It did not work. Her face had forgotten the shape of it. What she produced was closer to a wince, a brief unconvincing twist of the mouth that fooled no one. But Aleric's expression eased anyway, because he wanted to be eased, and he set one large hand between her shoulder blades and steered her gently through the open gate and up the path toward the doors.

Behind them, the iron gate swung shut on its own weight, the sound of it a held note finally let go.

* * *

Aleric knocked twice, briskly, then stepped back and settled both hands on Viridia's shoulders, lightly, but with a certain readiness, half expecting her to bolt the moment the door opened and wanting to be in position to stop her.

For a few seconds nothing happened. Then one of the tall double doors swung inward, and a young woman looked out at them.

She was older than Viridia but not by much, seventeen, eighteen perhaps, a fourth-year by the easy, proprietary way she occupied the doorway. Her hair was long and very black, pulled back into a ponytail that had been redone in a hurry. Her nails were painted black too, chipped at the edges. She wore the Hazel uniform with the small carelessness of someone who had worn it a long time, and at her throat hung a thin chain with a pale stone that caught the hall light.

"Can I help you?" she said, her gaze moving past Aleric to settle on Viridia with frank curiosity.

Aleric cleared his throat. "Ahem. Yes. My name is Aleric Porter, and I'm escorting young Miss Viridia Saeren." He produced the acceptance letter from inside his coat with his free hand, keeping the other firmly in place, and held it out. "She is expected, I believe."

The young woman took the letter and scanned it, and Viridia watched something shift in her face, a small recalibration, quick and contained, gone almost before she had seen it. Her eyes lifted from the page back to Viridia, and this time they did not go to her face. They went, for the space of a single heartbeat, to the dark-blue stone at her throat.

Then she smiled, and whatever it had been smoothed itself away.

"I see. Well, Viridia. My name's Amber Summers. I'm a fourth-year here." She stepped back and held the door wide.

"Come in, both of you. Most everyone's arrived already. We're only waiting on two more."

Not last, then. It was a small thing, and Viridia despised that it mattered to her, but it loosened something all the same. She stepped over the threshold. Behind her the heavy door drew shut, and Aleric's hands left her shoulders at last, and she had the disorienting sense of being handed off, passed out of one set of careful hands into another.

The hallway beyond was long and lush, the floor swallowed under thick carpet that took the sound out of their footsteps. What kept Viridia's attention, though, were the walls. They were hung end to end with paintings: landscapes and portraits and a few stranger things she could not place, some of them clearly old, the varnish gone amber with age, the figures in them dressed in fashions she did not recognize.

She slowed without meaning to.

Amber noticed. Of course she did; Viridia would learn, in time, that Amber noticed almost everything and simply chose what to do about it.

"That one's a Verrane," she said, nodding at a dim seascape where a single ship leaned against a wall of grey weather. "He taught here, supposedly, generations back. And that one there." She nodded at a tall portrait of a stern woman with a hawk on her wrist. "Nobody's quite sure who painted it, or who she even was. One of the early headmistresses, supposedly. The hawk's the giveaway, apparently. I never understood why." She said it lightly, walking backward now to keep facing them, easy and unhurried. "They like their history here. You'll get used to it. Half the building's a museum and the other half's a classroom and sometimes it's hard to tell which is which."

Viridia looked at the woman with the hawk a moment longer. Being told a thing's name helped. The world seemed

less likely to come apart if its pieces could be labelled. Verrane, and the hawk. She took the names with her and walked on.

The hall ended at another door, this one already open onto a large bright room.

Amber stopped at the threshold and turned. For a moment she looked at Viridia again, and there was nothing of the tour guide in it now, something steadier, almost weighing. "Orientation's in here," she said. "Headmistress takes it herself." A beat. "You'll be all right."

It was not phrased as a question, but Viridia understood that it was one, asked sideways the way kind people sometimes ask the things they are not sure they have the right to.

"Yes," she said.

Amber's mouth tipped, not quite a smile. "Right," she said, and led them in.

* * *

The room was built to make an impression, and it succeeded.

It was long and high-ceilinged, a hall or a chapel once, before someone filled it with rows of chairs and a purpose. Light came down through arched windows in long pale columns. High above, the ceiling had been painted ages ago with a faded scene she could not quite make out: figures with their arms raised, and above them something bright that might have been the sun or might have been a fire. No one else was looking up at it.

Fifty chairs faced a raised platform with a single dark desk. The arrangement was deliberate in a way she felt before she understood it: the newest arrivals seated closest, where every word would reach them and where they could

be seen, all at once. A room designed so the front row had nowhere to hide.

The front rows were already half full, and they were loud.

Not loud in any rude way. It was the bright, overlapping chatter of girls who already knew one another, who had met at this gathering or that one, whose mothers were acquainted, who had been writing letters all summer and now fell on each other with the relief of finally being in the same room. They leaned across the aisles. They compared the trim on their uniforms and the charms on their bracelets. One girl was demonstrating something with her hands, a small flourish, and three others were laughing. They had the easy gravity of a thing already formed, a group with edges, and Viridia, standing in the doorway, was very plainly on the outside of those edges.

She was good at this part, at least: the watching. Grief had only sharpened it, stripping away whatever part of her had once wanted to step forward and be included. The one demonstrating the flourish was used to being watched and liked it. The two by the window were performing their friendship a little, for the others.

A tall girl with copper hair turned in her seat and picked Viridia out where she stood. Her eyes did the quick sum strangers do, the loose hair, the slight build, the plainness of her, and landed last on the dark-blue stone at Viridia's throat. They stayed there a moment too long. Then the girl leaned to her neighbor and said something behind two fingers, and both of them looked, and looked away, and laughed. Cruel, Viridia decided, and filed her under it: the kind who picked. It would be weeks before she learned the copper-haired girl had been asking, low and worried, whether the new one had come straight from the funeral she'd heard about, and that the laugh had been the other

girl's, at something else entirely. Viridia, this once, had read the surface and called it the depth.

Up on the platform, behind the desk, a woman sat reading through a stack of papers and did not look up.

Viridia's eye went to her last and stayed longest.

She was not a large woman, but she filled the platform the way certain people fill a space simply by being indifferent to it. She wore a dress in the deep colors of late autumn, burnished gold at the bodice shading to a rose so dark it was nearly wine, with a high collar of emerald green that caught the window light. A pair of rose-tinted spectacles sat low on her nose, and through them her eyes moved down the page with brisk, unhurried attention. Her hair was pinned up. Everything about her was composed and exact and expensive-looking, and then Viridia's gaze dropped, the way it did, to the small wrong detail at the bottom of the picture.

Her shoes were blue. Bright, plain, slightly scuffed blue, the blue of a thing chosen because it was liked rather than because it matched. Under all that careful autumn, the blue shoes were practically shouting, and something in Viridia eased at the sight of them.

Beside her, Amber leaned in, her voice dropped low. "That's Lady Lightwell. The Headmistress. She takes orientation herself every year. Likes to see the new ones with her own eyes." There was something under the words Viridia couldn't read, some private weather, and then it passed. Amber tipped her head toward the front rows. "Take a seat up there. She has it set up so all the new arrivals are sure to hear everything."

Viridia looked at the bright crowded rows. Her stomach tightened. "Where will you be?"

"Don't worry." Amber's smile came easier this time, almost gentle. "I won't be far. Fourth-years sit in the back."

She nodded toward the rear of the hall, where a thinner scatter of older students lounged with the boredom of people who had done this three times already. "I'll come find you the second it's over. You won't even have to look for me."

And with a small wave of her black-nailed hand she was gone, down the side of the room and into the back, leaving Viridia alone at the head of the aisle.

There was nothing for it. She went.

The carpet gave under her feet and took her footsteps with it, so that she crossed the front of that bright room in a silence that felt, to her, enormous. A few of the girls glanced up as she passed, a flick of attention, a quick weighing, the brief curiosity reserved for a newcomer, and then went back to their conversations, because she did nothing to hold them. She did not smile too widely or speak too soon. She simply found one of the last empty chairs near the front, on the aisle, and sat, and set her hands in her lap, and let the noise close back over her like water over a dropped stone.

At the desk, Lady Lightwell squared her stack of papers against the wood with two crisp taps, set them down, and at last lifted her head. The tinted lenses swept once across the rows of waiting girls.

The stone at Viridia's throat went warm. Not the faint warmth of the gate this time. It pulsed once, hard, a heartbeat that was not hers, and the carved lines flared bright enough that she clapped her hand over it before she could think. When she looked up the lenses had stopped moving. They had stopped on her. For a half-second, no longer, Viridia had the distinct and uncomfortable sensation of having been seen. Not glanced at. Seen, the way her mother used to see her across the breakfast table, as though the surface were not the interesting part. Then the lenses moved on, and the stone went cool under her palm, and

there was no telling whether the Headmistress had marked it or whether she had only wanted, badly, to be wrong.

Then the moment let go. The Headmistress clasped her hands, and the bright chatter began, all on its own, to fall away.

* * *

"Hi."

The voice came from her right, low and bright and entirely unbothered by the hush settling over the room. Viridia turned.

A girl had taken the chair beside her. Had, in fact, moved into it, judging by the bag still half-shrugged off one shoulder and the slightly breathless look of someone who had relocated across an aisle on purpose. She was about Viridia's age, with long blond hair and green eyes and a smattering of freckles scattered across a small nose. She was a little heavier than the other girls, and she wore the uniform, the black vest with its white embroidered H over the right breast, the white undershirt, the brown skirt to just above the knee, the long white socks, with none of the casual carelessness Amber had. She wore it as something brand new and slightly miraculous, still not quite able to believe it was hers to wear.

She was smiling. It was a wide, open, helplessly friendly smile that showed teeth a little crowded at the front, one of them turned just slightly out of line, and there was nothing in it of the weighing Viridia had felt from the other girls. It was a smile with no edges at all.

"My name's Alice," she whispered, leaning in close and conspiratorial. "Alice Pembroke. What's yours?"

"Viridia," she said. And then, because the girl was still looking at her with such frank expectation, "Viridia Saeren."

"Viridia." Alice tried it out, and seemed pleased with it. "That's a good name. Mine's just Alice. There were three Alices in my year at home." She made a small face about it, comic and unselfconscious. "I always had to be Alice P."

Viridia did not know what to say to that, so she said the first true thing that came to her. "I like your uniform."

It was a small thing, almost nothing, but Alice's whole face lit with sudden pleasure. She smoothed the skirt down over her knees with both hands, a quick proud gesture. "Do you really? I keep thinking it's going to turn out to be a mistake, that someone's going to come and tell me there's been a mix-up." She laughed, soft, so as not to carry. "Nobody in my family's ever. I mean, I'm the first. The first one of us who could do any of it. So all this still feels a bit like I borrowed it." She tucked her hair behind her ear, and there was, for just a second under the brightness, something carefully managed, a self-consciousness she was choosing to wave off rather than let sit. "Is your family, were they all mages? You look like you belong here. You've got that look." And then, lighter, but with a small edge under it she did not seem to hear herself put there: "Old blood, I bet. You can always tell. It must be nice, knowing the room's yours before you walk into it."

It was not meant unkindly. Viridia understood that even as it landed. But it landed all the same, on the one morning she had nothing to land on: the assumption that the stone at her throat and the name on her letter were a kind of welcome she had been issued at birth, when in truth they were the last warm things left of two people three days dead. For a moment she could not answer, and the silence stretched a beat too long, and she watched Alice register it without understanding it, watched the bright face flicker, uncertain whether it had given offense and how. The room's not mine, Viridia did not say. Nothing is, just now. She let

the silence cost her the smile she might have given, and let Alice sit in not knowing why. It was the first thing between them that did not go smoothly, and it would not be the last; but it was the first.

Before either of them could mend it, a clear voice cut across the hall from the platform, and the last threads of conversation died at once.

"Good morning."

Lady Lightwell had risen. She stood very straight behind the desk, hands resting lightly before her, and her gaze moved unhurried across the rows. She did not raise her voice. She did not have to; the room had already given itself over to her.

"Welcome to Hazel. Some of you have waited a long time to sit in those chairs. Some of you have family who sat in them before you." A small pause, weightless and precise. "And one or two of you, perhaps, are still wondering whether you have made some kind of mistake in coming."

Beside her, Alice went very still.

"You have not," Lady Lightwell said. "You were chosen. Every one of you. Remember that, in the months to come, on the days when it does not feel true."

It was a kind thing to say, and meant kindly; Viridia could hear that much. And yet something sat underneath it she could not quite name. A second meaning, tucked beneath the careful words the way her mother used to bury meanings in ordinary advice, be careful who you let see you do it. The surface warm, the thing beneath it watchful. You were chosen. Said one way, it was reassurance. Said another way it meant you were selected, and assessed, and we know exactly why you are here.

The Headmistress went on: the daily schedule, the rules of the grounds, the four years here before they moved on to schools of their specialty. It washed over Viridia in a low

even tide. She caught pieces and let the rest go. She was tired in a way sleep did not touch, the bone-deep tiredness of holding a great deal of weight very still for days on end, and the bright hall and the level voice made it hard to keep her edges from blurring.

Twice, Alice nudged her gently with an elbow, once at something funny Lady Lightwell said about the kitchens, and once, more quietly, when the Headmistress mentioned that students who had lost family were always welcome to speak with the staff. The second nudge was softer than the first. It was not a did you hear that nudge. It was a small wordless I'm here nudge, offered and then withdrawn, and Viridia understood that somehow, without being told, Alice had read something in her in the last five minutes that the rest of the room had not.

She did not look over. She could not, just then. But she let her arm stay where it was, a hair closer to Alice's than it needed to be, and Alice did not move away either, and the two of them sat like that, not speaking, while the Headmistress told them all the things they were now permitted and forbidden to do.

When at last Lady Lightwell drew her hands together and said, "That is all. Welcome again. You may go," the room came apart into noise and motion all at once, fifty chairs scraping, fifty voices rising, the formed and friendly group reassembling itself in an instant.

Viridia stayed sitting a moment longer than the rest.

* * *

The room emptied all at once, loud and relieved, the way a crowd lets go the moment it is allowed to.

The girls rose in a wave of scraping chairs and bright voices, gathering bags and gathering each other, already deciding in clusters where to go and who would walk with

whom. Plans formed in seconds. Did you see, are you in the east wing, come find me at. The formed and friendly group simply picked itself back up and carried itself out the tall doors. The copper-haired girl passed at the head of it, and slowed as she came level with Viridia's chair, her eyes going again to the stone at the throat.

"Saeren," she said, reading the name off nothing, tasting it. "You'll want to keep that tucked under your collar, you know. People talk." She smiled, sweet and exact. "I'm only being kind. Welcome to Hazel." And she was gone before Viridia could decide whether it had been a warning or a threat, leaving the words sitting where she'd dropped them.

The sound of the crowd thinned down the carpeted hall until the great room had nearly drained.

Viridia stayed in her chair.

It was not a decision. Her body had declined to stand, and she let it, because the effort of rising and arranging her face felt like more than she had.

Her hand had found the stone again, the carved edges biting gently into her palm. None of them knew, the girls with their plans and their easy gravity. They walked out into the bright simple front of their lives and not one of them could have guessed that the quiet girl in the front row was drowning, and had been for three days, and was getting frighteningly good at doing it where no one could see. The pressure behind her eyes built. She breathed around it. She did not let it past. No one sees you do it, she told herself, in something close to her mother's voice. You decide who sees.

"Hey."

Alice had not left.

She was standing in the aisle with her bag on her shoulder and one hand resting on the back of the next chair, and she was not smiling now, or rather she was, but it had gone soft and uncertain at the edges, the smile of someone

who has noticed something and is not sure they are allowed to have noticed it. She did not sit. She did not crowd. She just stood there, near but not too near, and asked the question gently, as if it might break if she said it too loud.

"Are you okay?"

For a moment Viridia could not trust her voice. She got it under control. She loosened her grip on the stone, and she looked up, and she made her face do the thing faces are supposed to do.

"Yes," she said. "I'm fine."

Alice looked at her.

She knew. Viridia could see that she knew, that the yes had not landed, that it had gone out into the air between them and simply failed to convince anyone. Something passed behind Alice's green eyes, some small recalculation. And then, instead of pressing, instead of asking again or saying anything kind enough to undo her, Alice did the one thing that worked: she let it be.

"Okay," she said easily, as though she believed her completely. "Come on, then. We're probably supposed to find out where we're sleeping. I'll get lost on my own, I just know it." She tipped her head toward the doors, friendly and unbothered, holding the moment open without ever once stepping into it. "Walk with me?"

And Viridia, who had not let anyone see her since the morning the world ended, found that she could stand up after all.

CHAPTER TWO

The Emergency Meeting

They had not gone ten steps down the carpeted hall before a voice came after them.

"There you are."

Amber caught up with the easy lope of someone who had never once in her life hurried and did not intend to start now. She fell into step on Viridia's left, pleased with herself, a little, the way people are when they have done a kind thing and are glad to be caught at it.

"Told you I'd find you," she said. "I'm very reliable, in the things that don't matter." Her gaze went over Viridia's head to Alice, who was looking up at her with open wonder. "And you've made a friend. Good. Hold on to that one. First-day friends are the ones who knew you before you'd decided who to be."

"Alice," said Alice, sticking out a hand with the careful formality of a child minding her manners at a grown-ups' dinner. "Alice Pembroke."

"Amber." She shook it, gravely, and let it go. "Fourth-year. Viridia's sponsor, as of about an hour ago, which I'm told is faster than anyone's supposed to do it." She made a small face. "I've always been a bit impulsive."

Viridia turned the word *sponsor* over and could find no place to set it down. She had been chosen for something

twice now in three days, and both times by people who would not quite tell her why.

"What does that mean," she said. Not quite a question. She rarely asked things outright; she preferred to set a sentence down between herself and a person and watch what they did with it.

"It means," Amber said, "that when you trip over something in this place that you don't understand, and you will, it's built out of things nobody explains, you come and find me instead of working it out alone in the dark. That's the whole of it, mostly." She glanced sideways, and for a flicker the lounging ease went out of her and something steadier looked through. "The rest we'll get to."

Then it was gone again, smoothed away the way Amber smoothed everything away, and she was telling them where to find the west wing, and which staircase ate the most time if you took it during the rush, and that they should unpack now because the afternoon would not stay empty for long.

It did not, in fact, stay empty at all. But none of them knew that yet.

* * *

Room fourteen was halfway down the west wing, the number painted on a brown door in a gold that had begun to flake at the edges.

They opened it on a room cut neatly in two. A bed on each side, a desk, a small dresser, a nightstand, all of it doubled and facing inward across a stretch of floorboard, and between the beds a single round window, large as a wagon wheel, that let the afternoon in across both halves equally. It was, Viridia thought, a room designed by someone who believed that fairness was the same thing as kindness and had never tested the idea.

On each bed sat luggage. Alice reached the right-hand bed first, read the gold letters embossed on the suitcase there, and turned around grinning.

"These are yours." She crossed to the other bed and dropped onto it as though she had owned it for years. "I've got a roommate. A real one. I was so sure they'd put me with someone who'd." She stopped, and waved the rest of the sentence away, the way she did, before it could become a thing she'd said out loud.

Viridia went to the right-hand bed. Three suitcases, her name in gold down the side of each, the same gold as the flaking number on the door, the school stamping everything it touched with the same hand.

The first held her clothes and her uniforms, folded by someone who was not her mother. She put them away.

The second she knew by its weight before she opened it. Books. Her mother's books, the spines she had grown up reading the titles of without being allowed to read the insides, the worn cloth covers her mother's hands had worn. The smell came up out of the case when she lifted the lid, paper and dust and something underneath it that was just the smell of her mother's shelf, her mother's corner, the particular air of a room that no longer existed and never would again. Viridia's hand stopped on the lid. For one moment the room was very loud and very far away.

She made herself lift the topmost book anyway. It was a slim thing in faded green cloth, a book of pressed-flower studies her mother had kept by the kitchen window, the pages gone soft and the green spine sun-faded to grey along one edge where the light had reached it year after year. Viridia opened it without meaning to. Between two pages, flat and brown and weightless, lay a single pressed violet, one her mother had put there, some ordinary afternoon, alive once and picked once and laid down by a hand that was

gone. Viridia looked at it for what felt like a long time and was probably no time at all. Then she closed the book very gently, so as not to disturb the flower, which was a foolish thing to worry about and she worried about it anyway.

She closed the case. She moved it to the side, to deal with later, which was the place she put most things now.

The third suitcase was different. The fabric had sigils stitched into it in thread that caught the light wrong, the way her stone caught it wrong. She opened it slowly.

Inside, on a bed of black velvet, lay a slim silver rod with a rounded head at one end. And tucked beside it, folded once, a note in a hand she had never seen, not her mother's looping script, not her father's careful block letters, not the school's gold-stamp efficiency. A stranger's hand, and a steady one.

This is called a focus. To the best of my knowledge it has been passed down on your mother's side for more generations than anyone has counted. During your first magic class you will be asked whether you need one. Tell her no. Keep this with you always.

That was all. No name. No love. No spirits-guide-you. Just an instruction, and the more she looked at it the less it read like a gift and the more it read like a hand on her shoulder she had not felt arrive. Someone had known she would be asked a specific question, in a class she had not yet attended, by a teacher she had not yet met, and had decided in advance what her answer would be. *Tell her no.* It was not phrased as advice. It was phrased the way you tell a thing to a person you are managing.

She picked the rod up. It was lighter than it looked and colder than the room. The rounded head had a single line running through it, the mark of something meant to come apart into two halves and be mended. Down the body ran fine scrollwork and, in among it, words in the same

not-quite-language as the carvings on her stone, and she could no more read them than she could read the wind.

Keep this with you always.

A grieving, guarded girl does not read that as destiny. She read it the way she read a too-smooth face across a table: not *who chose me* but *who has been arranging me, and for how long, and what for.*

She slid the rod into the loop she found sewn at the waist of her skirt, where it sat as if the skirt had been made around it. The moment it settled against her hip the focus went briefly cold, then warm, a small private greeting, and somewhere at the very edge of her attention something else seemed to turn toward the warmth and take notice. Then it was only a metal rod against her leg, and the room was only a room, and she pushed all three suitcases under the bed, the books and the focus and the note and her folded ordinary clothes, the whole inheritance of her, out of sight.

"You're quiet," Alice said, from her own bed.

"I'm always quiet."

"No." Alice tilted her head, considering this with the seriousness she gave to most things. "You're quiet like there's a lot of it. That's different." Then, perhaps hearing herself, she colored and rushed on. "Sorry. I do that. My nan says I'd ask the moon what it weighed."

Viridia found, to her own surprise, that the corner of her mouth wanted to move. She let it. "What did the moon say."

"Wouldn't tell me." Alice grinned, delighted to have landed the joke. "Stuck up, the moon."

She let it go after that, slid off into talk of the room, of where the bathing rooms were, of whether the round window opened, and Viridia understood that the letting-go was deliberate, that Alice had found a closed door and chosen, on purpose, not to lean on it. It was the second time.

Viridia was beginning to think it might be the most reliable thing about her.

They unpacked in the comfortable way of two people who have decided, provisionally, to know each other. Alice talked the whole while, and arranged a small army along her windowsill: a knitted rabbit gone bald at the ears that she set out and then, catching Viridia's eye, defended ("don't, his name's Stitch, he's been everywhere I have"), a tin of sweets, a framed photograph she stood facing her own pillow. Viridia put out nothing. The difference between their two halves was plain, the populated and the bare, and Alice clocked it and said nothing, which Viridia counted, privately, as the third reliable thing.

"There," Alice said, when Stitch was settled and the sweets were hidden and the room was as much theirs as an afternoon could make it. She flopped back onto her bed. "Home. For four years." She said it bravely and it cracked very slightly at the end, on *years*, and she heard it crack and plowed straight on. "Tell me one thing about you. Anything. I've told you my whole life and I don't know one thing about you and we live here now."

Viridia thought about it. There were a great many things she would not say. She looked for one she could. "I like knowing the names of things," she said at last. "Paintings. Plants. People. If I know what a thing's called I feel better about it being in the room."

Alice weighed this, then nodded slowly. "That's a good one," she decided. "That's a real one. All right." She rolled over, satisfied, as though a fair trade had been struck. And in a way one had.

* * *

It was Alice who folded first, the way bright things do when the day catches up with them.

"I've never been away from home this long," she said. She was sitting cross-legged now, smoothing the same patch of skirt over and over. "I keep thinking, four years. My nan'll have got old by the time I..." She stopped. "That's childish, isn't it. Being homesick before it's even dark."

"No."

"My family's never." Alice tucked her hair behind her ear, the small managing gesture. "I'm the first. So everyone's so proud, and I can't be the one who comes home because she missed her nan." She laughed, too quickly. "What about yours? I bet they're..."

She did not finish. She did not need to. *Proud* was already in the air, already arriving, and there was nothing Viridia could do to step out of its way.

It came up under her ribs the way water comes up a well, fast, without asking. Her eyes filled before she had decided anything. She turned her head toward the round window, toward the flaking gold and the trimmed-flat hedges beyond the glass. Her thumbnail found the seam of her skirt and pressed there until it stung, one clean point of feeling to count against. Breathed once, around it. Did not let it past. Let her face go still. *No one sees you do it*. Her mother's voice, or close enough.

It held. It nearly didn't, and then it held.

"Oh," Alice said softly, behind her. "Oh, I'm sorry. I didn't." And then she was off the bed and across the floor and kneeling in front of Viridia, not touching, just there, near and careful, the way you stand near a thing you're afraid of breaking.

Viridia turned back when she could trust her face. "It's all right." Her voice came out level, and she logged the levelness the way she logged a sum that came out even, one small thing held in place. "My parents died. Recently. I'm..." She had been going to say *fine*. She heard how it would land

and chose something truer instead. "I'm still getting used to it."

Alice did not say any of the things people said. She did not say *they're in a better place* or *time heals* or *at least*. She just stayed where she was, kneeling on the cold floor of a room she'd had for an hour, and after a moment she reached up and patted Viridia very gently on the top of the head, twice, exactly as one might reassure a cat that the storm was nearly over. It was such an odd, graceless, kind thing to do that Viridia nearly laughed, which was, she suspected, the point.

"Come on," she said, and got up, and offered Alice a hand off the floor. "Let's go, then."

The chime cut her off.

It came from everywhere at once, a single long bronze note that climbed up through the floorboards and hung in the air of the room and would not quite finish. Both girls went still under it.

"That's not the breakfast one," Alice said. "Is it? I haven't heard the breakfast one. But it doesn't *sound* like breakfast."

It did not. It was a held note finally let go, Viridia thought, and then she thought of the gate that morning, swinging shut with that same sound, and decided not to say so.

* * *

The hall outside had filled with girls, all of them moving the same direction, the easy formed groups of the morning re-forming on the move.

A first-year with dark hair and a quick way of turning her whole head to look at things, the one Viridia recognized from the orientation room, the one who'd kept glancing at the door, fell back to walk beside them.

"You two are in fourteen, aren't you. I'm Della, I'm across in seventeen." She said it all in one breath. "A fourth-year

came round and said emergency meeting, dining hall, everyone. She wouldn't say what. She had a *face* on, though." Della's eyes were bright with the particular pleasure of being first with bad news. "First day and an emergency. My mum said it'd be quiet here."

"What kind of face," Viridia said.

"The kind they have when someone's hurt and they're not saying who." She dropped her voice to a thrilled hush and touched two fingers to Viridia's sleeve, the confiding gesture of a girl handing over contraband. "You didn't hear it from me." And Della bounced ahead to find her own people, having delivered the thing she'd come to deliver, already, plainly, deciding how she would tell the next one, leaving the two of them to follow the current down.

The dining hall was the largest room Viridia had seen yet, and the school had not been short on large rooms. Double oak doors stood open onto it. Four long tables ran the length of the floor, and a fifth crossed the far end, raised slightly, for the staff. The smell reached her before the rest of it did: bread, and something rich and brothy, and the green smell of cut herbs, and under it the warm animal noise of two hundred girls who did not yet know why they had been called. High along the walls hung iron brackets where lamps had been lit against the early dark, and their light fell warm and uneven across the long tables, catching here on a polished spoon, there on a girl's bright hair, leaving the corners of the great room in a soft brown gloom. The ceiling was lost up in it. Serving girls in grey waited at the edges, hands folded, watching the staff door the way everyone was watching it. Two hundred girls and you could hear, under the talk, the particular thin sound of people who have been told *emergency* and not been told why, the talk pitched a half-note too high, breaking off too soon, starting up again too fast.

The fourth-years had taken the left. The first-years drifted right. Viridia sat where Alice sat and watched the staff table, which was empty, and waited, like everyone, to find out what kind of day it had become.

Lady Lightwell came in through a door behind the staff table. She had changed nothing about herself, the autumn dress, the rose-tinted lenses, the blue shoes going quietly about their business under all that composure, and the room hushed without being asked, the way it had at orientation, the way water goes flat when something heavy is set on it.

Behind her came a fourth-year. And the room, which had hushed, made a sound.

The girl was holding her left arm against her chest. There were claw marks raked through the shoulder of her uniform, dark and stiff where the blood had dried, and below the elbow there was less of her than there should have been. Her hand was gone, and a good part of the forearm with it, the sleeve folded over and pinned where the rest of her ought to be. She kept her head down. She did not look at any of them.

Viridia heard Alice's breath go in and not come out for a moment.

"Normally," Lady Lightwell said, into the silence, "an incident like this would be handled quietly. We would heal what could be healed, we would say nothing, and we would carry on, because every girl in this room knows there are things beyond that gate that would be glad of the chance to kill her." Her voice was level and almost gentle, and that was the worst of it. "I am not handling this one quietly."

She let the room hold that.

"This young woman walked into the forest on her first afternoon and attempted to bond a fully grown dragon. With its mate." A small pause, weightless and exact. "Not ten paces away." The lenses swept the rows. "If that mate had

not had cause, already, to think kindly of this school, she would be dead. There is no healing that brings back the dead. There would have been nothing I, or any of us, could have done but bury her and write to her family about the dangers of the forest. Do you understand me. There would have been *nothing*."

No one moved.

"A dragon's claws carry its magic," she went on, more quietly, to the girl beside her now rather than the room. "They resist the healing we can give. Go to the infirmary. I'll be along." And the girl went, down the long aisle between the tables and out, cradling the place where her hand had been, and two hundred girls watched her go and not one of them said a word.

Lady Lightwell turned back. "We give the girls who do well here a great deal of freedom," she said. "Freedom to choose. Freedom, even, to be wrong. But knowing the size of a thing before you reach for it, knowing what it will cost you to be wrong, that is the first lesson, and the only one I will teach you twice." She picked up a small bell from the staff table and rang it, twice. "Eat. Then sleep. The first bell comes early."

And she was gone, out the doors, on her way to a girl with one hand.

For a long moment nobody touched the food. Then somewhere down the second-year table a fork scraped a plate, and the spell broke, and the room remembered it was hungry.

"I'm not going in the forest," Alice said, very firmly, to her soup. "Ever. They can fail me."

"You'd survive the forest," Viridia said. "It's the dragons you'd want to leave alone." She had no idea, saying it, that she would soon ignore her own advice entirely. She thought she was making a joke.

Alice snorted into her bowl, which Viridia counted, privately, as a small victory.

* * *

They came back to room fourteen quiet, the way the whole school had gone quiet, and got ready for bed without much talk.

"I'm glad they put us together," Alice said, from under her blankets, already half gone. "In case I didn't say."

"You said."

"Good." A pause, smaller. "Night, Viridia."

"Goodnight."

Alice was asleep within minutes, breathing soft and even, the deep instant unguarded sleep of someone who has not yet learned to lie awake. Viridia listened to it for a while in the dark. She had lost the trick of that, dropping off the edge of a day and trusting it to catch you, since the morning the world ended. She did not envy it, exactly. She just noticed she had lost it, the way you notice a coat you used to have.

When she was sure of Alice's breathing, she reached under the bed and drew out the second suitcase.

She did it slowly, the latches one at a time, muffling them against her palm. The smell came up again, her mother's shelf, and this time she let it. From the top of the stack she lifted the spellbook. She knew it was the spellbook the way you know a thing in a dream, without being told, a heavy thing bound in dark worn cloth, the corners soft with handling. She had seen it on the high shelf all her life. She had never once been allowed to open it.

She opened it now, by the thin light from the round window.

The first page was a tree. Not a drawing of a tree but a family tree, drawn in her mother's hand and other hands before it, a branching tangle of names going back and back,

dates beside them, lines crossing and dividing, the ink at the top of the page brown with age and the ink at the bottom still nearly black. She found her mother's name near the foot of it. *Bella*. And beside it, in the same near-black ink, her own. *Viridia*. Someone had written her into this before she was old enough to read it.

She traced upward. The names meant nothing and everything, strangers who had her blood, going up into the dark of a thousand years. Some she half-knew from the edges of stories, names that turned up in the histories she'd been made to read, and not all of them were names you wanted to find sitting in your own tree. Light mages and dark mages both, tangled together on the same branches as though no one had thought, back then, that it mattered which you were.

And then, near the middle, where the tree was perhaps four hundred years deep, one name with no dates beside it at all.

Every other name had dates, born, and died, the small brackets of a life. This one had neither. Just the name, sitting on its branch with a line going down out of it into the rest of the tree, connected to everything, accounted for by nothing. The name itself meant nothing to her; she was nearly certain she had never heard it spoken, not in any story, not in any of the histories she'd been made to read. A stranger on her own branch. She put her finger on it. She could not have said why it pulled at her. Only that her eye had gone to it the way it went to blue shoes, to chipped nails, to the one thing in a careful arrangement that did not match, and that her mother, who had drawn this page, had let it stand.

She would have looked longer. But the page after the tree was a letter, and she had not known there would be a letter, and once she had seen her own name in her mother's hand

at the top of it she could not have stopped reading it to save her life.

Dear Viridia,

If you are reading this, then I have passed beyond the veil.

She read it through once, fast, the way you take cold water, and then again slowly. Her mother told her the book had come down the family for generations, and the focus with it. That most of the spells in it were ordinary, the kind any mage might keep, except the dark ones, which her mother said were unique, and said it as plainly as she might have said *the blue cups are in the high cupboard*, as though dark magic were simply a thing the family kept in the house. She told her to add her own spells, when she had them, so that whoever came after would have them too. *Light and Dark, good and evil*, she had written. *They are both sides of the same coin. It is only how you choose to look at it.*

And then, near the end, the line Viridia would carry the way she carried the other one:

No matter the circumstances of my passing, always know that I loved you.

The circumstances of my passing. As though there had been circumstances. As though her mother, writing this at the kitchen table while the toast burned, had known there would be circumstances to be uncertain about. Had known, and not said. Had folded the knowing into ordinary words and left it for Viridia to find on a night like this one, in a school full of strangers.

Be careful who you let see you do it.

It was the same voice. It was exactly the same voice, the warm surface and the watchful thing underneath, and her mother had been speaking to her in it her whole life and Viridia had thought it was only the way mothers talked.

She did not cry. She was very good at it by now, the not-crying. She closed the book instead, slowly, and held it

against her chest with both arms, the way Alice had not quite touched her shoulder, the way you hold the one thing the flood has not yet taken, and she lay down that way, curled around a thousand years of names and a letter from a woman who had known something she would not say, and somewhere in the holding of it she went, at last, the way Alice had gone, over the edge of the day and down into the dark.

CHAPTER THREE

Introduction to Magic

The breakfast chime was a kinder sound than the other one, two notes instead of one, and they let each other go.

Alice woke all at once, gasping, hair everywhere, one cheek printed with the seam of the pillow. "Is it." She squinted at the round window, where the morning was coming in grey and clean. "It's food, isn't it. That's the food one. I'm learning the bells."

Viridia was already awake. She had woken with the spellbook still against her chest and had put it in the nightstand drawer before Alice's eyes opened, the latch easing shut under her thumb, the family tree and the letter and the line about *circumstances* all folded away into the dark of a drawer where they could be a secret again. The note from the focus she left where it was, under the bed. *Tell her no*. She had a class to get to where someone was going to ask.

They dressed and went down. The dining hall in the morning was a different room than the one that had held the maimed fourth-year: bright, ordinary, loud with cutlery, the staff table populated now by teachers in various states of being awake. The food was already steaming on the long tables, and the sight of it did something visible to Alice's whole face.

"I could get used to this," she said, loading her plate with a happiness she made no effort to hide. Bacon, eggs, toast,

more bacon. "At home it's porridge. It's *always* porridge. My nan thinks anything fried is a sin against the morning."

"It might be," Viridia said, taking toast. "Doesn't make it wrong."

Alice pointed her fork at her, delighted. "See, that's exactly it. You say a thing like it's nothing and then I think about it all through History." She ate. She thought, evidently, about the next thing. "What've we got first?"

"Introduction to Magic."

"Right. Good. I want the magic part. I've been a mage for." She counted on greasy fingers. "Nine months and I still can't do anything except make the focus warm up. They tested me, they said *yes, congratulations, you're one of us*, and then nobody taught me a single thing. I've been *holding* it this whole time."

Viridia understood that better than she let on. She, too, had been holding something a long time without being taught what it was.

"Nine months and nothing," Alice went on, around a corner of toast. "Do you know what they let me do, at home, once they knew? Nothing. My mum cried, which was nice, and then everyone treated me like I'd turn the milk if I touched it. The Harlows two floors down stopped letting their little ones play with my cousins, in case I." She waved her fork. "Rubbed off, I suppose. In case it was catching." She said it lightly, the way she said the things that weren't light at all. "First-generation. You'd think I'd done it on purpose to embarrass them."

"You did do it on purpose," Viridia said. "You're here."

Alice stopped chewing. Something went over her face, quick and surprised, the look of a person handed a thing they had not known they wanted. "Huh," she said. "Yeah. I suppose I did." She put the toast down. "See. That. That's the kind of thing you say."

Down the table a knot of second-years were comparing the trim on their cuffs, and one of them glanced over at the new girls and back, the brief weighing Viridia had learned to feel without looking up for. Alice felt it too; her shoulders came in a half-inch, the old self-consciousness, and then, visibly, deliberately, she pushed them back out again and reached for more bacon. Viridia watched her do it and thought: she is braver than she knows. She did not say so. She was saving it, the way she saved most things, for a day it might be needed more.

* * *

The Introduction to Magic room was on the first floor, in the hall opposite the orientation room, and it was the first place in the school that had felt to Viridia like a place worth being.

It was small and warm and crowded with growing things. Pots lined the windowsills, herbs and flowers and one ambitious vine that had got its fingers into the curtain rail. The light came in friendly. There were tables instead of ranked chairs, and the tables had marks on them, ink stains and scorch rings and the carved initials of girls who had sat there before, and Viridia found she liked that, the way the room admitted, plainly, that things had happened in it.

They got a table near the front. They had hardly sat down before the teacher came at them, beaming.

She was a small round woman in a red dress that had been bought for someone slightly larger, with frizzy brown hair escaping its pins in every direction and a pair of large glasses that magnified pale blue eyes into something owlish and kind. Silver hoops swung at her ears. There was a ring on her finger that caught the light differently from ordinary silver.

"I'm Mrs. Zoran, and I'll be your teacher this year," she said, all in a rush, as though she'd been waiting all summer

to say it. "I do hope you're ready to learn and have a bit of fun while you're at it." And then she was off to greet the next table, and the next, leaving the two of them grinning at each other.

When the room was full and the introductions made, Mrs. Zoran went to the front, clasped her hands, and asked: "What is magic?"

A pause. Then a brave girl near the window, Beth, she'd said, offered, "Light?"

"Not quite, dear."

"Power," said another.

"No-o." Mrs. Zoran shook her head, hoops swinging, pleased rather than disappointed. "Anyone else?"

Viridia had the answer and considered, for a moment, not giving it. The note's instruction sat in her like a second pulse: *don't draw the wrong sort of attention*. But the answer was simply true, and there was a difference, she decided, between showing off and not lying, and she lifted her hand.

"Energy."

"And why do you say that?"

"Because we don't make it." Viridia turned it over even as she said it, finding the shape of it. "And we can't get rid of it. It's already there. We just push it about." She heard how plain that sounded and let it stand.

Mrs. Zoran's whole face lit. "*Well* done. Other answers aren't wrong. People have argued this for a thousand years and they'll argue it a thousand more. But that, that is the closest we've come. Magic behaves like energy. We don't create it and we can't destroy it. We only learn to take hold of what's already in the world and bend it to our intent." She rubbed her hands together. "Which brings us to the interesting part. How do you take hold of it?"

No hands. She had not expected any. She slipped the ring off her finger and laid it flat on her open palm.

"This is a focus. A foci, if you've more than one, which most of you will one day. It helps me channel what I have toward what I want." She put it back on, turned to the potted plants on her desk, and passed her hand slowly over a bare clay pot.

For a moment nothing. Then green came up out of the soil, fast, a stem unspooling, leaves opening, and at the top a bud that swelled and split and went red, a deep wet poppy-red, the petals shivering as they unfolded. The whole class breathed in at once. The room smelled, suddenly and entirely, of turned earth.

There was something else, too, and Viridia seemed to be the only one who caught it: a faint cold draught with no open window to explain it, a thin thread of metal laid along the back of her tongue. It was there and then it was gone. She pressed her tongue to her teeth and said nothing, and around her the other girls only clapped and craned for a better look, feeling, as far as she could tell, nothing at all.

"Now." Mrs. Zoran took the ring off again and set it on the desk, where it sat looking utterly ordinary. "This is what can happen without one."

She passed her bare hand over the next pot.

The pot exploded.

Not enormously, but enough. Clay shards skittered off the desk, soil sprayed in a fan across the floorboards, and a whole flower, roots and all, arced up out of the wreckage and landed petals-down by Alice's shoe. A leaf drifted, last of all, into the silence.

"It isn't always so dramatic," Mrs. Zoran said cheerfully, into the general flinch. "But you see the trouble. The focus doesn't make the magic. It *holds* it. It pinches the flow down to something you can aim, and it firms up your intent into the bargain. Will is everything in this work, girls. If your will is soft, your magic will be softer." She brushed clay off her

sleeve. "Some people learn in time to do without, to hold the flow and the intent in nothing but their own concentration. It takes years. It takes more years than most of you will spend here. For now." She hauled a wooden box up onto the desk. "You'll want one of these."

She opened the lid.

"Those of you without a focus, come and choose. And, this matters, don't snatch. Take your time. Hold one, then another. You're not picking the prettiest. You're feeling for the one that feels like *yours*. You'll know it when it answers." She glanced up. "And those of you who already have a focus of your own, come and show me, so I can write it in your file."

* * *

The class came forward in a slow press, and the box turned out to be full of small wonders: pendants and rings and rods and beads, none of them quite ordinary, each catching the light with its own private weather.

Two girls did not go to the box. Viridia almost did.

She stood at the back of the press with her hand on the rod at her waist and found, to her own surprise, that she resented the note. *Tell her no*. A stranger had reached into her luggage and decided, in advance, what her mouth would do in a room the stranger would never see. She thought, for one cold contrary moment, of walking up to the box and taking some pretty bead from it just to prove that no unseen hand was working her like a puppet on a string. Her fingers actually loosened on the rod.

Then she stopped, because that was its own kind of being arranged, doing the opposite of a thing only because you'd been told the thing. She made herself find the real reason underneath both. The rod was her mother's. It had been in the family longer than anyone had counted. It was the last

warm thing she owned. She would keep it because *she* chose it, not because a note told her to and not to spite the note either, and she would do it in the open, where the choosing was hers and visible and could not be mistaken for obedience. It cost her something to decide that. The note had wanted her to pocket the thing quietly, unexamined, drawing no eye. She was about to do the opposite, and she knew, standing there, that she was trading the small safety of going unnoticed for the larger fact of being the one who decided. She came her three days to Hazel wanting to disappear. She let go of that on purpose, in a warm crowded room full of growing things, and walked to the front to be seen choosing.

The other girl who had not gone to the box was a girl named Rose, who came up holding out her wrist, where a tiny silver hammer hung from a bracelet.

"Ah, Miss Rose." Mrs. Zoran took the wrist gently and turned it. "Your mother's old focus?"

"My grandfather's, ma'am." Rose said it with a small fierce pride. "I bonded it when I was little. He let me hold it and it sort of warmed up. Nobody could get it off me after that."

"I can see the bond on it, clear as day. A good strong one." Mrs. Zoran patted her hand. "You're excused the rest of today and tomorrow both. We'll be covering ground you've already walked. Use the time as you like." Rose went back glowing, and Viridia thought: that is what it looks like, to have a thing from a dead grandparent and be allowed to be only proud of it.

"And you, Miss Saeren." Mrs. Zoran held out her hand. "Show me."

Viridia slid the silver rod from the loop at her waist and gave it over, and watched the teacher's face change.

Mrs. Zoran turned it in her fingers, slowly, the cheerful patter gone quiet. She ran a thumb along the scrollwork. She tilted the rounded head to the light and found the single seam that ran through it. "Where did you come by this?"

"It was my mother's. It's been in the family." Viridia chose her next words the way she chose all of them lately. "I'd rather use hers than take one from the box."

"You were told correctly." Mrs. Zoran's eyes came up over the top of her glasses. "Do you know what the writing says?"

"No, ma'am."

"No. I shouldn't think many would, anymore." She turned it once more, and seemed to come to a decision, or several decisions, fast, behind the owl glasses. "It hasn't been used in a long while. Foci go to sleep, if they're set down long enough. Let me wake it for you." She held the rod out before her in both hands and frowned at it the way one frowns at a stuck jar.

Then she pushed her magic into it.

Viridia could not have said how she knew, she had no name yet for the sense that told her, but she felt it happen, felt the pull of it from a foot away, the way you feel a draught from an opened door. The hair rose along her forearms, the way it had lifted over the poppy pot, only stronger now, much stronger. The cold metal taste came back into the back of her mouth, and she pressed her tongue to her teeth and made it stay there, unmentioned. Mrs. Zoran drew a breath and gave the rod everything she had. The half-orb at the top kindled, a pure white light welling up inside it until it shone fierce and steady, and the rod itself *moved*. It lengthened in her hands, the silver flowing longer the way water finds a slope, growing and growing until what she held was no longer a rod but a slim white-glowing cane near four feet long, the carved scroll running its whole length now, the seam in the orb glowing brightest of all.

The light faded. The cane stayed.

Mrs. Zoran let out her breath in a rush and put a hand on the desk. There was sweat at her hairline. "There," she said, and the cheer in it was a little frayed at the edge. "Just wanted waking, that's all." She held the cane out, and Viridia took it, and it was hers, balanced and quiet and warm in her hand, made to the length of her arm.

"I'll be honest with you, dear." Mrs. Zoran said it low, just for her, while the rest of the class craned and murmured. "I've primed a great many foci in my time and I've never met one like that. It took everything I had and it wanted more. It was." She searched for it, and seemed unsettled by what she found. "It was practically *begging*. As if it had been thirsty a very long time." She straightened her glasses and her smile both. "You've your work cut out for you with that one. Back to your seat, now."

Viridia went back to her seat carrying a four-foot glowing cane and the distinct sensation of having brought something to school that was hungrier than she was.

Mrs. Zoran turned to the class. "Can anyone tell me why Miss Saeren's focus was so hard for me to use?"

Rose's hand. "Because it isn't attuned to you. It's hers. If she'd already bonded it, you wouldn't have got any magic into it at all."

"Just so. Which is what we'll be doing tomorrow: bonding you to your new foci. A small ceremony, nothing to fear." She winked. "Mostly."

Alice had been bouncing in her seat for the whole exchange and could contain it no longer. She held out her cupped hands. In them lay a small five-pointed star on a thread-thin chain, and the star was not made of any metal Viridia could name, and it pulsed, faintly, from somewhere inside itself, a soft rhythmic light with a beat of its own.

"Look at it," Alice breathed. "I didn't understand what she meant, about resonating. I thought it was teacher-talk. And then I picked this one up and it was like." She pressed it briefly to her chest. "Like it *recognized* me. Is that mad? That's mad. Ooh, I can't wait for tomorrow."

"It suits you," Viridia said, and meant it.

"She said it'll grow with me." Alice cupped the star, watching the slow pulse of it. "When I get stronger it'll change, sort of. Show what I'm becoming." She looked up, and the brightness in her was so unguarded that Viridia had to look away from it, the way you look away from a window with the sun straight in it. "Imagine what it'll be in four years. Imagine what I'll be." Then the brightness wobbled, just once. "If I don't get sent home for being thick at it first."

"You won't."

"You don't know that."

"No," Viridia agreed. "But you make the focus warm up, and you've never been taught a thing, and you knew which star was yours the second you touched it. That's not nothing. That's a great deal of something, with nobody to help it." It was more than she usually let out. She rarely said so much. But Alice had looked, for half a second, the way Viridia felt all the time, and Viridia could not leave her standing there in it alone.

Alice's eyes went bright again, differently. "There you go again," she said, thick. "Stop it, I'll cry into the man's flowerpots." She knuckled at one eye and laughed and put the star carefully away inside her collar, where it sat over her heart and pulsed against her skin, hidden.

Then Viridia looked down at her own cane, white scrollwork and a thirsty seam, and the thought came before she could stop it. "I'm not sure I'll be able to hide this."

Alice gave her a strange look. "Why would you want to hide something you'll use every day?"

"No reason." Viridia laid the cane along the table. "Just thinking aloud."

* * *

Mrs. Zoran kept them another few minutes, a word about making your own focus one day, in fourth year or sooner with a sponsor's say-so, and how a focus you forged yourself was always better, bonded to you in the making, shaped to the magic you'd actually use, and then she opened the door with a wave of her hand and wished them a good day.

Viridia had her books half-gathered when the teacher said, "Miss Saeren. Stay a moment, would you."

Alice paused at the door. Viridia gave her a small nod. "I'll wait on the bench by History," Alice mouthed, and slipped out, glancing back once before the door swung shut.

Then the room was empty but for the two of them and the smell of turned earth and the broken pot still scattered on the floor.

Mrs. Zoran did not go back to her desk. She drew a chair around and sat in it, close, and gestured Viridia into the one beside her, and when Viridia had sat she said a thing that was not about the weather or the class or anything at all.

"Knowledge is power."

Viridia waited. She had learned that when adults said an odd thing in an odd voice, the kindest and the wisest course was to let them get to the rest of it on their own.

"Do those words mean anything to you?"

"No, ma'am."

"They're written on your focus." Mrs. Zoran held her hand out for it, and Viridia, after a breath, gave the cane over. The teacher traced the script with one finger, slowly, and read it aloud, and Viridia understood that she was being given something, that the reading-aloud was itself the gift.

"*Knowledge is power. Yet may whomever hold this rod have the wisdom to use such power wisely.*"

She let it sit.

"That first part, *knowledge is power*, has been a kind of war-cry, in its time. The creed of a great many dark mages, down the years. The belief that no knowledge should be kept from anyone. That no law has the right to govern a person's conduct, only their own conscience." She turned the cane in her hands. "It has started wars, that idea. It has ended them. The light mages have spent six hundred years afraid of it." She looked up. "I am about to tell you something I'd be wiser to keep behind my teeth. I'll have to trust you to be wiser with it than I'm being."

"You can," Viridia said. Whether it was true she could not have said. She found she wanted it to be.

"This focus wasn't made for a light mage." Mrs. Zoran said it quietly. "Nor for a dark one, exactly. It was made for someone with *both*."

She watched Viridia take that.

"Now. There's a quarrel among the few scholars who still care to quarrel. Some of us believe that once, a very long time ago, most people were born with both sides of the gift. Light and dark, whole, in one person. The records from that far back are mostly ash and rumor." Her voice dropped. "But we know one thing. At some point the light mages went to war on the dark. A crusade. They put whole families to the sword. Whole lines, ended."

Her mouth thinned. "I've my own opinion as to why so many are born with no gift at all these days. I think we killed our way to it."

Viridia did not move. "So it's a dark focus."

"It's an *old* one. Older than the war, I'd guess, from the script and the metal. Made, perhaps, when whole was the ordinary thing and nobody thought it strange." She handed

the cane back, and Viridia took it in both hands. "It's the strongest focus I've ever held. And it was made for someone with both sides of the gift."

The words sat between them. Mrs. Zoran did not ask the question. Viridia could see her decide, very deliberately, not to ask it.

"I don't want to get into trouble," Viridia said instead. It was not a lie. It was simply not the whole of what she was feeling, which she had no intention of showing anyone.

"Then keep it that way." Mrs. Zoran was quiet a moment, turning something over behind the owl glasses, and when she spoke again it was lower still, almost to herself. "I had a brother. Older than me. He was born with the dark side, and I with the light, same parents, same kitchen, same bread, and you'd have thought, the way the world treated us, that we'd been got by different fathers entirely." She smoothed her too-big sleeve. "He was the gentlest soul I ever knew. He kept bees. He couldn't kill a wasp, never mind a person. And they came for him all the same, because of what he *might* one day choose to be, and that was reason enough." She blinked, and the brightness came back up over the memory, a curtain drawn against a draught. "So you'll forgive an old woman for caring rather a lot about who gets called wicked for the shape of the thing they were handed. It's not a tidy subject for me."

There was nothing to set against a grief that old. So Viridia gave her the true thing instead. "I'm sorry."

"It was a long time ago." Which was not, Viridia noticed, the same as saying it no longer hurt. Mrs. Zoran reached out and, just for a moment, put her hand over Viridia's where it gripped the cane. "I'll tell you what I believe, and then I'll stop, because I've already said more than's safe." She leaned in. "I don't think the dark side of the gift makes a person wicked. I've known kind dark mages and cruel light ones,

and the gift made no difference to either. It's only ever how you use the thing you were handed." She drew back, and the warning came up in her like a finger raised. "But you must understand. There are very few people in this school as easy in their minds about all this as Lady Lightwell and I. Out there." She nodded toward the window, the gate, the world. "Fewer still. So whatever you carry, carry it quietly. Especially the day you walk back out that gate."

She rose, stiff in the knees, and helped Viridia up after her. "Off with you. I've made you late for poor Mr. Cote, and there's no quicker way to age a girl than an hour of his lecturing." The cheer was back, mostly. "Go on."

Viridia thanked her, for the cane, for the words, for the risk she had only half-understood, and went out into the corridor.

* * *

The corridor was empty. The class had gone on; Alice was waiting somewhere down by History; the school went about its loud distant business one floor up and one floor down. For a moment there was nobody, and Viridia stopped, and held the cane up before her in the grey window-light.

She turned it slowly. The seam in the orb. The scroll she could not read. *Made for someone with both sides of the gift.* She did not know, yet, what that meant about her. She had a suspicion she had been carrying since the orientation hall without daring to take it out and look at it, and she did not take it out now. But standing alone in the empty corridor, she allowed in, briefly, something that grief had pushed under for days, not its grey weight, not the careful work of keeping her face level.

She turned the cane once more and watched the grey light slide down the white scroll. A focus that had been thirsty long enough to frighten Mrs. Zoran. A focus made for

someone whole, in an age when whole had been ordinary, handed down a tree of names a thousand years deep to a girl in a corridor who could not read its writing. It ought to have been too large a thing to hold. It sat balanced and easy in her hand, the way the rod had sat in the loop of her skirt, the skirt sewn around it. As though, somewhere down all those branches, someone had measured her without ever having met her.

She felt watched.

Not in the room. The corridor was empty. Watched across time. Someone in a strange hand had known she would be here, and packed her a thing thirsty enough to frighten her teacher, and told her in advance what to say. She had not done as the note said, not exactly; she had kept the focus, but on her own terms and in the open, and the open was the part the note had not wanted. She wondered, now, whether she had just spent something the stranger had meant her to keep. The seam meant to come apart into halves. The name with no dates. Her mother's *circumstances*. It was a door someone else had already walked through, ahead of her, leaving it on the latch. Behind the grief she heard herself want to know who, not the warm wanting of a girl handed a destiny, but the cold steady wanting of one who has found a stranger's footprints in her own house.

Then footsteps somewhere, and a girl's laugh, and the school came back. Viridia slid the cane into the loop at her waist, where it now stuck out absurdly past her knee and there was nothing to be done about it, and went to find Alice on the bench by History, carrying her question quietly, the way she had just been told.

CHAPTER FOUR

History and Lunch

If the Introduction to Magic room was a window thrown open, the History room was a cellar somebody had forgotten to air.

The blinds were down and the lamps turned low, and the light that survived all that came through brown and tired, the color of old varnish. Books were stacked along the walls in leaning towers, more books than there were shelves to hold them, and over everything lay a fine grey felt of dust so old it had stopped being dirt and become a kind of weather. When Alice breathed in too deeply she sneezed, and three girls sneezed after her, and the dust drifted and resettled and did not care.

At the front, behind a desk that groaned, sat a very large man in a brown tweed suit that had given up trying to contain him. Grey hair, a long grey beard, a belly that arrived a moment before the rest of him did. He waited until the last girl was seated, with the unhurried patience of a man who knew the room would always, in the end, wait for him.

"Good afternoon, ladies. I am Mr. Cote, and I shall be teaching you the history of our people." His voice was deep and dry and entirely without hope. "It is my belief, and Headmistress Lightwell's, that by studying those who came before, you may contrive to make some *new* mistakes, rather than repeating the abundant old ones." He let that land on

no one. "Open your texts. Read the first two chapters. When you have done, raise a hand and I shall give you a small quiz, after which you may go to your lunch." He folded his hands on the great shelf of his belly. "There will be no discussion. There is nothing in the first two chapters worth discussing. That comes later, when you are old enough to be disappointed by it."

And he sat, and the room sat, and for the better part of an hour there was nothing but the rustle of pages and the occasional ruinous sneeze.

The reading was dry and Viridia drank it anyway. The first chapters laid out the thing Mrs. Zoran had told her sideways an hour before, only flattened into dates. The light mages had risen, six hundred years gone, into the seats of government. The dark mages had been pushed first to the edges of power and then off them. And further back, in an age the text called *the Sundering Wars* and handled with the brisk discomfort of a family discussing a hanged uncle, there had been a long campaign to put the dark lines to the sword.

The text did not call it a crusade. The text called it *consolidation*.

Viridia's pencil stopped. She thought of a beekeeper who could not bring himself to swat a wasp, and of what *consolidation* would have meant for him. She underlined the word with her eye and did not underline it on the page.

She took notes: the years of the wars, the trade laws that had followed, the slow squeeze that had turned the dark-born and then the gift-less into people who got the work nobody else wanted. It was all written in the flat untroubled voice of a winner explaining why the winning had been only sensible, and Viridia found she could read the cruelty in the gaps between the dates as plainly as if it had been set down in full, the way she read the thing under a

too-smooth face. The book did not lie. It simply declined to feel anything, and left the feeling to her. And once, near the end of the second chapter, in a paragraph plainly included so it could be dismissed, she read a thing that stopped her pencil.

Certain of the old texts make reference to creatures said to issue from beyond the veil, the so-called Horrors of antiquity, which drained the life from any they touched. No reliable account survives, and the modern scholar may safely regard these as the embroidery of a frightened age.

The embroidery of a frightened age. She read it twice. She did not know why it caught in her, only that it had the same wrongness as a name with no dates, a thing the page wanted her to walk past, and so she stopped at it on principle. She copied the sentence into her notes, *creatures from beyond the veil, dismissed*, and then felt foolish, and then left it where it was.

Beneath the paragraph sat a small crude woodcut: a figure with too many limbs reaching out of a black doorway toward a fleeing man, captioned, in the curling type the book reserved for things it found quaint, *A peasant's rendering of the Horror*. The man in the woodcut had dropped his lantern, and the artist had taken care, across all those centuries, to show it falling, the little scratched lines of its light going sideways. Viridia looked at that detail, the dropped lantern, the spilled light, longer than the page deserved, and could not have said why a frightened age's embroidery should feel, in the dim cellar of the History room, quite so much like a warning somebody had folded up small enough to forget.

She turned the page. The next chapter was about grain tariffs. She was almost grateful.

When she had read enough, she raised her hand. Mr. Cote beckoned her up, took a quiz paper from the stack, and laid down the law in a murmur. "Notes, yes. The book, no. Bring

it to me when you've done and take yourself off to lunch." She carried it back and saw Alice rise to fetch her own; they passed in the aisle and traded a quick conspirator's smile, two girls let out of the cellar a few minutes early.

The quiz had fifteen questions and fourteen of them were facts. The fifteenth was not.

Do you think the light mages of the Sundering acted rightly in seeking to end the dark lines? Defend your answer.

Viridia sat with her pencil over the page for a long time.

She knew what the room wanted. She knew what six hundred years of *consolidation* wanted, what the gold-stamped suitcases and the rose-tinted Headmistress and the gate that closed behind her three days ago all quietly wanted. The safe answer wrote itself: *the dark mages were dangerous; the light mages protected the world; regrettable but necessary*. She could see the sentence whole before she'd written a word of it. It would cost her nothing.

She thought of Mrs. Zoran's brother, who kept bees and could not kill a wasp.

She wrote: *No*.

Then she stopped, because *No* was not an answer, it was a cliff-edge, and she made herself climb back from it and build the path properly. *No*, she wrote, *I do not think they acted rightly*. She wrote that some of the dark mages had surely been wicked, that any large group held its share of the wicked, light or dark or gift-less. But that being capable of harm was not the same as having done it, and that to kill a person, or a family, or a whole line of families, for what they *might* one day choose was to punish them for a crime no one had committed yet. She wrote that a thing was not made safe by ending everyone who could conceivably threaten it; it was only made smaller, and more afraid, and more willing to do the next terrible thing.

She read it back.

Her hand wanted to change it. The want came quite distinctly, the small animal urge to scratch it out and write the safe sentence, the one that cost nothing, the one nobody could come for her about. *Be careful who you let see you do it.* Her mother had not been talking about quizzes. But the voice fit anyway, and for a moment Viridia held the pencil and hated, with a clean cold fourteen-year-old's hatred, that she had to think about it at all, that a true thing should have to be weighed against the danger of being seen to think it.

She got up before she could lose her nerve and laid the paper face-down on Mr. Cote's desk, and he took it without looking, and she went out into the corridor with her heart going harder than a quiz had any right to make it go.

"I'll see you in a few," she told Alice on the way past, and Alice, halfway through her own essay with her tongue between her teeth, lifted her pencil in salute without looking up.

* * *

The dining hall at the wrong hour was a sleepy, half-lit place, the long tables mostly empty, the lamps not yet lit for the meal.

Only the fourth-years were in, scattered down the left in loose ones and twos with the boneless ease of people who had nowhere they urgently had to be. Heads turned when the door opened, the brief reflexive weighing of a room checking who'd come in, and then went back to their business when they saw it was only a first-year.

Only Amber didn't go back. She was lounging sideways across a bench with her boots up on the next one, and she lifted a hand. "She's with me," she called down the table, to no one who'd asked, and unfolded herself and came over. Today her black hair was tied back and there was fresh polish on her nails, very black, already chipped at one

thumb where she'd evidently been at it. There was an ink smudge on the side of her hand, the writer's smudge, the kind you got from dragging your fist across a wet line, and Viridia marked it: so Amber, for all her lounging, had been writing something, somewhere, before this.

"You're early," Amber said, dropping onto the bench beside her. "Cote let you out already? He must like you. He kept me the full hour every time, the old toad. What'd he set you?"

"Two chapters and a quiz. We could use our notes."

"The using-your-notes ones are the only mercy in that class." Amber stretched. "He's not so bad, underneath. Bores me to weeping, but he's straight with you, which is rarer here than you'd think." She reached into a pocket sewn into her skirt and drew out a folded square of paper. "Here. I copied the whole independent-study list off the board by the library. Have a look. Anything jump out?"

Viridia unfolded it and read. Most of it she crossed off behind her eyes as she went: cookery, deportment, household administration, the long gentle slope of subjects designed to make a girl pleasant and employable and no trouble to anyone. But three caught and held. *Beginners' Magical Theory and Application*. *Magical Creature Taming*. And, last on the list in a slightly different ink, *Magical Warfare*.

"That last one's not like the others," Viridia said.

Amber's mouth did something complicated. "No," she agreed. "It isn't." She didn't explain it. She tapped the first one instead. "Theory and application's Zoran's. You'd like her. The taming one's a whole semester to learn something that takes an afternoon, but it's on there if you want the slow road." She watched Viridia's finger rest on the third line and not move. "And that one," she said, "is mine to worry about. Come on. We're going to go and ask for some things, and I

want you behind me and quiet while I do it. Can you be quiet?"

"I'm very good at quiet."

"Yeah," Amber said, looking at her a beat too long. "I noticed. Come on."

She pulled Viridia up, and over the noise of standing called down the hall, "Kari, tell Alice I've stolen her roommate for lunch, would you," and a girl down the table waved a hand without breaking her conversation, and then they were through the door behind the staff table and into the parts of the school the brochure did not photograph.

* * *

Lady Lightwell's office sat at the top of a narrow stone stair, behind a door that did not match anything else in the building.

It was banded in steel, the dark metal woven somehow *into* the wood rather than nailed on top of it, and across the bands ran a line of small red runes that Viridia could not read and did not like the feel of. Amber knocked. A voice told them to come, and they came, Amber first, Viridia a careful step behind.

The room beyond was plain to the point of severity, which surprised Viridia in a school that gilded its luggage. A simple wooden desk. A few bare patches of wall where pictures had clearly once hung and been taken down. And on the desk, just two things: a great white crystal on the right, clear as river ice, and a great onyx crystal on the left, black and drinking the lamplight rather than throwing it back. One white. One black. Sitting on the same desk, an arm's reach apart, the way the names had sat tangled on the same branches.

Lady Lightwell looked up over her rose-tinted lenses, set down the paper she'd been reading, and took the spectacles off entirely.

"Ladies. How can I help you."

"Ma'am." Amber's voice changed, the lounge going out of it, replaced by something more careful, a person picking her footing. "As you know, I've sponsored Viridia Saeren. A sponsorship usually buys a little room in a girl's schedule, so I've come to ask about hers."

The Headmistress's eyes moved to Viridia. They went, for the briefest instant, to the dark-blue stone at her throat, and Viridia felt it, the small specific weight of being looked at *there*, the same flick of attention Amber had given the stone at the door three days ago. Then it passed. "And what is it you'd ask for, Miss Summers?"

"Two things." Amber took the folded list from Viridia's hand. "First, I'd like her excused from History and put into Mrs. Zoran's Theory and Application instead. She's not for an archivist's desk, ma'am, and I can't see what else Cote's class buys a girl like her."

"Substituting a core subject is rarely done. Even with a sponsor."

"I know. But half the time a first-year doesn't know yet what she's for, and we make her take the safe class anyway, and four years later she's qualified for the life she'd have fallen into regardless." Amber said it fast and even, a speech she'd had ready. "Another class would do her more good. I believe that, ma'am, or I wouldn't spend the breath."

Lady Lightwell regarded her for a long moment. Then, faintly, she almost smiled. "You make a tidy case. Very well. I'll allow the substitution." She drew a sheet toward her, wrote a brief note, and held it out. "Give that to Mr. Cote so he knows to mark her absent and not truant. Was there a second thing?"

"There was." Amber did not take the note straight away. She glanced sideways at Viridia, a flick, a warning, *brace*, and then squared up to the desk. "Yes, ma'am. Two things, actually."

Something shifted in the room. Lady Lightwell set down her pen. She picked her spectacles back up off the blotter and turned them over once in her fingers, slowly, and did not put them on. "Before you go on, Miss Summers," she said, and her voice had gone very level, very quiet, the dining-hall voice, the *I am not handling this one quietly* voice. "Be aware that what you are about to ask may cost you. Do you understand that?"

"I do, ma'am."

"Then ask. But ask knowing it."

Amber breathed out. "I'd like permission to teach Viridia to summon and bond a creature myself, rather than putting her through a semester of the taming class. And." Her voice held, barely. "I'd like her placed in your Magical Warfare course."

The spectacles went still in Lady Lightwell's hand.

"That is a one-on-one course," she said. "It is not a thing that should appear on any list handed to a first-year. It is not, in fact, on the master list at all."

"No, ma'am. I put it on her copy myself."

"You." For the first time the composure cracked, just along one edge, and what came through it was not quite anger and worse than anger: it was alarm, quickly mastered. "I teach that course to fourth-years. To a chosen few of them. *Why*, Miss Summers, would you put it in front of a girl who has been in this building for three days?"

"Because she needs it." Amber did not look away. She had gone a little pale but she did not look away, and Viridia, still at Amber's shoulder, felt something move in her chest that she could not yet name and would later understand was the

beginning of loyalty. "She's got no one, ma'am. No family, no money behind her, no soft place to land if this all goes wrong. The other girls have people. She has herself. And I'd rather she be able to *rely* on herself than be pleasant and helpless and at the mercy of whoever's in the room." She swallowed. "I know what it costs me. I'm spending it. On purpose. On her."

For a moment Lady Lightwell said nothing, and the nothing was worse than shouting would have been. She rose from her chair and went to the window, where a sliver of afternoon got through the blind, and stood with her back to them, and when she spoke it was to the glass.

"Do you have any idea," she said, very softly, "how careful a person has to be, to keep a place like this open? How small a reason it would take to close it?" She turned. Behind the rose lenses her eyes were hard to read, but her hands had folded together in front of her, very still, the stillness of someone holding something down. "And you ask me to put a three-day first-year into the one course in this school I would least like to explain. You think you know what you're asking. You don't. The answer is no, Miss Summers. I'll allow the substitution and not the rest. Take your win and be glad of it."

It was meant to be the end. The door was swinging shut, Amber's favor sliding back unspent into a future that would never come round again, and she did the thing she had been told not to do.

"You said it would cost her," Viridia said.

The room went quiet in a new way. Amber's head turned a fraction; *quiet*, the turn said, *I told you quiet*. But Viridia had stepped half out from behind her, and she did not step back. Lady Lightwell looked at her — really at her now, the whole of her — and waited.

"You said what she's asking might cost her," Viridia went on, and kept her voice level the way she kept everything level, "and she spent it anyway, on a girl she's known three days, because she thinks I'll drown without it. So she's right that I have no one. But I'm not asking you to keep me safe. I wrote on Mr. Cote's quiz this afternoon that the light mages were wrong to put the dark lines to the sword, and I knew when I wrote it that it was the answer nobody in this building wanted, and I wrote it anyway, because it was true." She let that sit a beat, in a room with a white crystal and a black one a hand's reach apart. "I'm not going to be pleasant and helpless. I'm going to be in the world whether you teach me or not. The only question is whether I go into it knowing what I'm doing." She heard how much of herself she was setting out on the desk, in the open, the way she'd set the focus out that morning, and she let it stand. "Teach me how not to be at the mercy of whoever's in the room. That's all I'm asking. I'd rather you than the world."

The office was very still. Amber had stopped breathing.

Lady Lightwell came back from the window slowly. She looked at Viridia for a long moment, and something in the rose-lensed face shifted, the way a held thing shifts when it is set down. "You argue like someone's taught you to," she said at last, quietly. "Or like no one had to." She let out a breath. "And you do not even know yet to be afraid of what you just said in front of me. That is the most dangerous thing about you, Miss Saeren. You notice things, and then you say them out loud, in the wrong rooms, to the wrong people, because they are true. The world has a name for girls like that, and it is not a kind one."

"Then tell me what I'm asking," Amber said, finding her voice again, low and brave. "Tell me what we're asking."

"No." Lady Lightwell's mouth thinned. "I'll grant it, against my better judgment, and I'll let you both go on

thinking you understand it, because the alternative is worse. That's the kindest thing I can do for you today." She came back to the desk and sat. "And it is, you should know, considerable unkindness dressed up as a favor. Remember that I warned you. Both of you." Her eyes stayed on Viridia a beat longer. "I grant it because of what *she* showed me just now, Miss Summers, not only because you paid. You should know that too. You bought the door. She is the one who walked up and knocked on it where I could see her face."

The office was very quiet. The white crystal sat beside the black one. Outside the steel-banded door the school went on, distant and unknowing.

Lady Lightwell looked at Viridia for a long, weighing moment, not at the stone this time, but at her, the whole of her, the way she had looked at the rows in the orientation hall, as though the surface were not the interesting part. Whatever she saw, she did not say. At last she let out a slow breath and set the spectacles down.

"Fine," she said, and the word came out tired, far more tired than a single word ought to be able to sound. "Amber Summers, you have used your one favor. There will not be another. Not for her, not for yourself, not for anyone. Do you understand me clearly?"

"Yes, ma'am." Amber dipped her head. "I expected as much."

"I'm sure you did." Lady Lightwell had, briefly, the face of a woman who had watched something she valued spent on her behalf and could not decide whether to be grateful or furious. "I'll send for her when the warfare lessons are to begin. For the summoning, see Ms. Locke for the supplies. Tell her you have my word on it." She put her spectacles back on, and behind the rose-tinted lenses she became the Headmistress again, complete and closed. "Now go, both of

you. I've a school to run, and you've a great deal of luck to not waste."

* * *

They did not speak until they were down the stone stair and around the corner, out of the reach of the steel-banded door.

Then Viridia put a hand on Amber's arm and stopped her.

"I don't understand what just happened in there," she said. "She said it would cost you. You went pale. You spent something you can't get back and you spent it on a girl you met three days ago." She held Amber's eyes the way she rarely held anyone's. "Why would you do that? You don't know me."

Amber leaned back against the cold stone wall. The lounge was gone; she looked, for a moment, exactly her age and no older, a girl of seventeen who had just done a frightening thing and was waiting for her own heart to slow. "Certain of us fourth-years," she said carefully, "get sent on jobs. Now and then. The ones willing to go get a few privileges out of it. And one favor. One thing, anything within her power, asked once." She studied a chip in her nail polish with great attention. "That's what I spent. That's what it cost."

"That's not what I asked." Viridia kept her voice gentle, but she did not let go of the question. "I asked why *me*."

For a second she thought Amber wouldn't answer at all. Then Amber pushed off the wall, and the grin came back up over whatever had been underneath it, the way the surface always came back up with her. "Maybe I just like a long shot," she said. "Maybe I'm impulsive, like I keep telling everyone. Maybe I lost a bet." She started walking, fast enough that Viridia had to follow. "Or maybe," she threw back over her shoulder, lighter than air, "I'm a very good

judge of people and you'll make me look brilliant in four years. Come on. We've a creature to find you, and the afternoon won't keep."

It was a deflection and they both knew it was a deflection, and Viridia let it go, the way Alice let things go, on purpose, not leaning on a closed door. But she did not forget it.

She was thinking, too, about what she herself had just done. She had come to Hazel meaning to go unseen, and in two rooms in one day she had stood up and let herself be looked at — first the focus, waked and examined in the open instead of pocketed quiet as the note had wanted, and now the office, where she had stepped out from behind Amber and put the truest, least safe thing she owned on a Headmistress's desk. Amber had spent a favor she could not get back. Viridia had spent something too, and she had spent it knowingly: the anonymity she had walked in craving, the small grey safety of being no one anybody remembered. Lady Lightwell remembered her now. *The most dangerous thing about you.* She had handed the woman the dangerous thing herself, with both hands, and she could not pretend it had been done to her. She took the question, and the pale face, and the way Amber's eyes had gone to her stone at the door three days back, and she folded them down small and put them away with the note in the strange hand and the name with no dates and the violet pressed flat in a green book.

She was beginning to have rather a lot of things put away.

* * *

Alice found them at the foot of the creature-class corridor, breathless, her bookbag half off one shoulder and a smear of pencil-lead along her jaw where she'd been resting her chin on her hand.

"There you are. Kari said you'd been *kidnapped*, she said it just like that, she enjoyed it far too much." Alice pulled up, took in Amber, took in the corridor, took in whatever was still hanging in the air around the two of them. "Why do you both look like you've seen a ghost?"

"We've been to the Headmistress," Viridia said.

"On *purpose*?" Alice's eyes went round. "What did you do?"

"Nothing yet," Amber said, recovering her grin. "Give her time." She glanced at Alice properly then, the weighing look, but a kinder version of it than the fourth-years gave at the door. "You're the roommate. Pembroke." It wasn't quite a question. "Listen. Don't take it to heart that nobody's spoken to you yet about sponsoring. It's early. Keep your head up and do the work and someone'll notice. Someone who's right for you." She said it offhand, but not carelessly, and Viridia understood that Amber was steering, that she had someone in mind already, or a kind of someone, and would no more say so outright than she'd answer *why me*.

Alice flushed, pleased and embarrassed at once. "Oh. Thanks. I wasn't, I mean I was a bit." She gave up on the sentence and grinned. "Thanks."

"What did Cote set you in the end?" Viridia asked her, partly to spare her, partly because she wanted to know.

"Same as you, I'd think. Two chapters, fifteen questions." Alice made a face. "I knew all the dates. It was that last one that did me. The essay one."

Something went still and careful in Viridia. "What did you put?"

"For whether the light mages were right to." Alice dropped her voice without seeming to decide to, the way you do near a thing that might be dangerous to say loudly. "I said no. I said it was wrong." She picked at the strap of her bag. "I sat there ages. I kept thinking, this is the sort of question where there's an answer they *want*, you know? You can feel

it. And I nearly wrote that one. But then I thought about the Dunmores, back home, dark family, three floors down, they kept to themselves and the dad mended everyone's boots for next to nothing and one winter when my nan was poorly Mrs. Dunmore brought broth up every day for a week and never once said a word about it." Alice shrugged, and the shrug was not light. "And I thought, you'd have killed *her*? For what she *might* do? So I wrote no." She looked suddenly anxious. "Was that stupid? Have I gone and failed my first history quiz being self-righteous?"

For a moment Viridia could not speak at all, and for once grief was not the reason.

"No," she said, when she had it. "You haven't been stupid." She did not say *I wrote the same*. She did not say *you have no idea how much I needed to hear that someone else looked at that question and could not write the safe thing either*. She filed it instead, the broth and the boot-mender and the way Alice had said *you'd have killed her?*, set among the things she was keeping, except that this one she kept warm, near the front, where she could find it. "It wasn't stupid," she said again. "It was right. They're not always the same thing here. You should know that. But this time they were."

Amber had been watching the two of them with an odd expression, half amused and half something else, something almost wistful. "God," she said, mostly to herself. "First-years." But she said it the way you say a thing you're fonder of than you'll admit, and she clapped her hands once and broke the moment open before it could get too large. "Right. Pembroke, off you go, this next part's just for the kidnapped. Viridia, with me. Time to go and ring the dinner bell for the whole forest and see what comes."

CHAPTER FIVE

Amber's Story

Amber did not take her to the forest first. She took her into an empty classroom and shut the door.

It was a teaching room that nobody had taught in for a while: chairs upturned on tables, a smell of chalk and disuse, a long board still ghosted with the half-erased diagram of something that might have been a spell or might have been a plumbing repair. Amber checked the corridor before she closed the door. Viridia noticed. She pulled two chairs down off a table, which Viridia noticed too, sat in one, gestured at the other, and for a moment said nothing at all, which Viridia noticed most of all.

"You asked me why," Amber said finally. "Out there. Why I'd spend it on you." She turned a chip of nail polish over with her thumbnail. "I gave you three answers and none of them were the one. You knew that."

"I knew that."

"Yeah." Amber breathed out. "You're going to be a great deal of trouble, you know. People who notice things always are." She was quiet a moment longer. Then she reached into her collar and drew out a second necklace, one Viridia had not seen. It had been hidden under her shirt, under the pale stone everyone could see. She held it out into the dim light.

It was a small dark orb on a chain, and carved into it, fine and close, were symbols. Viridia did not need to ask. She had

carried the same symbols at her own throat for three days, traced them in the dark, watched them hold their faint light in plain sun. They were not quite the same. The arrangement was different, the way two pages in the same hand are different. But they were the same kind of thing. The same language. The same maker, or the same school of makers, across however many years.

"They're like yours," Amber said. "I clocked yours at the door the first morning. That's the truth of it. I saw your necklace and I knew, and I went and found Lady Lightwell and told her I'd sponsor the new girl before I'd so much as heard you speak." She let the orb drop back against her chest. "Which was mad. Which was impulsive, like I keep telling everyone, except this time it wasn't impulsive at all. It was the least impulsive thing I've ever done. I just dressed it up as impulsive because the truth is a longer story and I didn't know you yet."

"Tell me the longer story," Viridia said.

So Amber did.

She told it badly, which was how Viridia knew it was true. She did not tell it in order. She started in the middle, with the kitchen, and had to go back; she stopped twice and started again; she said *anyway* a great deal, the way people do when they are stepping over the parts that still have edges.

She had been eight. There had been a robbery. Four men, she thought, though she had only ever seen three, and to this day she could not say whether the fourth was real or something she'd invented to make the geometry of it work. Her father had been hurt at the shoe factory a few months before; he'd lost a leg below the knee and was in bed most days, learning to be a different kind of man than he'd been. Her mother had been in the kitchen making dinner. Amber had been upstairs.

"I heard it," she said. "I heard them come in and I heard my mum, and she didn't even shout. That's the thing nobody tells you. She didn't shout. There was just a sound, and then there wasn't her anymore making any sound." She was looking at the ghosted board, not at Viridia. "They hit her. With something. To make her be quiet, I think, except she was already quiet, she was the quietest person, she..." *Anyway.* "And my dad heard the noise and he got himself down the stairs somehow, on the one leg, all the way down, and he..."

She stopped.

"He found her on the floor," Amber said, more steadily, the way you say a thing you have said to yourself ten thousand times until it wore smooth. "And he went for them with his bare hands. A one-legged man who couldn't stand without the wall. He nearly killed two of them. They had a knife in the end. They cut him and they ran and he just sat down next to her, on the floor, and he held her hand, and he bled, and there was nobody to come, and by the time anybody came." She spread her hands. There was nothing in them. "I was upstairs. The whole time. I was under my bed with my hands over my ears and I came down after it went quiet and they were both on the kitchen floor and the dinner was still cooking. The pot was still on. I remember the pot was still on."

Viridia did not say anything. She had learned, in three days and a lifetime, that there was nothing to say to this, that the things people said were for the comfort of the people saying them. She just stayed where she was, near, the way Alice had stayed near, and let Amber get to the end of it.

"So I did what any kid does," Amber said. "I tried to fix it. I knelt down between them and I reached for everything I had, all of it, every scrap, and I tried to make them be alive again." She smiled, and it was a terrible smile, fond and

ruined at once. "Light mages aren't supposed to be able to touch death. It's not a light thing. But I didn't know that. I was eight. So I just *pushed*, with everything, until something tore."

"Your core," Viridia said quietly.

"My core." Amber tapped the pale stone at her throat, the one everyone could see. "Shattered it. Blew it apart from the inside reaching for something a light mage has no business reaching for. And it worked." She said it flatly, the most terrible part said most flatly. "For about a minute. They opened their eyes. Both of them. And I got to say goodbye. I got to tell them, got to say it, the thing you'd want to say, and they heard it, I know they heard it, and then they were gone again and so was most of me." She shrugged, and the shrug cost her. "Worth it. I'd do it again. People ask me. Well, nobody asks me, because nobody knows. But if they did. Worth it. A minute. To say goodbye." She looked at Viridia then, directly. "Most people don't get the minute."

The room was very still. The dinner still cooking. The pot still on. Viridia held those two details the way she held the violet pressed flat in the green book, because she understood, now, that Amber had handed them to her the way you hand someone the one thing you have left of a person, carefully, and only once.

And under it, unspoken, was the other thing. Viridia thought of a kitchen she had stood in three mornings ago, scorched bread and her mother's tea, the last ordinary one. She did not say *me too*. She did not say *I know*. She did not say anything at all. But something must have shown, not on her face, she was too good for that now, but somewhere, because Amber looked at her a moment and then nodded, slowly, as if a thing had been confirmed that neither of them would ever name.

The silence after stretched out, and it was not an empty silence; it was the full kind, the kind with two people's whole histories sitting in it. Viridia became aware of small things: the chalk-dust in the slanted light, the upturned chairs, the half-erased diagram, a fly somewhere bumping the window over and over with the dull patience of a thing that cannot learn. She let herself look at the fly rather than at Amber, to give Amber a moment to put her face back together, because she understood by now that the kindness was sometimes in not watching.

When she did look back, Amber was watching *her*, with an expression Viridia couldn't quite read: careful, and a little raw, and waiting.

"Yeah," Amber said softly. "I thought so. The look you've got." She stood, briskly, putting the lounge back on like a coat. "Anyway. That's the longer story. The necklace." She touched the dark orb through her shirt. "It's what lets me have a life with a shattered core. I can't make my own light anymore, so I borrow it from this. Lady Lightwell gave it to me. *How* she did it isn't mine to tell. You want that, you ask her, and good luck. But she did it, and at some cost to herself, and that's why I'll do near enough anything she asks and never count it." She offered Viridia a hand up. "And it's why, when I saw a girl walk in with a stone like mine round her neck and the look of someone drowning, I didn't stop to think. Some things you don't get to think about. You just go."

Viridia took the hand and stood. "Thank you," she said. It was too small. There was no word the right size.

"Don't thank me yet." The grin came back, properly this time, dragging the heaviness off the room behind it. "You haven't seen what's about to come out of that forest when you call it." She opened the door and checked the corridor and tipped her head. "Come on, drowning girl. Let's go and get you something to hold on to."

* * *

The forest began where the lawns gave up.

There was a classroom on the ground floor, the one with a great tree carved into its door, that had, improbably, a second door leading straight outside, onto the grass, with the dark line of the trees beyond. Amber explained it in passing: the creatures teacher kept it so she could march a class out to the things they were studying rather than dragging the things indoors. They cut across the edge of the lesson, past seven second-years and a tired-looking woman who gave Amber a look that promised consequences, and out the side door into the open afternoon, and walked toward the trees.

The forest was not like the school. The school was made; the forest was simply old. The light changed under the first branches, going green and underwater, and the noise of the place changed too, the bright thin chatter of the lawns dropping away, replaced by something deeper and busier, a constant low industry of wind and wing and small unseen movement, and under all of it a watchfulness, as though the wood had turned, without hurry, to see who had come in.

The ground softened underfoot, all leaf-mould and the give of a thousand years of fallen things. The smell came up rich and dark, wet earth and rot and green growing over the rot, the whole patient cycle of a forest breathing in the gloom. Somewhere far off water moved. Somewhere nearer something with wings resettled itself with a sound like a sigh. Viridia found, to her surprise, that she was not afraid of it. After the gilded careful corridors of the school, where everything was assessed and everyone was ranked and a stone at your throat could change a stranger's whole face, there was something almost restful in a place that did not care who she was at all. The forest would have looked at the

Headmistress and the gift-less and the High Chancellor himself with exactly the same green indifference. It was the first thing she had met in three days that wanted nothing from her.

"Keep close," Amber said, low, and something in the way she said it took the restfulness back down a notch. "It's restful right up until it isn't. People who forget that come back missing a hand, if they come back."

"Right." Amber stopped where the trees thickened and handed Viridia a black metal bracelet. On her own left wrist, Viridia saw now, was a blue one. "Crash course. How many creatures a person can bond depends on two things: how much magic you've got, and how hungry the creature is for it. A little mana toad costs almost nothing and gives you a little back. Something bigger costs more. With me so far?"

"What happens if you call something too big for you," Viridia said. She was already thinking it through, the arithmetic of it.

Amber's face went serious. "Then it can kill you. The good ones won't let it get that far. Most creatures can feel whether you've got the magic to hold them, and a decent one won't bond a person it'd burn out. But the bond runs both ways. If your creature dies, you lose whatever the bond cost you, until you heal. And the other way round." She let that sit. "That's why most people never do it. For some, the gain's worth the risk." She clapped her hands, dispelling the gravity. "We'll start gentle. Watch me first."

They came to a small clearing with a worn stone bench at its center. Amber set Viridia on it, then drew from her pocket a little glass figure of a bear, no bigger than a thumb. She closed her fist around it and shut her eyes, and Viridia, with the new unnamed sense she was only beginning to trust, the draught-from-an-open-door sense, felt Amber reach, not into the dark orb hidden against her chest, but

into the pale stone everyone could see, drawing light from the thing that lent it to her. She fed the light into the glass bear, and then pushed it outward, into the trees, in three slow pulses. Then she came and sat down.

"There. I called. Now we wait and see if anyone's listening." She stretched her legs out. "What I did: tapped my necklace, never could do this with my dark side, not since. Fed the magic into the focus, sent it out carrying what I want. *Companion. Bond.* If something out there fancies it, it'll follow the pulses home."

They waited. The wood breathed around them. And then, off to the right, a snuffling, and out of the undergrowth came a boar, broad and bristled, with a row of metal quills standing up along its lower back and two great tusks that looked, impossibly, to have been capped in iron. It rooted its way toward them, unhurried, and came to a stop in front of Amber.

She went down on one knee in front of it, easy, unafraid. "Would you have me?" she asked it, looking into its small dark eye. The boar considered her. Then it leaned its snout into her open palm, and at the touch it came apart, dissolved into a swarm of tiny lights that drew together and settled, with a small bright finality, into a white charm now hanging on Amber's bracelet.

"And that," Amber said, getting up and brushing off her knee, grinning at Viridia's face, "is that. I'll let him rest a bit before I call him back; rude to do it straight off. Don't be disheartened if nothing comes for you, by the way. Some people call for weeks before they find their match." She gestured Viridia up off the bench. "Your turn. And listen. Small. I mean it. Send out the *littlest* call you can manage, the way I showed you, three soft pulses and no more. Reach for a mana toad, a finch, something that costs nothing. You don't know your own bottom yet, and the only way to learn it is

from above it, not below. Big calls bring big things, and a big thing will bond a girl who can't hold it and burn her hollow doing it. Start small. Every word of that is a rule. Promise me."

"I promise," Viridia said, and at the time she even meant it.

* * *

Viridia stood in the green light with her cane in both hands and no idea at all of how to begin, which she had a feeling was going to be the way of most important things.

Broadcast your intent. And your need. What did she need. This was no school exercise. It felt like the realest question anyone had asked her since the morning the world ended, and she allowed herself, just this once, to look straight at the answer instead of folding it away.

She needed not to be alone.

That was the whole of it, underneath everything: under the grief she carried behind her ribs, under the careful face, under the inheritance she kept beneath the bed. She had let exactly two people near her in three days and she was already terrified of losing them. She needed something that would not be taken. Something that would stay.

Small, Amber had said. Reach for a finch. A mana toad would not stay. A finch would not stay. A small safe creature called with three soft pulses would be a small safe thing she might lose the way she had lost everything, and she had had enough, in three days and a lifetime, of small safe things that left. She understood exactly what Amber had told her, and why: the arithmetic of it, that a call too big for her could kill her. Amber had said it twice, plainly, and the boar had only just shown her what a measured call looked like. She understood all of it. And she decided, standing in the green light with her dead mother's cane in both hands, that she

would rather risk the bottom dropping out of her than make a careful little call and bond some careful little thing that might not stay either.

She did not think about light or dark, or about hiding. She thought about the need, the whole unfenced size of it, and she opened herself all the way down past where she had ever opened before, and she reached with all of it.

She felt the magic move and she did not stop it. It came up out of her core the way grief did, sudden and unbidden, and poured down her arms into the cane, and the half-orb at its top kindled. But not white. Not only white. The light that welled up inside it was white *and* black at once, a brilliant clean light and a deep velvet dark twined together in the same small space, neither swallowing the other, both somehow shining, a thing that should not have been possible and was sitting in her hands being possible anyway.

On the bench, Amber went still.

Viridia did not see it; she was looking at the orb, at the two lights braided in it, and feeling, not fear, which was the strange part, but the opposite of fear. *Recognition*. As though she had been carrying something folded in half her whole life and had just, for the first time, let it open. Light and dark, two halves of a whole. *It's all about how you perceive it*, her mother had written, and here it was in her own hands, perceived, and something deep in her chest shifted and aligned and clicked home like a key she hadn't known she was turning, and for one impossible moment Viridia Saeren felt, of all things, *complete*.

The clearing had gone strange around her. With the orb burning white-and-black in her hands she could see, suddenly, that the wood was not the green-dim quiet place it had seemed. It was alive with light, faint threads of it everywhere, in the trees, in the moss, in the small hidden moving things, a whole web of soft glow she had been

walking through blind. Until now it had hidden from her completely. She did not understand what she was seeing and did not stop to. She had no attention to spare. Every scrap of her was pouring down her arms and out through the cane, and the more she gave the lighter she felt, not weaker but *clearer*, as though she had been carrying a second body all her life and had only now set it down.

"I need a companion who will stay," she sent out into the wood, in one long pulse, no longer holding anything back. "Someone who won't falter. Someone who'll be at my side until the end."

She lifted the cane high and gave a cry, wordless, primal, scraped up from somewhere below thought, and the light left the orb in a rush that emptied her. Her legs went. She sat down hard on the clearing floor with her ears ringing and the world gone white at the edges, and a thin line of blood started from her nose and ran warm to her lip before she even felt it. She wiped it with the back of her hand and stared at the red smear, stupid with drain. Too much. She had given far past the bottom of herself, exactly as Amber had warned her she might, except that there had been no *might* about it; she had aimed past the bottom on purpose, and here it was, the price, running warm off her chin. And the call had gone out with all of it behind it, far past the clearing, far past where Amber's three neat pulses had reached, rolling out into parts of the wood that had no names, because she had flung the door open as wide as it would go instead of cracking it the careful inch Amber had shown her. She was in no state to wonder what, that far out, might have lifted its head to listen. She had not summoned, she would understand later. She had refused the safe call and thrown the door open wide enough that something large heard.

On the bench, Amber started up to help her, and froze.

A roar came out of the trees to the right. Not the snuffle of the boar. A roar that Viridia felt in the stone bench, in the ground under her, in her teeth.

And then it stepped into the clearing, and it was magnificent.

A tiger. But no tiger had ever worn fur like this, a deep changing mix of sky-blue and forest-green that seemed to hold the colors of the wood itself. Bone-white horns curved back from its head, fine blue veins threading through them like lightning trapped in ivory. Two long fangs, saber-curved. Paws the size of dinner plates, each one capable, plainly, of ending her. It was seven feet from nose to tail and it was looking directly at her with eyes the color of a storm, eyes that had actual small forks of lightning moving in the irises, and it was the most frightening and the most beautiful thing she had ever seen.

"Don't move," Amber breathed.

But Viridia already knew, the way she had known which true thing to say to Alice, the way she had known the orb would open if she let it. She knew, on the level beneath knowing, that this creature meant her no harm. It had come because she had called. It had heard a girl in a clearing say *stay*, and it had come.

She put up a hand to keep Amber where she was. And then, on legs that barely held her, swaying with the drain of it, she got up, and crossed the clearing, and knelt down in front of the thing that could have killed her with one swipe.

It came toward her slowly, and the clearing seemed to make room for it. There was nothing of the animal's wariness in the way it moved, none of the boar's snuffling caution; it walked the way old things walk, things that have outlived their own fear, unhurried and certain, placing each enormous paw without a sound. Up close it was larger than it had any right to be, and warmer. She could feel the heat

coming off it, and a faint charge in the air around it, the same prickle as the moment before lightning, so that the small hairs on her arms stood up. It smelled of rain and crushed pine and something underneath that, older, that she would later learn to call simply *Lor-ar*. For three hundred years this thing had walked a forest no human had mapped, and it had heard a fourteen-year-old girl in a clearing ask, with everything she had, only and exactly to not be alone, and it had come.

It lowered its great head to look at her, level, eye to lightning eye.

You did not call so much as throw yourself open, little one. The voice was in her mind, deep and dry and unhurried, the voice of something very old and faintly amused. A wiser girl would have whispered. You shouted with everything you had, past every limit set for you, and a thing my size does not answer a whisper. So. You wanted a companion who would stay, and you were willing to spend your life to ask for it. I have lived three hundred years among small careful calls. Yours was neither. I will be your protector, for now. My name is Lor-ar, of the pride of the sky. The eyes held hers. Will you accept this bond?

Viridia, who had asked the wood for something that would stay, reached out one shaking hand and laid it on the broad warm forehead of a creature out of legend.

"Yes," she said.

The drain hit her again, sharper this time, the bond drawing its toll, and she gasped and nearly pitched forward, caught herself, palm still pressed to his brow, and looked up, expecting him to dissolve into a charm the way the boar had, into a tidy white light on her bracelet.

He did not dissolve.

He stayed exactly where he was, enormous and real and warm under her hand, regarding her from two inches away

with eyes that danced now with open amusement at the look on her face.

* * *

It took Amber a full minute to get her voice back.

"That," she said, rising slowly from the bench, "is a horned sylvan tiger. Those are extinct. Everyone says those are extinct."

Lor-ar turned his head to her, unhurried. *You have also bonded a creature of the forest*, he told her, speaking into both their minds at once. *Treat him well, or send him home. Those are the only two honest things to do with a bond.*

"I will," Amber said faintly. "May I have your name?"

You may. It is Lor-ar. He turned back to Viridia and put his great nose, briefly, against her cheek, a gesture so absurdly like a house cat that she laughed, a short startled sound, the first real one in three days, gone almost before it arrived.

"Lor-ar," Amber tried, getting hold of herself, falling back on the practical the way she did when a thing was too large. "I don't honestly know how the Headmistress is going to take a full-grown sylvan tiger walking into her school. You might have to go in the bracelet while we're indoors..."

One white-and-blue eyebrow rose.

And how, Lor-ar inquired, *am I to protect the little one from inside a trinket?*

Amber tried, gamely, to explain that there was no danger to protect against inside the Academy, that it was a school, that nothing would happen to her there. Lor-ar listened to all of it with the patience of something three centuries deep, and was entirely unmoved, and when Amber finally ran out of arguments he let a pause go by just long enough to make his point.

Enough, he said. *I will not go in the trinket. But I will compromise.*

And he shrank.

There was no other word for it. He simply diminished, fur and horns and saber-fangs and all, folding down and down until what sat licking a paw in the clearing was a tiger the size of a large house cat, still horned, still storm-eyed, still patently capable of opinions, but small enough now to be carried, or at the very least argued with at eye level.

"I didn't know you could do that," Amber said weakly. Then the weakness went out of her, and something harder came up under it, and she crossed the clearing and took Viridia by the shoulders, none too gently, and looked into her face. "You did that on purpose," she said. It was not a question. Her voice had gone low and shaking. "I told you small. I made you *promise* small. Three pulses, a toad, I said it twice — and you stood there and opened yourself up like a slit throat. I felt it from the bench. I felt the bottom go out of you." She gave Viridia one small rough shake, fear wearing the coat of anger the way it does. "You could have died right there in the leaves and I'd have had to carry what was left of you back and tell Lightwell I let a girl burn herself hollow on her first afternoon in the forest. Don't you *ever* — " She stopped. She made herself stop, and let go, and stood breathing, and what came out next was quieter, and worse. "What is it in you that would rather die asking than live with a small answer? No. Don't tell me. I think I already know, and I don't like that I know it."

Viridia did not have an answer that would make it better, so she gave the true one. "I'm sorry I frightened you." She did not say *I'd do it again*, though it was sitting right there, because she did not think Amber could bear to hear it, and because she was not entirely sure it was the kind of thing you ought to say out loud.

You were not meant to know, Lor-ar said to Amber, of the shrinking, and chuffed, a sound that was unmistakably

laughter, and stood, and gave himself a shake. Then his storm-eyes found the dried blood under her nose, and the amusement went out of them. *Your sponsor is right to be afraid,* he said, quieter. *You poured yourself out like a jug with no bottom, and you did it knowing. Someone will have to teach you where the bottom is, little one, and soon.* He turned his great head, slow, toward the deeper trees, where the green light failed into true dark, and held it there a moment, scenting. *And understand this, since you chose to learn it the hard way. A call that size does not stop at the edge of a clearing. It went out past me, past the named parts of the wood, and out there something heard it and did not come — which is worse than if it had. You have announced yourself, the once, to a hungry thing in the dark, and a thing like that does not forget the taste of a door thrown open. That is the tail your defiance has on it. You will carry it whether you meant to or not.* He let the silence sit a breath too long. *Up. You need to sleep before you fall down. I have decided I will permit it.*

Viridia got to her feet, swaying, and Amber got an arm under her, and the three of them started back out of the green underwater light toward the lawns and the grey stone school. And the whole way, Lor-ar, three hundred years old, extinct, a spirit walker by some title Viridia did not yet understand, possessed of magic that had made a teacher sweat just to wake its cousin, ran ahead of them through the long grass and then came tearing back, and ran ahead again, and circled, and pounced at nothing, exactly like an overgrown kitten let out for the first time, and Viridia watched him do it through the fog of her exhaustion and felt, rising up through the drain and the grief and the careful held weight of everything, something warm and entirely unguarded that she had not felt in so long she had half forgotten its name.

It was not grief. That was the remarkable thing about it.

CHAPTER SIX

Lady Lightwell's Concern

They came out of the trees onto the lawns with the light going long and gold, and Lady Lightwell was already standing on the front steps, watching them come.

She had not been there when they went in. Viridia was certain of that. Someone had told her, then, or she had simply known. And there was something in the way she stood, very straight, hands folded, that made Viridia's stomach drop the way it had dropped at the gate three days ago, the specific lurch you feel when you have done a large thing without permission and are about to be asked to account for it.

Lor-ar, trotting at her heel in his house-cat size, did not so much as break stride.

"Miss Saeren." Lady Lightwell came down a step. The rose-tinted lenses moved from Viridia, gray-faced and swaying, to the small horned tiger beside her, and Viridia watched her take it in, watched the composure hold over the top of something that was, underneath, very close to alarm. "Would you care to explain to me why I have spent the last hour fielding reports of unusual magical activity from the forest. And why you appear to have brought some of it home with you."

Viridia opened her mouth. Nothing useful came.

There is magic at work here that the little one is not permitted to discuss, Lor-ar said, stepping forward, and Viridia felt Lady Lightwell go still as the voice arrived uninvited in her head. *Do not punish her for the consequences of something she did not know to fear. She called. I answered. That is the whole of what concerns this school.*

Lady Lightwell looked down at him for a long moment. Something moved behind the lenses that Viridia could not read.

"I was given to understand," she said at last, slowly, "that the horned sylvan tigers were extinct."

Lor-ar showed his teeth. It was not a smile. *They have tried, many times, to make us so. It has not taken.*

The Headmistress absorbed that. For a moment she said nothing, and in the saying of nothing Viridia, even half-dead on her feet, caught something, a flicker, quickly gone, that was not alarm at the tiger at all, but almost its opposite: the look of a person handed a piece of a puzzle she did not know she was assembling, who has just understood that the picture is larger and more dangerous than she'd feared. The lenses came back to Viridia, and rested on her, and then, Viridia was sure of it, tired as she was, dropped for half a heartbeat to where the dark-blue stone hung against her collarbone, the way they had in the office, the way Amber's eyes had at the door. As though everyone who mattered in this place kept checking that the stone was still there, and what it meant.

"A girl of fourteen," Lady Lightwell said quietly, mostly to herself, "summons an extinct creature from a forest that swallows fourth-years whole, and walks out of it gray but unharmed." She drew a breath. "Three days. You have been here three days." Whatever she thought of it, she folded it away as neatly as Viridia folded things away, and when she spoke again it was clipped and practical, a woman dealing

with what was in front of her. "I see." Her gaze came back to Viridia, and softened, fractionally, around the edges, taking in, perhaps, how badly the girl was swaying on her feet. "You have drained yourself half to nothing. Go to bed. You're excused all classes tomorrow." A pause, exact. "And I expect to see you in my office, first thing in the morning. We are going to have a conversation, you and I. It is overdue." She turned to go, then added, almost to herself, "I'll tell the kitchens you'll be feeding two now."

It was not phrased as a threat. That was the trouble. Viridia climbed the steps past her on legs that barely held, and could not for the life of her decide whether she had just been forgiven, or warned, or simply filed: assessed, and ranked, and entered into some account she could not see the rest of. *I expect to see you*. Said one way it was a teacher being kind to a tired girl. Said another way it meant *I am keeping a closer eye on you now, and we both know why*. She had asked for this, she thought, dimly, on the stairs. She had stood in that office and asked to be seen, and she was being seen, and there was no taking it back.

She paused, three steps up, and looked back. The Headmistress had not moved. "Lady Lightwell," she said, before she could decide not to. "Am I in trouble?"

For a moment she thought she wouldn't answer. Then Lady Lightwell turned her head, and the gold light caught the rose lenses so that for an instant Viridia could not see the eyes behind them at all, only two small fires where they should be.

"No," she said. "Not trouble. Trouble would be simpler." And she turned back to the forest, which was the whole of the answer, and somehow worse than any answer, because Viridia stood there with it and could not tell, could not for the life of her tell, whether the woman on the steps meant to protect her or to watch her, and was left with the cold

suspicion that the honest answer was *both*, and that Lady Lightwell had not yet decided in what proportion.

She was too tired to work it out. She climbed, and Lor-ar climbed with her, and behind them Lady Lightwell stood on the steps a while longer, watching the dark line of the forest, and did not come in.

* * *

The west wing was empty; the other girls were still in their afternoon classes, and Viridia met no one on the stairs, which was a mercy she had not known to ask for. She let herself into room fourteen and got as far as the edge of her own bed before the day caught up with her all at once.

She had not understood, until she stopped moving, how much the bond had cost. Ordinary tiredness was a weight you carried. This was a hollowness, which was worse, because there was nothing in it to set down. She had handed over a portion of herself in the clearing and the place where it had been was still raw, an ache with no location. Her hands felt far away. The edges of things had a faint smear to them, the way the world smears when you have wept too long, except she had not wept; she had only reached down into herself and given away more than she'd known she had.

She thought, dimly, that this must be a fraction of what Amber had felt, that night on the kitchen floor between her dead parents, reaching for something a light mage had no business reaching for, *pushing until something tore*. Amber had shattered her core doing what Viridia had done a smaller version of in a sunlit clearing with a teacher's daughter watching and no danger at all. The thought sobered her even through the fog. She had been lucky. She was beginning to suspect she had been lucky in a great many ways she did not yet understand, and that luck was not the same as safety.

She sat down heavily on the edge of the bed. The room tilted, gently, and righted itself. The blanket under her palm was the rough school wool she was already growing used to, smelling faintly of cedar and the lavender they packed the linen in, and somewhere below the window a bell rang the hour and a door banged and a girl laughed at something, the ordinary noise of a building that had no idea what had happened in the forest and went on being a school regardless. She held on to the small sounds. They were easier than the silence in her chest.

Lor-ar leapt up onto the bed before her and turned a circle on the blanket, the way cats do, and settled himself against the wall, and looked at her.

Come, little one. He patted the blanket once with a great soft paw. *Sleep, and let it come back. I will keep watch.*

She managed one question first, around the edge of sleep. "Lor-ar. The orb. When I called you, it went white and black. Both. At the same time." She had to push the words out through the heaviness. "Amber looked at it and went strange. Is that, is it not supposed to do that?"

Lor-ar regarded her with his half-lidded storm eyes.

No, he said. For your people, it is not supposed to do that. A pause, weighted in a way she was too tired to fully feel. Sleep, little one. We will speak of what you are when you can keep your eyes open to hear it. It is not a small conversation, and you have earned a small one.

What you are. Not *what you did.* She caught the difference even through the fog, the way she caught all the differences, and filed it, and then sleep took the question out of her hands and she let it.

She did not have it in her to argue further, and did not want to. She crawled in beside him, under the round window with the gold light fading out of it, and curled against the warm bulk of him. He ran warm, warmer than any animal

had a right to, and there was that faint charge in the air around him still, the prickle of a coming storm held just at bay, and she put one hand into the impossible blue-green fur and felt the slow furnace of his breathing, and the grief and the drain and the careful held weight of three days all loosened their grip at once, and she was asleep before she had decided to be.

She did not dream, or if she did the dreams went where the others went now, down into the place she could not follow them. She slept the deep blank sleep of the truly spent. The school went on without her; the light left the window. Somewhere a tray of food was brought up, set on the nightstand, and went cold. Through all of it the small horned tiger lay against the wall with his storm eyes half-open, watching the door, exactly as he had said he would.

* * *

She woke to a smell of soup and a face an inch from her own.

She came up out of sleep with a start and found herself nose to nose with Lor-ar, who had apparently decided that the most efficient way to wake a person was to be the first thing she saw.

I had begun to wonder, he said, unmoving, whether you intended to sleep through to spring.

"How long was I out?" Her voice came out cracked. The window was dark; the half-moon hung in it, low. Hours, then. She pushed herself upright, and the rawness had gone, not entirely, but mostly, the spent place inside her filled back up to something workable. "Did someone bring food?"

Your friend. The round one, Alice. She came, and was very put out that you were asleep, and left you that. He nodded at the tray. *She and I had a long conversation while you snored. You*

snore, little one. I felt you would want to be told by someone who cares for you.

Viridia lifted the lid off the tray. Soup, meat and vegetables gone tepid, a chunk of bread with the butter soaked in. She found she was ravenous in a way she had not been in days, her body demanding back what the day had taken. She ate without ceremony. Around a mouthful she said, "What did you and Alice talk about?"

Many things. She is a great talker, your friend. Restful, in a way. She asks her questions and answers half of them herself and requires very little of you. There was something almost fond in it. *Chiefly, we talked about how your people are broken.*

Viridia stopped with the spoon halfway up. "Broken how?"

Your people have only one side of the gift, Lor-ar said, as though this answered everything.

"How does that make us broken?" The soup was forgotten now; she had turned fully toward him. "Everyone has one side. That's just how it is. You're light, or you're dark, or you're nothing at all. That's the whole world."

That, said Lor-ar, *is the whole of the world you were given. It is not the whole of the world.* He looked at her with something that was almost pity and almost patience and entirely ancient. *Your people were meant to hold both halves. Someone, long ago, took the other away. That is the brokenness. Not a flaw you were born with — a wound that was done to you, so long ago that you have forgotten it was ever a wound, and call the scar your nature.* He let the word sit between them, *wound*, and did not reach for it again, and would not say the rest, so that she was left holding the single terrible noun in the dark the way she held the stone at her throat: a small hard thing with edges, given to her to carry and not yet to understand.

Viridia sat unmoving in the dark with the cold soup in her lap.

"And me," she said. Quietly. Already knowing, the way she always knew the thing a half-beat before it was said. "What about me."

But Lor-ar only flicked an ear, and rose, and stretched, and would not be drawn the rest of the way (*that is the longer conversation, and your soup is already losing its argument with the cold*) and padded off to investigate the room instead, nosing under the desk and into the seam of the wardrobe door with the bottomless curiosity of a creature for whom every room is new. Viridia watched him and ate her cold soup and felt the question settle into her, *broken how*, one more thing to be turned over in the dark. She had a great many of those now. She was beginning to think this might be a school where the lessons that mattered all happened after the bell.

She had finished the bread and was deciding whether she could manage to undress before sleeping again when the door opened and Alice came in, and stopped dead, one hand still on the handle.

"Dragon," Alice said.

Then, "No. Tiger. *Why is there a...*"

I am not a pet, Lor-ar said, with great dignity, from the middle of the floor.

Alice shrieked, a short delighted terrified sound, and clapped both hands over her mouth, eyes enormous over the top of them. "It talks. It's in my *head*. Viridia, it's a talking tiger and it's in my head and it's got *horns*, are you seeing this, why are you so calm, why is there a horned talking tiger on our..."

"His name's Lor-ar," Viridia said. "He's mine. I bonded him. Today. In the forest." It still sounded mad, said aloud, in an ordinary bedroom. "I'm sorry. I should have warned you. There wasn't really a way to."

Alice took her hands slowly down from her mouth. She looked at Lor-ar. Lor-ar looked at Alice. And then, instead of

fear, instead of the dozen sensible reactions one might have on coming home to find a horned predator on the floor, Alice's whole face opened into the helpless friendly delight that Viridia was coming to understand was simply how Alice met the world.

"He's *beautiful*," she breathed. "Can I, is it allowed, can I touch him?"

You may, Lor-ar allowed, try.

Alice crept forward and laid a tentative hand on his head, between the horns, and Lor-ar suffered it with the air of a king permitting a liberty, and Alice made a small sound of pure joy. "He's so warm. Viridia, he's so warm." She sat down cross-legged on the floor in front of him, all her homesickness and self-consciousness forgotten, and looked up. "I want one. I want one so badly. How do you get one?"

You do not "get" one, Lor-ar said. He is not a pet, as I have now said twice. He is a bonded companion. There is a great difference.

"I didn't say he was a pet," Alice protested. "I said I'd *like* a pet like that."

Which is, of course, entirely different. He turned his head to Viridia, and she could have sworn he rolled his eyes. *She did the same thing earlier. I begin to see why you keep her.*

"I heard that," Alice said. "He thinks loud. Does he always think this loud?" She did not wait for an answer; she had already moved on, the way she did, scratching very gently at the base of one bone-white horn while Lor-ar pretended, with enormous dignity, not to be enjoying it. "Will the others be allowed to see him? Or is he a secret? He feels like the sort of thing that ought to be a secret." She glanced up, and for just a second the brightness in her sharpened into something shrewder, something that saw more than it let on. "You've a lot of secrets, haven't you. For somebody who's been here three days." It was not an accusation. It was almost gentle. "It's all right. I'm good at secrets. The

Dunmores trusted me with theirs and I never told a soul, not once, not even when the other kids would've thought I was brave for knowing." She went back to the horn. "Just. If you ever want to not carry a thing on your own. That's all. I'm here. I'm right across the room."

Viridia looked at her, kneeling on the floor of their shared room with her hand in the fur of an impossible creature, offering, without making any fuss about it, exactly the thing Viridia most needed and least knew how to take, and had to look away, at the dark window, and breathe once, around it, the way she did.

"I know," she said, when she could. "Thank you."

And she meant the *thank you* the way she had meant it to Amber, too large for the words, and Alice, who heard things, heard that too, and did not make her say any more.

* * *

It was Alice, when the wonder had worn down to a glow, who remembered her own news.

"Oh, oh, I forgot, with all the tiger. *I've got a sponsor.*" She said it the way she said the best things, unable to keep it in. "A fourth-year. She heard I was first-generation, and she's first-generation herself, and she came and found me and asked, just like that. I've written to my father already. He's going to be..." Her voice caught on it, on her father being proud, and she pushed past it. "She thinks I should study in the medical wing. Says it'd suit me."

Viridia listened, and watched Alice's hands as she said it, the way they kept smoothing the same fold of blanket flat and flat again, the way they had smoothed her skirt in the orientation hall, a body too full of good news to keep still under it. She was glad for Alice, genuinely, warmly glad, and underneath the gladness, so quiet she almost missed it in herself, was a thread of something more complicated. Alice

was building a life here. A sponsor of her own, a wing of her own, a path of her own that belonged not to Viridia but to who Alice was going to become. Three days ago they had been two strangers at the outside edge of the same room. Now Alice had somewhere to go in the morning, somewhere that was hers. It was exactly what Viridia had wanted for her. It was also, she registered with a small private honesty, a door opening between them, the first hairline gap of two lives that had briefly been one and would now begin, gently, to be two again. She was happy for Alice. She was. And she was, very faintly, afraid of being left, which she recognized, the moment she felt it, as the same fear that had sent her into the forest to call for something that would *stay*.

She put the thought away with the others; she had grown good at that. She let only the gladness show.

"Does it?" Viridia asked. "Suit you?"

Alice considered this with her usual gravity. "I think so. I helped look after my grandfather, at the end. My nan and I. It wasn't nice, but I wasn't squeamish about it, and I didn't mind sitting with him, even the hard bits. Magic can't heal everything, you know. Somebody still has to sit with the parts it can't." She said it simply, and Viridia thought, not for the first time, that Alice was a great deal less ordinary than Alice believed herself to be. "So. Maybe. I'd like to be useful. I'd like to be the sort of person they're glad came."

"You already are," Viridia said.

Alice went pink and threw a sock at her, and the moment lifted, the way Alice always lifted things before they could get too heavy. She got ready for bed, chattering about her sponsor, about the medical wing, about whether Lor-ar ate ordinary food or something more alarming, and was asleep, in the end, mid-sentence, the way she always was, dropping off the edge of the day and trusting it to catch her.

Viridia lay awake.

She lay awake on purpose, which was new. For three nights she had lain awake because the grief would not let her go; tonight the grief was there, it was always there, but it was not the thing keeping her up. She was keeping herself up. She wanted, for once, to be alone with the inside of her own head, and the dark room with two sleeping breathers in it, Alice's soft and even, Lor-ar's a slow deep furnace-rumble at the foot of the bed, was the safest she had felt since the kitchen.

She let herself, finally, take the things out and look at them.

A focus that had been thirsty for centuries, made for someone with both sides of the gift, handed down a tree of names a thousand years deep. A note in a stranger's hand that knew where she would be. A teacher who had risked herself to tell her a truth the world would punish her for. A girl with a shattered core who had spent her one favor on her at the door. An orb that had burned white and black at once and made her feel, for one impossible breath, *complete*. A creature out of legend asleep on her bed because she had asked the forest, with everything she had, only not to be alone. And somewhere out there in the dark a Headmistress with blue shoes and a watchful kindness who wanted to see her in the morning, and would not say whether it was to help her or to keep an eye on her, and quite possibly did not know herself.

Broken how, Lor-ar had said, of her people. Not of her. *Your people are much diminished*. He had said it as though she were the exception. As though she were the whole thing and the rest of the world were the broken thing, which was so completely backwards from everything she had been told her whole life that it would not fit in her hands at all, except that some quiet part of her, the part that noticed the one

detail that did not fit, had caught on it and held, the way you hold when a stranger says your true name.

She did not know what she was. That was the plain fact at the bottom of it. Three days ago she had been a grieving girl being delivered to a school, and now she was something the school had categories for and did not, she suspected, want. *Be careful who you let see you do it.* She understood the warning differently now. Her mother had not been talking about quiet, or watching, or grief. Her mother had been talking about *this*, the thing in the orb, the thing in her, the thing the world killed people for. Her mother had known, and buried the knowing inside everyday advice, and left it for her to find too late.

But under the fear was the other thing again, the warm thing, the first heat felt in a long-cold room. If she was somehow the whole one, then the void her parents' deaths had opened was not the only thing she was made of. There was this, too: something in her enormous and unfinished and entirely her own. She held both at once, the grief stowed small behind her ribs and the strange new life assembling itself around her, and did not choose between them. You did not get to choose. You carried the loss and the becoming in the same two hands.

The half-moon moved a little in the round window. Lor-ar's breathing rose and fell. And Viridia Saeren, fourteen years old, who had come through the gate three days ago with nothing she could name, lay awake between the dark she had been given and the dark she was walking into. Somewhere past the glass, far out beyond the trimmed hedges, the night did not feel empty the way nights used to. It felt occupied, faintly, at the edge of her new sense, by something turned her way. She had no word for it yet. She would learn one soon enough, and wish she had not.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What Lor-ar Knows

She woke to a face.

Not a hand on her shoulder, not the chime, not the gray light coming through the round window. A face, a hand's width from her own, two storm-lit eyes open and patient and far too close, and the warm gust of breath that smelled, faintly, of last night's soup.

Viridia did not startle. Three days had taught her better. She only lay there and looked back at him, and let her heart settle out of the small jolt it had given, and thought that this was, in fact, the most ordinary thing that had happened to her since she came through the gate. A girl waking with a tiger an inch from her nose. There was something restful in how completely unremarkable it had already become.

You sleep like the dead, Lor-ar observed, not moving. *I have watched lesser creatures hibernate with more conviction, but only just.*

"Good morning to you too."

Is it? I had not formed an opinion. I leave the weather to those who must walk in it. He rose then, in the unhurried way of a creature who has never once been late for anything, and turned a slow circle on the blanket, and resettled with his chin on her ankle as though it had been put there for the purpose. *Your friend left a tray. The soup has gone cold a second*

time. You have a gift for letting soup die, little one. It is a small tragedy I have now watched twice.

She sat up. The room was empty but for the two of them; Alice's bed was made, the green book gone from the nightstand, which meant the medical wing, which meant Alice had a place to be in the mornings now and Viridia did not, today, by order of the Headmistress. The thought of the office sat under everything, *first thing in the morning*, but the light through the window was thin and early, and she judged she had an hour, perhaps more, before she had to put on the face she wore for Lady Lightwell and go and be looked at.

So she ate the cold soup, because it was there and she was hungry, and because Lor-ar was watching her with the bright expectant air of someone who has been waiting all night to say something and is now deciding how to begin.

"You said we'd talk," she said, around the bread. "When I could keep my eyes open. About what I am."

I said it was not a small conversation.

"My eyes are open."

He considered her. The light caught the blue veining in his horns and ran along it, and for a moment he seemed older than the room, older than the school, a thing that had wandered in from a much larger story and was tolerating the smallness of this one out of courtesy.

Very well, he said. Then I will begin where I began with your friend, last night, while you snored. I will tell you that your kind are broken. And before you bristle. He flicked an ear. You will let me finish, because you bristled last night too, half-asleep, and it was not your best work.

"I didn't bristle."

You said broken how in the tone a cat uses for a closed door. Eat your bread.

She ate her bread.

* * *

It came out of him slowly, in the way she was learning he gave the things that mattered, not as a lecture but as a man turning a stone over in his hands and naming what he found on each face of it. He had had, he said, three hundred years to learn patience, and he spent it freely, and the spending of it was itself a kind of argument: that this was old, that it would keep, that there was no need to swallow it all at once.

"One side each," she said, when he had laid the bones of it out. "Light, dark, or none at all. That isn't a wound. That's just the shape of us."

It is the shape of the ones you have met. It is not the shape of a person. He shifted his chin off her ankle and sat up, the better to look at her. *A coin cannot be minted with a single face. A flame cannot burn and cast no shadow. Every creature past a certain size is built of the giving and the taking both, and the grander the creature, the truer that runs. Small things may carry only the one, a mana toad, a finch. No harm in it; nothing was stolen from them. They were finished that way, and a pebble is finished too.* His gaze did not leave her. *Your kind were not finished that way. Your kind were meant to hold the two of them at once. And then, longer ago than your wars remember, hands reached in and pared the second half off, household by household, bloodline by bloodline, until the babies stopped arriving with it, and then stopped recalling they had ever owned it, and learned to name the scar a birthright.*

Viridia set the spoon down.

She wanted to argue. She could feel the shape of the argument in her, all the clean familiar furniture of the world she had grown up inside, *light mages and dark mages, the wars, the way it had always been*, and she reached for it the way you reach for the side of a pool when the floor drops out from under you, and found that her hand closed on nothing. Because she had felt it. In the clearing, with the focus alight

in two colors at the same instant, she had felt the floor of herself come back up to meet her, had felt the word that he was now putting to it: *whole*. She had not had a name for it then. She had only known that something she had not known was missing had, for one breath, stopped being missing.

"That's a very large thing to say," she said, "about everyone I've ever met."

It is. He did not soften it. I find your people fascinating and exhausting in roughly equal measure, and this is chiefly why. You have been hollowed and told it was always so, and you build whole lives in the hollow, and call the building a nation, and go to war over which of you may keep the smaller half. A pause. I do not say it to be cruel. A thing can be broken and beloved. I am very fond of a three-legged thing I knew once. But I will not call a missing leg a fourth kind of walking, and I will not call your wound your nature, because you, of all of them, deserve to be told the truth about the shape of yourself.

You, of all of them. She caught it, the way she caught the one detail in a room that did not belong, and set it aside, and did not yet let herself look directly at it.

"How can you possibly know," she said instead. "About thousands of years ago. You said yourself you're only three hundred."

Am I to take it that a creature cannot know what came before it was born? Then you know nothing, little one, having been alive a scant fourteen years, and we may stop talking and you may go back to your soup. The whiskers moved; it was as close to a grin as he came. *I am a spirit walker. It is what the -ar means, on the end of my name. Lor is what I was called. -ar is what I became. There are a handful of us in a generation, and we are permitted to walk down into the place where the past keeps itself, and to look. I have looked. I am not guessing.*

She turned that over. A creature who could walk into the past. A thousand years of ancestors folded into her mother's book. A rod that had gone parched and waiting since before any of this was a country. The pieces did not yet make a picture, but they had begun, faintly, to face the same direction, and she did not like the picture they were facing.

"And me," she said. Quietly. The same question she had asked in the dark last night, only this time he could not duck out the door, because he had promised, and because her eyes were open. "What about me."

* * *

For answer, he rose off the blanket and laid his broad brow against her breastbone, the bone-white horns sliding past her cheeks, and held it there.

Look at me, he said, his voice arriving inside her skull and nowhere else. *Not with your eyes. With your magic. Reach into the place the cane drinks from, and bring up both halves of it, the light and the dark together, the way you did in the clearing, and lay them over your eyes like a film of water. Both halves. It does not work with one.*

"I don't know how."

You do. You did it once already, when you called me. Your hands have not forgotten it. Stop asking your head.

She closed her eyes. She found, under her ribs, the thing she still flinched from, the place that had been so raw last night and was now only sore, and she did not push it the way she had pushed in the clearing. She only drew, gently, from both sides at once, and felt them rise together the way two streams meet and make a wider water. Then too fast, the draw running away from her like a tap wrenched full open. The water pitcher on the desk cracked clean across with a sound like a knuckle popping; the cold tray rattled; a hairline of frost ran up the inside of the window and was

gone. She gasped and pulled back, and Lor-ar's paw came down firm on her wrist.

Less, he said. *You are not bailing a sinking boat. You are dipping a cup.*

She breathed. She tried again, smaller this time, and carried the two halves up behind her eyes the way you carry a full glass across a room, and held them there, and Lor-ar said *now*, and she opened her eyes.

The room had caught fire. Not with heat. With light.

She made a small involuntary sound. Everything that had been ordinary, the desk, the wardrobe, the cold tray, sat dim and unchanged, ordinary objects in ordinary morning. But Lor-ar, an inch from her face, blazed. He was lit from the inside out, every line of him laced with moving energy, the way a window is laced with frost except that this moved, ran, breathed; and at the center of him, where his chest pressed against hers, a core turned slowly on itself, the two colors plaited into one wheeling thing, and she understood without being told that she was looking at the most private fact a creature owned, and that she was seeing it because he had let her.

There, he said. *Now you see as I see. Tell me what you find. The first three things.*

She turned her head, slowly, drunk on it.

The first thing was the window. Through the glass, the lawn outside ran with thin threads of light, low to the ground, hundreds of them, going about their small bright business; *grass*, she thought, dazed, *that's the grass alive*, and under it deeper threads that must be roots, and she had to look away before it pulled her out the window entirely.

The second thing was her mother's stone, where it hung against her collarbone. It held a small flame, pale and steady, light-side only, a tidy little ember of a thing.

The third thing was the soup.

"The soup's still a bit alive," she said, faintly, and heard how absurd it was the moment it left her, and could not help the laugh that came up after it, the first real one in days, cracked and surprised. "There's a. The carrots are still. Lor-ar, the *carrots* have a little..."

Vegetables are stubborn, he said, with enormous dignity. *They take a long while to admit they are food. It is one of the more tedious facts of the living world and I am glad it amuses you.*

There was a fourth thing too, when she looked for it. The cane at her hip had its own slow light, banked and waiting, a thread of it reaching toward her like a plant leaning at a window; and where the cane's light met the edge of her own, the two did not so much touch as recognize each other, the way a key finds the one lock it was filed for. She had carried it three days against her body and never known it had been quietly trying to come home to her the whole time.

She laughed again, the sound surprising her a second time, and pressed the back of her wrist to her mouth, and the laugh ran down into something steadier, and she sat in the burning room and looked at all of it, and for one whole minute she was not grieving and not frightened and not managing her face. She was only a girl seeing the world for the first time as it actually was, which was *alive*, impossibly, everywhere, all at once, and she had been walking through the middle of it blind.

Then Lor-ar drew his head back, and the loss of him left a clear line of sight straight down, and she looked, because of course she looked, and saw her own core.

* * *

She forgot the carrots.

She had braced, vaguely, for something like the stone at her throat: a pale flame, light-side only, the broken half she had been told she was. Or perhaps, if Lor-ar was right, the

small black smudge she had glimpsed on Amber, the secret thing under the necklace. She had not braced for this.

Her own core was the twin of his, the same plaited wheel of light and dark, and it was vast. Where his was a coal, hers was a hearth. Where his turned slow and certain, hers wheeled with a banked, patient force that she could feel as well as see, a deep furnace-rumble in her own chest that she had been living on top of her entire life and never once heard. It dwarfed the pale ember of her mother's stone the way the sun dwarfs a struck match. It was, she thought, the size of three of his.

She sat rigid, not trusting herself to move.

"That's not right," she said. Her voice had gone flat, the way it went under pressure, the cataloguing voice, the naming voice. "That's bigger than yours. That's. You're three hundred. You're a spirit walker. I'm fourteen. That's not possible..."

No, Lor-ar agreed. It is not what your world would call right. It is, however, what is true, and the two are not always on speaking terms. He settled back on his haunches. The cane did this. The focus your mother left you. It is from the old days, when some unfortunate few were still born with their two halves split apart, unjoined, a light core and a dark core sitting separate in the one chest, neither of them able to reach the other. A cruelty of the severing, in those who slipped through it half-done. So the people of that time made a thing to mend them. A focus that would take the two split halves and weld them into one. That is what was thirsty. That is why it drank a teacher half to nothing to wake, and you to nothing to use. It was not lighting a candle. It was joining two rivers, and rivers do not join cheaply.

"I felt it," she said, remembering. "The summoning. Something shifted. Inside. Like a key going round."

Your two cores becoming one. That shift was the whole of you arriving in the same room for the first time. The storm eyes were

on her, and there was something in them that was not quite pity and not quite pride and was, she thought, simply the look of a very old creature watching a young one understand something that cannot be un-understood. *You were not born with the second half taken away, little one. You were born with both, split, the old way, and you have just spent everything you had to make them one. That is why you are the size of a hearth and I am the size of a coal. You are not a smaller, broken version of the world around you.*

He let it land.

You are the larger, whole version. And the world is the broken one.

* * *

She did not cry. She wanted, suddenly and badly, to do something with her hands, so she picked up the tray and set it on the floor, and she did not cry, because no one saw her do it, that was the rule, the only rule that had held through everything, and there was no one here to see her but a tiger who already knew everything that mattered and had the grace not to watch her too closely while she got her breath back.

It would have been easier, she thought, if it had been only frightening. Some of it was; there was a cold thread running beneath it, *the thing they kill people for*, her mother's voice at the breakfast table, *be careful who you let see you do it*. But beneath the fear sat the warm thing as well, and she was ashamed of how much room it took up. Because for three days she had believed the great vacancy her loss had left was the whole sum of her: a hollowed girl in a colder house. And here, wheeling slow under her own ribs, was the plain enormous fact that the hollow was not all she contained. There was the hearth as well. There had always been the hearth.

She got up, because sitting with it was becoming unbearable, and crossed to the window to look out at the burning lawn, and that was when she saw Alice.

* * *

Alice was crossing below, on the path from the medical wing, her arms full of green-spined books and her head down against a wind that wasn't there, hurrying the way she always hurried, late to something, talking to herself in the way of a person rehearsing a thing she means to say well. And Viridia, with both halves still laid like water over her eyes, looked at her friend, and saw her core.

It was a pale flame. Light-side only. A small steady candle of a thing in the center of her chest, exactly the tidy little ember Viridia had taken her own to be. And it was, very faintly, wrong; she could see it now, with the new sight, the way you can see a tooth is turned out of line once someone points it out and then can never unsee it: a clean place where another thing should have joined, a stump, a seam that led nowhere. The mark of the half that had been taken before Alice was ever born. The wound that Alice would live and die calling her nature, never once feeling it, because you cannot miss a limb you were never given.

You see it, Lor-ar said, from the bed.

"Yes."

She is broken. As all of them are. As you alone are not.

Viridia watched Alice reach the door below and fumble it open one-handed, books sliding, and recover them with a small graceless lunge, and disappear inside, off to be useful, off to keep company with the hurts magic left untouched, off to build her own bright life one ordinary day at a time. She thought about going down. She thought about catching her on the stairs and putting a hand over her eyes the way Lor-ar had put his head to her chest, and showing her, *look, look*

what you really are, look what the world did to all of you, and watching Alice's whole face open the way it opened at everything, with helpless friendly wonder.

She did not move.

Because what would she be giving her? A door Alice could not walk through. A wound Alice could not feel and now could never un-know. The candle was steady. The candle was *enough*, it had always been enough, and it would not make Alice whole to be told otherwise. It would only make Viridia less alone — and she had already learned, in the forest, what it cost to reach for something only because you could not bear to be alone.

So she let the sight go. The room dimmed back to morning. Alice's pale candle, the burning grass, her own impossible hearth, all of it faded out, and the world came back ordinary and dull and survivable, and Viridia stood at the window holding the newest of her secrets, the heaviest one yet, the one she could not even hand to the one person who shared a room with her.

"I won't tell her," she said.

No, Lor-ar agreed, gently. I did not think you would. It is a lonely kindness. They are usually the realest kind.

* * *

She got dressed, after that, because the office would not wait forever and there was nothing left to do with her hands. She dressed in the school's colors, the vest and the skirt and the long socks, and slid the cane into the loop sewn at her hip, where it rode now, primed, four feet of silver that knew more about her than she did. Lor-ar shrank, without being asked, to his house-cat size, and sat on the end of the bed washing one paw with the unbothered air of a thing that has all the time in the world.

She had one more question. She had been carrying it since the clearing, turning it over under all the others, and she had not asked it because she was afraid of the answer and afraid, more, of there being no answer at all.

"Lor-ar."

Mm.

"My parents." She kept her voice level. She kept her hands still. "If I was born with both halves, split, the old way, then it came from somewhere. The book has a tree of names a thousand years deep, the bright kind and the shadowed kind knotted onto one bough, and the focus came down my mother's side. So." She made herself say it. "Did they have it too? Both halves? Were they like me, and just never..." The sentence ran out of road. *Never said. Never showed me. Be careful who you let see you do it.* "Did they know? What I am?"

Lor-ar stopped washing his paw.

For a moment he did not answer, and in the not-answering she let herself hope, absurdly, that he was choosing among several true things, that there was an inheritance here she could reach back and touch, a line that ran from her mother's stillness and her father's burnt toast straight down into the hearth turning under her ribs, so that even this, even the strangeness, would be a thing she had *from them*, one more thread tying her to the kitchen she could not go back to.

I do not know, Lor-ar said.

The hope went out, quietly, the way the sight had gone out, leaving the room dull and survivable.

I am sorry, little one. I would tell you if I knew. I never met them. I can walk into the past of the world, but not into the past of one small house, not where the door is shut and the people are gone and there is no one left who carries the memory of them but you. He came across the blanket and pressed his head, briefly, to her arm. *The tree in your mother's book may hold the answer. The*

names. The one without dates, that you noticed and did not understand. There is an account being kept there that someone meant for you to read. But I cannot read it for you, and I cannot tell you the thing you most want to be told, which is that they knew, and held it, and would have told you in time. I do not know if that is true. I know only that it is what you wish were true, and that wishing it and knowing it are not the same.

So the grief came back. It had never left; it never left; but it had been crowded for an hour, pushed to the edge of the room by the burning grass and the carrots and the vast wheeling fact of herself, and now it walked back into the middle of her and sat down where it always sat, behind her ribs, in the held place no one was permitted to see. Only now it had a new question folded into it, a question that would not be answered in this book or this school or perhaps anywhere: *did you know what I was? Did you carry it the way I carry it now? Were you whole, the two of you, in that cold house, and never once let me see you do it?*

She would think about it, she understood, for the rest of her life. She set it with the others and let it be.

* * *

She stood at the door with her hand on the latch and did not, for a moment, open it.

She was not the girl who had arrived three days ago. That one had been a grief on a chain, a hollow handed off to a porter and a school. This one had a tiger, and a riddle with no floor to it, and a hearth wheeling under her ribs, and not broken, after all, in a world that was. The strange new fact of her, the one she would carry into the office and not say.

Lor-ar wound once around her ankles, warm, the prickle of a held storm in the air of him.

Come along, he said. The Headmistress is waiting, and she, of all of them, has had her eye on that bauble of yours since the day you walked in. Let us go and find out how much she already knows.

Viridia drew one breath, around the held place, the way she did, and opened the door, and went out to be looked at.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Forest at Night

The office had been the strange part of the day, and then it had not been the strangest, because by evening Lor-ar was standing at the door of room fourteen with his ears flat and a tension in him she had not seen before, and was saying that they had to go to the forest, and that they had to go now.

"It's nearly dark," Viridia said.

Yes. He was already turning for the stair. *That is the point. Bring nothing. Wear something you can ride in.*

She did not ask the question that wanted asking, *ride what*, because some part of her already knew, and because the office had taught her something about the size of the room she had walked into. Lady Lightwell had spent an hour that morning being carefully, terribly polite, asking questions whose real shapes lived under the words, and Viridia had answered carefully and given nothing, and had come away with the clear understanding that whatever was happening to her was bigger than a school year and that the people who ran the school knew it before she did. So when a three-hundred-year-old creature told her, with his ears flat, that there was somewhere they had to be before the moon was high, she changed into the dark trousers and the plain shirt and the soft shoes, and she went.

Alice was at the medical wing. There was no one to tell. That, too, was becoming a shape she recognized.

They went out the way they had gone the first time, around the side, into the long grass, into the trees. At the edge of the wood Lor-ar shook himself, head to tail, and the small house-cat shape ran off him like water and left the whole of him standing there, seven feet of him, the storm-charge crackling faintly in the air at his shoulders.

On my back. Mind the horns. He folded down. *You will be locked in place once we move, for your safety. Do not fight it. And do not, whatever you see, ask me to stop. We are already later than I would like.*

She climbed up between his shoulders and got her hands into the deep fur, and felt the static take her, a soft full-body lock that held her seated as surely as a strap, and then the world tore backward.

She had thought she understood, after the first ride, how fast he was. She had not. He went into the dark wood at a flat sprint and did not slow for it, threading the black trunks, going over fallen timber and through gaps she could not have seen in daylight, and the wind he made tore her hair straight back and brought tears that the speed wrung out of her whether she willed them or not. There was no one to see, which was its own small mercy; she let the wind have them.

The forest was alive around her in the new way now. She had not let the mana-sight go since morning, could not quite work out how to, and so the wood did not stream past her as darkness but as a tide of low green threads, a thousand living things startling out of their path: owls going up in cold blue sparks, something large and slow turning over in a thicket as they passed, the roots beneath them all laced together under the soil in a web she had never once suspected. She thought, dizzily, holding on, that she had walked over the top of this her whole life and called it ground. She thought that the world was simply more crowded with life than anyone had ever told her, and that the

not-telling was beginning to look less like ignorance and more like a thing arranged.

She held on. She did not ask him to stop.

The ride went on past the point where she could have told anyone how long it had lasted. The cold worked into her hands where they gripped the fur, and the small bright animals fell away behind, and the ground began, faintly, to tilt upward. And then, ahead, through the moving trunks, came a light that was not blue and not alive: orange, hard, leaping. Firelight, thrown up a wall of stone.

The trees opened.

* * *

The clearing stood at the foot of a wall of rock, the mountain she could see, just, from her round window. There was a cave mouth in the rock, and the cave mouth and the ground in front of it were scorched black, old fire and fresh, and on either side of the opening a fire burned now, whole trees torn apart and stacked and set alight, throwing a hard orange light up the cliff.

There were two dragons.

She had read the word her whole life. She had seen the word painted on the hallway walls of the school, small and stylized, a creature for a crest. Nothing had prepared her for the fact of them. The nearer one was scarlet, brilliant even in firelight, and she breathed flame in a long unhurried stream over something on the ground between them, again and again, the way a person might tend a low fire to keep it from going out. The farther one she did not see at first because he was the absence of light: pitch black, blacker than the dark behind him, so that he showed only where the firelight slid off the planes of him and was swallowed.

Between them, on the bare scorched earth, lay an egg. It was as long as Viridia was tall. The scarlet dragon bathed it

in her fire, and now and then the black one leaned in and added a breath of his own, and his fire was not orange or red. It was black, a black flame with no light in it at all, and where it passed over the shell the shell seemed for an instant to drink the dark.

Lor-ar released the static. She slid down on legs that did not entirely belong to her and stood in the heat off the fires and could not, at first, do anything but look.

And then, because she still had not closed the new sight, she looked at the dragons the way she had looked at Lor-ar that morning, and nearly sat down in the scorched grass.

If her own core was a hearth and Lor-ar's a coal, these were furnaces, foundries, things that did not belong inside a body. The scarlet dragon's core wheeled white and dark together, the whole gift, vast and turning slow as weather. The black dragon's was the same and was somehow more, older, denser, with a heaviness to the dark side of it that pulled at her own like a hand at the hem of a coat. She understood, looking, why the floor of the world had answered her call by sending these. They were not large creatures. They were nearer to forces. And the egg between them, when she found the courage to look at it, held the smallest fire she had ever seen with the sight, a new spark barely lit, all the colors at once, turning over and over inside the shell like a thing impatient to begin.

She made herself let the sight go, before it pulled her in. Even then it came back the moment she stopped holding it off, settling over her eyes without her asking, and she noted that, too: it was getting easier. It was getting harder to turn off.

You cut it close, Lor-ar. The voice came into her skull without ceremony, vast and rough, the black dragon's, though he had not moved. *You are fortunate he has not hatched. It could come at any breath.*

"My apologies, Drake." Lor-ar dipped his great head. "She needed the day to recover. She drained herself to the floor calling me."

The black dragon swung his head around, slow, and looked at Viridia. The eye that found her was the size of a dinner plate and very old. He regarded her for a long moment.

Doesn't look like much, he said.

The scarlet dragon, without breaking the rhythm of her fire over the egg, lashed her tail sideways and caught him across his. He grunted.

What, he said, aggrieved. *Am I not to have an opinion of the girl my son is to be tied to for the rest of his life, Varissa?*

You are not to be unkind to a frightened child who has done nothing but answer a call she did not understand, the scarlet one said. Her mind-voice was warmer, lower, with something fierce running under the warmth. *Forgive him,* she said to Viridia. *He is not rude. He is grieving, and he is bad at it, as the big ones always are.*

* * *

Drake left the fire.

He came forward, and as he came he shrank, the great black bulk folding down and down until a man stood in the firelight where the dragon had been. He was taller than Viridia, dark-haired, in plain tan breeches and a white shirt, and the eyes in the man's face were the dragon's eyes, ancient and unhappy. He sat down by the nearer fire and ran his hand through the flame as though it were water, deep in some thought he did not share, and motioned for them to sit, and for a while he said nothing at all.

"Has she been told why she is here," he asked at last. Not to her. To Lor-ar.

"She is new-hatched herself, to all of this," Lor-ar said. "Tell her plainly."

Drake looked into the fire. When he spoke it did not come out like a lesson. It came out like a man telling a thing he would rather not, in order, because the telling could not be avoided.

"Long ago," he said, "when your kind and mine still kept faith with each other, a pact was struck. To come when called. To stand, each for the other, against a great enough need. The years wore on it. Your kind forgot. You kept us as pets, and then you hunted us for the wall over your hearths, and the ones of us that were left went home into the high places and let the pact go quiet." His hand turned in the fire. "It was not broken. Only quiet. And a thing that is only quiet can be woken."

He looked at her then.

"You woke it. When you called into that forest, you did not call for a companion. You called from the floor of yourself for something that would not leave you, with both halves of a gift no one has carried whole in an age, and the pact heard a need that large and answered it whether we willed it or no." He nodded, once, at the egg in its bath of fire. "My son. When he hatches, he will bond to you. There is one way and one moment to bond a dragon, and it is the first breath, the first sight, and it cannot be undone or repeated. His life will be yours and yours his." The man's jaw worked. "That is why I am poor company tonight. I am sitting at a fire, watching the last hours I will have a son who is only mine."

"How old are you," Viridia asked, before she could weigh whether it was a thing one asked.

He did not seem to mind. "Near six thousand years," he said. "Varissa, near five. We were not young when the pact was made. We were there at the making of it. That is why it took us so hard when it woke. The old bindings sit deepest in

the old ones. A younger creature might have felt your call as a tug and shrugged it off. We felt it as a summons we had sworn to in person, and there is no shrugging off a thing you swore to with your own mouth, even an age ago, even when keeping the word costs you a son." He looked at the egg. "We have had others. One did not live through the last war. We have tried, since, the two of us, for two hundred years. This is the first to quicken. And the pact gives him away the night he is born."

He stood, abruptly, and walked off toward the dark edge of the clearing, and between one stride and the next he was the dragon again, and he went up off the ground with a single thunderous beat of his wings and into the night sky, and a moment later, high overhead, he tore a long ragged plume of black fire into the dark.

Viridia sat motionless by the fire. She had asked, four days ago, for something that would not leave her. She had not understood, until now, that everything in this world that came when called came from somewhere, was someone's, had been loved before it was hers. She had thought she was asking the forest for a gift. She had been asking it for someone else's child.

* * *

"It is not your doing," Varissa said.

She had not stopped tending the egg. Viridia turned to find the scarlet head lowered near her, the slit-pupiled eye warm in the firelight, watching her with what looked, on a dragon, very near to gentleness.

He has told you the count of years, I expect, and the one we lost, she said. He always does; it is how he keeps the wound where he can watch it. What he will not have told you is the rest. That after the last one we did not speak of trying again for forty years. That when this egg quickened I would not let myself believe in it until it

moved under my own breath, for fear of how it would be to lose another. That I have spent every night since with my fire on this shell, not because it needs it, but because it is the only thing left that I am permitted to do for him. The great head tilted toward Viridia. I do not tell you this to lay the weight on you. I tell you so you will hold the size of it. We are handing you our only child. Do you understand that I would not do this for a soul I had any choice about?

"I." Viridia's voice came out unsteady, and she let it, here, in front of a creature who had buried a child and was about to hand over another. "I don't know how to be worth that."

No one does, beforehand, Varissa said. You learn it after, or you fail it. I have watched a great many mothers, of every kind. The ones who ask that question are the ones I do not worry about.

High above, Drake's plume of black fire tore the dark again, farther off now, smaller.

He will circle until he has burned it out of himself, Varissa said, following Viridia's glance. It is how the big ones grieve. Loudly, and from a height, and then not at all, ever, for a thousand years. There was no scorn in it; there was a long marriage in it. I grieve closer to the ground. Someone must, or nothing would get done. The slit eye came back to Viridia. You grieve like me, I think. Quietly. With your back straight and your hands busy. Yes?

Viridia did not answer. There was no need; the not-answering was the answer, and Varissa let it stand, and that, more than anything anyone had said to her in four days, made Viridia's throat close. It was the first time someone had named the thing she did and not asked her to stop doing it.

Then you will manage him, Varissa said gently. A grief held quiet leaves room in the hands for a small thing that needs holding. You will see. She bent her head and laid one more long breath of fire over the egg, and the shell glowed scarlet, and then—

A sound came out of the egg. A crack, sharp as a snapped bone, loud in the clearing.

"Now," Varissa said, and her warmth went taut with something that was very old and very urgent. *Go to him. Help him free. He must see you. You must be the first thing he sees in the world, and the last thing he must doubt for the rest of his life is whether he is yours. Go.*

* * *

Viridia was on her knees in front of the egg before any decision reached her.

The shell was hot under her hands, not burning, alive with the heat of two dragons' fire, and it shuddered. A second crack ran across it. From inside came a sound, a small high reaching sound, and then a snout pushed through the broken place, a snout that was not one color but all of them, scales that threw the firelight back in red and gold and green and blue at once, shifting as they moved.

She got her fingers into the crack and pulled. The shell was thicker than she expected, and tougher. It fought her. She set her teeth, pulled harder, and a long curved piece came free with a sound of tearing. Inside, in the wet dark, something heaved and pushed toward the opening she had made. She cleared another piece, and another, working fast now, her hands slick with the strange clear fluid of the egg, and Varissa's voice was at her ear, *there, the seam, follow the seam, do not crack the brow*, and she followed the seam, and the shell came away in halves.

He was folded in on himself, the way a thing is folded that has spent its whole short existence in a space too small for it: the wings pressed flat and wet against his sides, the long tail wound twice around, the head tucked under one limb. He was the size of a large cat and he weighed more than any cat had a right to, dense, hot, trembling. She got both hands

under him and lifted, taking the wet weight of him out of the wreck of the shell, and he uncurled in her hands by degrees, one limb and then the next, and the head came up last.

He opened his eyes.

The world stopped.

She had no other way to say it, after, and she did not try to find one. Time, which had been running fast all night, simply set itself down. The firelight stilled. The clearing went away. There was the small heat of him in her hands and there were his eyes finding hers, eyes that held every color the way his scales did and behind the colors something old and waking and unmistakably *aware*, and into the held silence of that look something passed both ways at once, a recognition with no words in it, a tying-off, a knot pulled tight in the dark, and she felt it land in the same place under her ribs where the hearth turned, felt her own enormous core flare and reach and take him in. She did not fence it this time either. She had learned, in a clearing with a cane in her hands, that she was a girl who reached past the safe edge when something worth keeping was on the far side of it, and she did not yet know whether that was the best thing in her or the most dangerous, only that it was hers.

It cost her. The taking-in dragged at the hearth hard enough that the clearing tilted and went white at the edges, and the old iron taste flooded the back of her mouth, and she had to lock her elbows to keep from folding down over the wet weight of him. She held on. She would have held on through a great deal worse, and some far-back part of her, even then, suspected she might one day have to.

She was changed in that moment, and knew it as it happened. The firelight came up too bright, the crackle of the burning logs too sharp, the night air carrying scents she had no names for, resin and scorched stone and the clean cold of the heights above. The mana-sight, which she had

held open all day by an act of will, dropped into place inside her and stopped being work, a thing she simply had now, the way she had her own two hands.

And under all of it, deeper than the sharpened senses, in the warm turning dark below her ribs where the hearth lived, there was now a second presence. A small new fire, his fire, sitting close beside her own and tied to it past any untying. She could feel him in there the way you can feel someone in a dark room with you, a warmth and a weight and a faint contentment that was not hers. He was frightened and he was new and he was, already, not afraid of her, and the not-being-afraid came down the new thread between them and settled in her chest, and she thought she might understand, now, a little of what Varissa meant about the hands and the holding.

She looked down at the dragon in her hands, and a name rose up through her and out of her mouth before she had chosen it.

"Raizen."

The little dragon bobbed his head at the sound of it, as though he had been waiting for her to find it, as though it had been his all along and he was only glad she had caught up.

"The bond is complete," Lor-ar said quietly, beside her. There was no amusement in it. There was something almost like reverence.

* * *

She carried him to Varissa.

The scarlet dragon had taken her human shape: a tall woman with pale skin and flame-red hair loose down a black dress, and she knelt in the firelight and looked at her son in Viridia's arms with a love so plain and so finished that Viridia had to look at the fire instead of at her face.

"He's beautiful," Viridia said, because it was true and because she did not have anything larger.

"He is," Varissa agreed. She did not reach to take him. She held herself very straight, the way Viridia held herself, and Viridia understood the cost of the straightness exactly. "You will feel changes in the coming days. Do not be frightened of them; they are him, settling into you, and you into him. Your skin will harden as his is hard. Other things, smaller, that I cannot predict. Lor-ar can answer what I have not the time to."

She laid one fingertip, very lightly, on the small ridged spine of her son, and then she drew her hand back and stood, and the gentleness folded away and something fiercer came up under it, and she looked at Viridia over the fire.

"Hear me clearly, and carry this word for word to your Headmistress, because I will know if you soften it." The fierce thing in her was not aimed at Viridia; it was aimed past her, at a school, at a world. "If harm comes to my son, in that place of hers, by her hand or by her carelessness or by any hand she might have stopped, she will not have a school. She will not have a stone left standing on a stone. I will come, and I will burn it to the ground, and I will not be quick about it." A breath. "Tell her I said it kindly. I am being kind. The unkind version I will only say the once."

Viridia's mouth had gone dry.

She turned the threat over, even in the heat of the fire, even with the new dragon settling into the deep of her, because that was how her mind worked, it caught the one detail and it would not let go, and the detail here was that a dragon five thousand years old had just made her, a fourth-day pupil, the carrier of a death sentence for the woman who ran her school. The size of it frightened her. Not the threat itself; she did not doubt Varissa would do exactly what she said, and slowly. What frightened her was that she

had become, without trying, without wanting to, a person through whom large and terrible powers now sent their messages to one another. A girl who carried a stone and a grief had walked through that gate. Something else stood at this fire, and the something else had a dragon's mother trusting her with a warning and a school's mistress watching her with rose-tinted care, and it was getting harder, day by day, to find the girl underneath.

"I'll tell her," she said. "Word for word."

Something in Varissa eased, fractionally. *Good*, she said, the warmth coming back. *Then we understand each other, you and I.* She looked to the sky, where the black shape of her mate still turned and grieved against the stars. *Go now, before the moon is full up. I must go and talk my husband down out of the dark. He will be like this for days. He always is.* For one moment the fierceness and the warmth were both in her face at once. *Be good to my boy.*

And she was the dragon again, scarlet and enormous, and she lifted off the scorched ground and rose to where Drake wheeled and grieved, and the two of them joined and circled, and a thread of red fire and a thread of black laced up together into the night.

* * *

Lor-ar led them to the path at the clearing's edge.

"On my back again," he said. "Hold him; I will not lock the small one in. He has had enough of being held still inside a shell." He folded down. "You may ride the dragon yourself, in time. Not tonight. Tonight you are tired in a place rest does not reach, and you are carrying something new, and I would rather you both arrive whole."

She climbed up. The static took her, and did not take Raizen, who lay along the warm fur in the crook of her arm,

exhausted, his eyes already closing, the small new fire of him steady against the dark of her.

They went back slower than they had come.

Viridia looked back once, before the trees took the clearing, at the two dragons circling the mountain in their twin colors of fire, at the cave that had held a son and would now hold only the parents who had given him away. Then the wood closed over it, and there was only the dark, and the speed, and the small living weight against her arm.

She was fourteen years old. Four days back she had arrived at the gate with a stone on a chain and a grief she could not set down, and now she rode something out of the oldest paintings through a forest that swallowed grown girls whole, a dragon asleep in the bend of her elbow and a tiger's mind running quiet alongside her own, and somewhere behind her a mother who would unmake a school over the small life curled now against Viridia's heart.

There was no undoing it. That was the plain fact she carried home in the dark. Whatever she had been when she walked through the gate, she was not that now, and she could not go back and be it. The bond was complete. It would be complete when she was old, if she lived to be old; it would be complete on the day she died. She had not chosen it, exactly. The pact had chosen for her. But choice or no choice, it was hers now, the way the hearth under her ribs was hers, the way the grief was hers, a thing she would carry whether she had asked for it or not, and would not, she found, lying along the running warmth of Lor-ar with her cheek near the small sleeping dragon, have given back if she could.

When the wood gave way to open ground the school stood dark and quiet on its lawn, and one window on the west wing burned with a low lamp. Alice, waiting up, or only reading late.

Viridia stopped in the cold grass and looked at it, and felt the new weight of the thing she was about to do: walk in past her one friend with a dragon under her coat and a death-threat in her mouth and say *nothing*. Her skin had begun to tighten across her knuckles already, a faint stiffening she could feel when she flexed her hand, the first of the changes Varissa had named. By morning there would be other changes she could not explain and would have to. The list of things she carried where Alice could not see them had been three days short and was now longer than she could hold in one thought. She pressed Raizen closer, where his small fire beat against her own, and the weight did not lighten, but it steadied.

Then she slid down off Lor-ar's back, and held the small bright life she had brought home from the dark a breath longer in the cold.

Tomorrow there would be a dragon to hide and changes she could not explain and a death-warrant to carry, word for word, to the woman who ran the school. Tonight there was only the lit window, and Alice behind it, and the long quiet work of walking past the one person she could not afford to tell. She fixed her face into the careful nothing, and carried the warm weight inside.

CHAPTER NINE

Lady Lightwell's Office

The corridor was different now, and Viridia could not stop seeing it.

She had walked this hallway a dozen times in four days, past the painted faces and the tall windows, and it had been only a corridor: carpet, lamps, the long line of dead painters and their dead subjects. Now she walked it with the mana-sight settled into her for good, no longer something she held open but something she simply had, and the corridor was full.

The lamps in their sconces each held a small bright knot of worked magic, light bound into glass and kept. The carved blue veins in the staircase ran faintly with the same; some old enchantment, decoration with a use she could not name. And the girls. The girls were everywhere, two of them going the other way arm in arm, three more on the stair, and each of them carried in her chest a small steady flame, light-side only, pale and tidy and the same as every flame she had seen since the morning Lor-ar had pressed his brow to hers and shown her the truth of it. Candles, all of them. Wounded, all of them, and not one of them knowing.

Raizen rode her shoulder, his tail wound twice round her arm, half-asleep and warm against her neck. Lor-ar padded along at her side in his house-cat size. Together the three of them were, she was fairly sure, the strangest thing this

hallway had carried in its long and proper life, and the other girls gave them a wide berth and pretended not to stare, which only made the staring louder.

It was strange, she thought, climbing toward the office, how quickly the impossible became furniture. Four days ago the sight of a horned tiger in a school corridor would have emptied the building. This morning two second-years had glanced at Lor-ar, glanced at the small bright dragon, and gone back to their own conversation about a boy in the town, because the news had got round and a thing everyone has heard about is no longer a thing worth stopping for. People could grow used to anything, given a day or two. She wondered if that was a mercy or a warning. She suspected, given the morning she was walking into, that it was both.

She had not slept much. She had lain awake holding the new fire in her chest, and the warning she had to deliver word for word, and the question Lor-ar could not answer about her parents, and at some point near dawn she had given up on sleep and simply waited for the hour she was due in the office.

She was due now.

The door at the top of the stone stair had steel bands worked into the wood and red runes cut into the steel. She had passed it twice before and thought it only stern, a heavy old door an institution kept for show. Now, with the sight, she could see that it was nothing of the kind. The runes ran with a deep banked working, layered, patient, the lines of it doubled and re-doubled in a way that spoke of years of careful addition; and she could not read what it said, the script being the older kind that lived in her mother's book and her own focus, but she could read what it was for. It was a door built to keep things out, and to keep things in, and to hear, perhaps, whether anyone stood listening at it. More care had been put into this one door than into the whole rest

of the wing. A schoolmistress's study had no business being warded like a vault.

Unless, of course, it was not only a study. She marked it, the way she marked everything. Up close the wood smelled of old wax and colder iron, and the runes gave off a faint warmth she could feel before her knuckles ever touched them, as though the door were breathing slowly in the dim of the stairwell. She raised one fist, waited until it had stopped shaking, and knocked.

"Come in," said the voice from within, after a pause that was a beat too long.

* * *

Lady Lightwell stood at the single window with her back to the door, looking out at the forest and the mountain, and she did not turn around at once.

"Three days," she said, to the glass. "When you walked through my gate I gave you four years, Miss Saeren, the way I give every girl four years, and I thought I knew roughly what they would contain." She turned then. The rose-tinted lenses caught the morning and held it, two small panes of color in front of eyes Viridia still could not read. "In three days you persuaded your sponsor to spend her one favor putting you into a class I reserve for fourth-years. You walked into a forest that has cost this school a hand this term alone, and you walked out of it with a creature I was assured no longer existed. And then, having apparently decided that was a quiet enough start, you went back in last night and returned True Bonded to a dragon."

"Two days," Viridia said. "It was two days, for most of that. The dragon was last night."

Something moved at the corner of Lady Lightwell's mouth. It was not quite a smile, and it was gone before it finished. "I stand corrected. Two days. That is so much more

reassuring." She came away from the window and sat, and gestured Viridia to the chair across the plain wooden desk, on which sat the two crystals, white on the right and onyx on the left, each of them, Viridia saw now, alive with bound magic of its own. "Sit. Put the tiger somewhere. And before you say a word." She lifted one finger. "I am aware there are things you have been told you may not discuss. I am not going to ask you to break a confidence to a creature six thousand years old. I am too fond of this building."

Lor-ar, at Viridia's feet, lifted his head.

On the matter of the dragons, he said, his voice arriving in the room, I am instructed to say nothing, and so I will say nothing, except for one item, which I am instructed to say in full. He paused, and there was, unmistakably, relish in the pause. Raizen's mother bid the little one carry you a message, word for word. She asks me to tell you that if any harm comes to her son in your care, through your hand or your carelessness or any hand you might have stopped, you will not have a school. You will not have a stone standing on a stone. She will come, and she will burn it to the ground, and she will not be quick about it. A beat. She asked that I add that she says it kindly. She wished it understood that this is the kind version.

There was a silence.

She also wished it conveyed, Lor-ar added, into the quiet, with the air of a creature delivering the last and best item of his commission, that she is being kind. She asked me to be sure you understood that this was the kind version, and that you would not enjoy the other one. I have now said it twice, which I believe satisfies the instruction "word for word," and which I confess I have enjoyed more than is seemly. He laid his chin back down on his paws. Dragons are very direct. It is restful.

Lady Lightwell went motionless behind her desk and absorbed this, and Viridia, watching her with the new sight, saw the thing she had been half-expecting since the

morning Lor-ar taught her to look and she had not yet dared confirm: that under the light-core necklace at the Headmistress's throat, where there should have been the pale flame of any light mage, there turned instead a black swirling mass, slow and deep, a dark core hidden behind a borrowed light. The same arrangement as Amber's. The Headmistress of Hazel Preparatory, the woman who trained the country's light mages, was a dark mage wearing a light mage's face.

Viridia kept her own face empty. She had a great deal of practice at keeping her face from telling on her.

"Word for word," Lady Lightwell said at last. "Yes. I imagine that is word for word; you have the look of a girl who delivers things exactly." She drew a slow breath. "Tell her. No. Do not tell her anything. One does not reply to a dragon; one survives having been addressed by one." She set both hands flat on the desk. "I will keep her son safe. I would have done in any case. It is, I will admit, a more motivating instruction than most I receive."

* * *

She took off the spectacles then, and rubbed the bridge of her nose, and for a moment, without the rose lenses, she looked tired and human and not at all like a woman who could hold a corridor together by being feared in it.

"What do you want from this school, Miss Saeren?" she asked.

Viridia thought about it. She thought about the easy answers, *to learn, to do well, to make my parents proud*, the things you said to a teacher who was deciding what to make of you, and she found she did not want to give any of them. Partly because she suspected the woman across the desk would hear an easy answer for exactly what it was and think less of her for trying it. Partly because she was tired, and the

question was a real one, asked plainly, and she had not been asked many real ones lately; everyone had been telling her things instead, large impossible things, and a question felt almost like a courtesy.

So she gave the real answer, and was a little surprised, hearing it, to find it was true.

"I want to be able to protect myself," she said. "I spent a long time not being able to protect anything. And I want to help, where I can. People who can't protect themselves." She paused. "I don't know how to do either of those yet. But that's why I'm at a school."

"People in general? Or people in particular?" Lady Lightwell watched her. "Your history teacher came to me, you know. Mr. Cote does not often come to me. He came to tell me about a first-year's answer to an essay question. The one about whether the light mages of the old wars did right, hunting the dark mages to the root." A pause, weighted. "You said no. At some length, I'm told, and well."

So that was where it had gone. Viridia had wondered, turning the essay in with her heart in her throat, whether anyone read those.

"I meant it," she said.

"I'm sure you did." Lady Lightwell turned the spectacles over in her hands. "It is the kind of thing that gets a girl noticed, Miss Saeren. Not always by people you would want to be noticed by. So let me ask you plainly, since you seem to be a girl who prefers plain things." She looked up. "Do you believe a person born with the darker half of the gift is, for that reason, a danger to be put down?"

Viridia met the rose-less eyes. She thought of the black core turning slow behind the light-core necklace. She thought of Amber, on the kitchen floor between her dead parents. She thought of her mother's letter, *light and dark, good and evil, it's all in how you look at it*. She decided, in the

space of a breath, how honest to be, and then she decided to be more honest than was safe, because she did not think this woman was asking out of idleness.

"No," she said. "I think being born with the dark half makes you a dark mage. I think being born with the light half makes you a light mage. I don't think either one makes you good or evil. I think you decide that yourself, after, the same as anyone." She held the gaze. "And I think a great many people are being killed for a thing they were born with and never chose, and that calling it justice doesn't make it justice."

For a long moment Lady Lightwell said nothing. Then she put the spectacles back on, slowly, as though arming herself, and the tired human face went away behind the rose, and something else looked out.

"If only there were more of you," she said quietly. "Every week there are fewer of us, and more of them, and the difference between the two grows harder to survive."

* * *

"Us," Viridia repeated.

She had not meant to say it. It came out because the sight had shown her the truth and the truth had made the word land differently. *Us*. The woman had said it without thinking, and now it sat in the room between them, and they both knew Viridia had caught it.

Lady Lightwell did not flinch. She had clearly decided something, in the last minute, about how this conversation was going to go.

"You can see it," she said. It was not a question. "The mana sight. Your tiger taught you, or the dragon gave it to you, I neither know nor care which. You have been sitting in my office for ten minutes looking at my chest with a face that is trying very hard to look at nothing, and I am too old to

pretend I don't know what that means." She folded her hands. "Yes. I am what you think I am. The necklace is the same kind that keeps your sponsor walking around. It is not the secret you should be most concerned about in this building, but it is mine, and now you have it, and so we are, the two of us, in a position of mutual trust, which is a polite way of saying that we can each ruin the other and had therefore better not."

Viridia found she was not as shocked as she should have been. She had seen it; seeing took the shock out of things, she was learning. What it left in place of shock was a great many questions.

"Amber said you helped her," she said. "The necklace. When her core shattered. She said it wasn't her secret to tell how."

"It still isn't." But the Headmistress did not refuse the subject; she only set its edges. "I will tell you what I tell anyone who has earned a piece of the truth and will keep it. There is a resistance. You will have gathered that much, between your sponsor and your reading and your unfortunate habit of noticing things." She leaned back. "Some of my fourth-years do not spend their absences on the errands they record in their files. They run supplies that the capital would rather never reached the people it is starving. Now and again, when word comes to us in time, they go out and they bring a family in before the soldiers reach them. Not often. We hear too late, mostly. We hear after." Something passed over her face and was put away. "I help where I can without losing this position, because this position is the most useful thing I have ever been, and a great many people are alive because a dark mage was permitted to run a light mage's school for fifteen years and no one thought to check her necklace." She said it without pride and without apology, the way a person states a load

they have carried so long they no longer notice the weight of it. "That is the shape of it. I will not give you names. The girls who go out do not know each other's full part in it, on purpose, so that no one of them taken can give up the rest. You will not ask, and if anyone ever asks you, you will know nothing, because the less you truly know the less they can take from you."

"I understand," Viridia said. "I won't ask."

"Good." The Headmistress studied her a moment. "You take that better than most would. I tell a girl her school is a front for a banned resistance and she usually does me the courtesy of looking frightened."

"I'm frightened," Viridia said. "I just don't do it where it shows."

For the first time the not-quite-smile finished itself, and Lady Lightwell looked at her with a flicker of plain recognition, one careful person regarding another. "No," she said. "I don't suppose you do. We are going to get along, you and I, in the wary way of two people who have each other by the throat."

* * *

"There is a man," Lady Lightwell said, after a moment, and something in her voice changed, went carefully level in the way Viridia's own voice went level over the things that hurt. "Heading the resistance. Jazen. He is, I think, the most powerful dark mage alive, and he has spent the last two years doing the hardest thing a powerful and grieving man can do, which is to keep asking for peace when every instinct he has is screaming for the other thing."

"Grieving," Viridia said.

The Headmistress looked at her, and looked away, out the window, at the forest.

"They killed his sister." She said it flatly, the flatness a kind of containment. "Two years ago. She was visiting a dark-mage family when a raid came through. The official account, the one in the capital's papers, says a full cohort of dark mages slaughtered an entire town, every light mage in it, indiscriminate. Thirty-two of them, the account says." A pause. "The truth is that there was no cohort. There was a girl, and the family she was visiting, and the soldiers who came to burn them, and then there was Jazen, who arrived too late and found his sister's body in the ash, and lost himself entirely, and killed every soldier in that town with his own two hands, alone." Her jaw was tight. "He has never forgiven himself for it. Not for killing them. For losing control. For becoming, for one afternoon, exactly the thing they say all of us are. He has been suing for peace ever since, as hard as a man can, because he is terrified of who he becomes when there isn't any. And the High Chancellor will not meet him, and will not stop the killing, and one day soon the asking is going to run out, and then there will be war, and it will be a bad one, because the man leading the other side spent two years trying with everything he had to prevent it."

The fire popped in the grate. Raizen stirred against Viridia's neck and went still again.

Viridia sat with it. She had read the histories. She had taken Mr. Cote's quiz on the old wars and written her careful, dangerous answer and turned it in before she could lose her nerve, and the whole time it had been a thing in a book, the way the dead in the hallway paintings were a thing on a wall. Now it had a brother in it. A man who had come home too late and found his sister in the ash and become, for one afternoon, the monster they had always called him, and had spent every day since terrified of meeting that monster again in the mirror. She thought she understood that better

than the Headmistress could know. She knew something about a held thing that wanted, with its whole weight, to be let loose, and about the work of holding it. She had only ever held grief. She tried to imagine holding what Jazen held, two years of it, with an entire desperate people watching to see which way you would break, and she could not, quite, and was glad she could not.

"What would that mean," she asked. "For us. Here."

"For you it would mean leaving." The answer came at once; she had clearly thought about it for a long time. "If it comes to open war, I pull the dark-mage girls out of this school and we go to a resistance camp, the largest and safest one, where Jazen is. I will not leave a single one of them here to be found." She looked at Viridia, and there was something almost like apology in it. "Which now includes you, I'm afraid. You are not a dark mage, exactly. You are something I do not have a word for, something I am fairly sure has not walked these halls in a thousand years. But the law that wants the dark mages dead would want you dead twice over if it understood you, and so you will leave with the rest of us, when the time comes. Until then your one task is to learn. Everything. Especially from Mrs. Zoran, who is a light mage and one of us in every way that counts." A thin breath. "I am sorry. You came here for a school. I am telling you that you have walked into the middle of a war that has been pretending, for everyone's comfort, not to be happening."

"How long," Viridia said. "Before the pretending stops."

Lady Lightwell was quiet for a moment. "Jazen has set a line," she said at last. "He has told the Chancellor, through the channels we have, that he will go on asking for peace until the next dark mage is killed by the capital's order. One more. After that he stops asking. He has held to it longer than I thought any man could; he holds to it now, while they go on killing the ones they can find, because so far they have

killed them in raids he can call accidents and not in the open, by decree. But that is a thread, Miss Saeren, and threads of that kind do not last." She looked at the fire. "I would be surprised if we finished the year inside these walls. I tell you so that when the morning comes that I send for the dark-mage girls, you will not waste any of the little time we will have being shocked."

* * *

Lady Lightwell stood, which was a dismissal, and Viridia stood with her, and gathered the sleeping dragon more securely against her shoulder.

"You should go to Mrs. Zoran," the Headmistress said. "You will be late. Tell her you were with me; she will not mind." She came around the desk, and at this nearer distance the morning struck the lenses full-on and turned them to two flat coins of color, so that the eyes behind them went somewhere Viridia could not follow. "Miss Saeren. One more thing, and then I will let you go and be a child for an hour, if you can manage it." A pause. "You notice things. It is the most dangerous quality you have, more dangerous than the dragon, more dangerous than whatever you are. So I will give you a piece of advice in exchange for the message you carried, and call us even." The voice dropped. "Notice quietly. The world you have stepped into kills the people who let it be seen how much they understand. You will have learned that already, from your mother, I expect, if she was anything like the people who tend to produce a girl like you." She straightened. "Go on. Learn your symbols. We will speak again."

Viridia went.

And in the corridor outside, with the door shut behind her and the wards humming faint in the wood, she stopped,

and let the sight rest where it wanted to rest, on the girls passing in the hall.

A girl going past caught Viridia staring and frowned, uncertain, and Viridia let her eyes drop to the carpet and emptied her expression in the space of a breath, the old reflex, drilled into her by a mother who had never once said aloud what it was for. *Notice quietly*. She had practiced it her whole childhood. Only now did she grasp the price of being caught.

She had seen it all morning and not understood what she was seeing. Now she understood, and she made herself stand there and count, because counting was what she did with things too large to feel all at once.

One on the stair: a tall third-year with her hair in a plait, laughing at something, and under the thin chain at her throat, where the borrowed pale stone sat, a small dark mass turning slow and careful, hidden behind the stone's stolen flame. One at the far end by the windows, a quiet girl Viridia had seen at meals and never spoken to, the same. The fourth-year coming up from the dining hall with a stack of books, the same. Not many. Four, five, that she could find from where she stood. But more than none, and now that she knew the shape of the thing she was looking for she understood that there would be more she could not see from here, scattered through the years and the classrooms, each one wearing a light mage's face over a dark mage's heart because the alternative was to be hunted.

Dark mages. In a school for light mages. Walking the corridors in their stolen light, raising their hands and giving the right answers, writing home to families who had hidden them here because here was the one place in the country a dark-born girl might be safe, because the woman who ran it was one of them, and had built this whole proper, paneled, respectable institution as a hiding place in plain sight. Every

one of those girls was one bad afternoon away from the thing that had been done to Jazen's sister, and every one of them came down to breakfast anyway and smiled at Mr. Cote, because pretending was the rent you paid to go on living.

The war was not coming to Hazel. It was already here, in the desks, behind the borrowed flames, and she would never again walk this corridor and think it only a corridor.

Raizen woke against her neck, and yawned, a small gust of heat, and pushed his blunt new head into the angle of her jaw. He could not speak yet; that would come, Lor-ar said, in time. But the warmth of him came down the bond all the same, a wordless small contentment, untroubled, certain of her, and it asked nothing and explained nothing and was, just then, the only honest comfort in the building.

You feel it, Lor-ar said, low, at her heel. *What you have seen. It sits heavy.*

"I can see," Viridia said quietly, starting down the stairs to go and learn her symbols, "and I can't unsee it. And there's no one in this whole school I'm allowed to tell." She steadied the dragon at her shoulder. "Except the two of you. Which I suppose is why the forest sent you."

Lor-ar said nothing to that, which from Lor-ar was a kind of agreement, and the three of them went down together into the ordinary morning that Viridia would never again be able to see as ordinary.

CHAPTER TEN

The Language of Magic

The first lesson happened by the fountain, after dark, the night Lor-ar decided she was ready to be shown what magic actually was.

The fountain stood behind the school, a stone basin where carved dolphins spat water into a pool, and at night, when the windows had gone dark and the first and second years were shut in by curfew, it became theirs. Lor-ar had chosen it, she suspected, because it was out of sight of the windows and within sight of the forest, so that he could keep half an eye on the black edge of the forest while he taught. He sat back on his haunches in the moonlight, full size, the storm-charge prickling faint in the air around him. He held up both forepaws. Over the left one a black flame came into being; over the right, a white one.

It was, she would think later, the true beginning of everything that came after, more than the gate or the summoning or even the hatching, though none of them had felt like beginnings at the time. Beginnings rarely did. They only announced themselves once you knew what they had begun.

Viridia, sitting on the bench with the cane across her knees and the newborn dragon asleep in her lap, stopped breathing.

She had seen flame her whole life. She had never seen dark flame. The black fire over Lor-ar's left paw gave off no light at all; it ate the moonlight near it, a flame that burned downward into itself, and beside it the white flame burned clean and ordinary, and the two of them sat there in his paws, separate, balanced, waiting.

Watch the magic, not the fire, he said. You have the sight. Use it.

She looked, and saw it: two distinct streams running up out of his core, one bright and one dark, each feeding its own flame, neither touching the other. And then, slowly, deliberately, he brought his paws together. The streams came with them. The two flames met.

She braced for one to swallow the other. Neither did. They became a single flame, white shot through with flickers of a black so pure it had no shine to it at all, and it burned brighter than either had burned alone, and the two streams went on feeding it side by side, light and dark, balanced, whole.

"It should be impossible," she said. "One should win."

Only if they are at war with each other. They are not. They are two halves of one thing, and a thing is not at war with itself unless someone has taught it to be. He let the flame go out. That is the secret your people lost when they lost the dark. Not the dark alone. The balance. Everything you do with one side, little one, you can do better with both. Now. He looked at her. Your turn. Do not make fire. Only call them up, dark to your left hand, light to your right, and hold them ready, and do not let either one go out.

* * *

She got it wrong for a week.

That was the part the histories never told you, she thought, lying awake some nights with her hands still tingling from the effort: that the extraordinary was mostly

failure, patiently repeated. The paintings on the school walls showed light mages at the height of their powers, calling down fire, holding back floods, their faces serene. No one painted the years of guttered flames and torn nerves and sitting in the dark feeling stupid that came first. She was beginning to think that was the real difference between the people on the walls and everyone else: not that they had never failed, but that they had failed long enough, and privately enough, to come out the other side.

The first night her dark flame went out the instant she lit the light one, as though she could only attend to one child at a time. The second night she held them both, and then, reaching to bring them together as Lor-ar had, lost her grip on both at once and sat there with empty hands while a tiger watched her with the infinite patience of a creature who had nowhere else to be for the next two hundred years. The third night something tore a little when she pushed too hard, a small bright pain behind her sternum, sharp enough that she gasped, and Lor-ar was on his feet at once and made her stop, and would not let her begin again that night for anything.

You forget what you spent, calling me, he said, more gently than usual. And what you spent again, the night the egg hatched. You are not a bottomless thing, little one, whatever the size of your core. The hearth is large, but a fire still goes out if you throw the whole woodpile on it at once. Slowly. We have time. Of all the things you and I have, time is the one we have most of.

You are trying to force it, he said, the way your people force everything, with the will, because the will is all they were left. You do not need to force it. You need only to ask the two halves to do what they already wish to do, which is to be together. They have been kept apart your whole life. They are very glad to be asked.

After that it came easier. By the end of the week she could hold both, light over the right hand and dark over the left,

steady, for as long as she liked, and bring them together into the one bright balanced flame, and let them part again. Lor-ar watched her do it on the seventh night and said nothing for a while, which from Lor-ar was high praise.

Good, he said at last. Now we may begin the part that matters. The fire was only to teach your hands. The thing I am going to teach you next is the thing your people would kill to keep buried, and would kill you for knowing. He settled. Magic is a language. It has always been a language. And you are going to learn to read it.

* * *

Alice found out on the ninth night, because Alice found out everything eventually.

She came down to the fountain in her nightclothes and her pink wool socks with a book under her arm and the particular braced look of someone who has worked herself up to a thing all day and means to say it before the nerve runs out. "I know you come out here," she said. "I'm not daft. You think I sleep through you climbing out the window? I've just been letting you have your secret, because that's what you do, you let people have their things. But I lie there awake every night now wondering, and I'd rather you tell me to go away than wonder, so." She sat down on the end of the bench, decided, and folded her hands. "Tell me to go away."

Viridia looked at her. She thought about all the things she could not tell her: the dragons, the pact, the size of her own core, the wound in Alice's own chest that Alice would never feel. And she thought about the thing she could.

"I'm not going to tell you to go away," she said. "I'm going to teach you to see."

She did what Lor-ar had done to her, that first morning. She put her hand gently over Alice's eyes, and reached up both halves of herself, and coated Alice's eyes with light and

dark together the way she had been taught, and then she took her hand away and said, "Open them."

Alice opened her eyes, and the world caught fire, and Alice made a sound Viridia would remember for a long time.

"Oh," Alice breathed. "Oh, *Viridia*." She turned her head, slowly, taking in the burning grass and the lit fountain and the great blazing shape of Lor-ar, and her whole face had opened into the helpless wonder that was simply how she met everything good, and there were tears standing in her eyes, and she did not bother to hide them, because Alice never hid anything. "It's *alive*. All of it. The whole world's *alive* and nobody told us." She pressed both hands to her mouth. "How long does it last? Can I always, will I always be able to..."

"Only while I keep it on you," Viridia said. "A few hours. But there's another way. A way you can learn, so you don't need me to do it. It's harder. But you can."

"Teach me," Alice said at once, the way the best of her always came out, all in a rush with nothing held back. "Teach me everything. I don't care how hard it is. *Teach me*."

* * *

So Alice joined the night lessons, and the strange thing was how much better it went, with two of them.

Lor-ar took to her at once, in his dry way, and complained about it constantly, which was how Viridia knew. *Your friend asks better questions than you do*, he informed Viridia, *because she does not pretend to already understand. It is restful. You should try not understanding things aloud more often*. Alice could not hold the twin flames the way Viridia could; she had only the one half, the light, and that was the plain limit of her, and she met it without bitterness, the way she met everything. But she did not need the flames for the part that mattered. She needed the language, and the language did not care

which half you carried, only whether you could call the right shape to your mind fast enough to mean it.

And here was the wonder of it, the thing that made Viridia stay up too late and pay too little attention in her daytime classes. The language was real. It was old, older than the dragons themselves, and it had a name, and a people. Lor-ar told her on the eleventh night, while Alice traced a shape over and over in the dust until it sat right.

"They were called the Moravians," he said. "They are gone now, all of them, so long gone that even I can only find the edges of them when I walk in the past. But they were the first, as far as I or the dragons have ever learned, to do a thing no people had done before. They listened to magic until they understood that it was speaking, and then they wrote down what it said." He let that settle. "Every other people who ever worked magic has been shouting at it in a language it does not speak, and forcing it, by sheer will, to roughly do as they meant. The Moravians learned its own words. With the words you do not force anything. You simply say the true thing, and magic, which has been waiting an age to be addressed properly, does exactly and only what you asked."

It was not a figure of speech. She understood that better with every shape she learned. A focus, she saw now, was a translator and a crude one: you fed it your will and your wish for fire, and it did the rough work of turning that into something magic could obey, and it took a portion of the meaning in the trade, the way every translation does. The shapes took nothing. The shape for fire did not approximate fire. It was the word *fire*, in the tongue the thing itself answered to, and when she set it in her mind and let her magic run into it the fire came clean and exact and entirely hers.

She learned the shape for growth first, because Lor-ar said the gentle ones were safest to fail at. She drew it for Alice in the dirt by the fountain, and Alice, who could not hold the twin flames but could hold a shape as well as anyone, learned it too. The next morning in Mrs. Zoran's class Alice coaxed a dead twig into putting out a single green leaf without touching her star focus once, and looked across the room at Viridia with her eyes shining, and Viridia had to study the grain of her own desk for a moment to keep her face in order.

Once, on the fourteenth night, Lor-ar broke off a lesson mid-shape and stood, ears forward, facing out past the treeline, and would not say what he had heard. Viridia turned the sight that way and found, far off past the forest, the same low greyness she had glimpsed from the assembly window weeks before, a thinning in the living threads of the land. Only it was not where it had been. Weeks ago it had sat behind the third ridge, a smudge at the limit of seeing. Now it had come forward to the second. She could measure it against the hills the way you measure a tide against a post, and the measuring was worse than the sight of it. "It's nearer," she said. "Two ridges nearer than the last time." Lor-ar's tail went still. *It moves faster than it did*, he said, and that word, *faster*, was the one that stayed with her, because it meant the thing had a speed, and a speed could be counted, and a thing you could count was a thing that would, on some particular day she did not yet know the number of, arrive. *What is it*, she asked, because for the first time it had a fixed mark and was no longer only a smudge she could doubt. He was a long moment answering, and when he did, he gave the thing a name, which was worse than no answer, because a name made it real. *Your kind has a word for it now, where there is anyone left to say words. The Hollowing.* He did not look away from the dark rim of the world. *Where the war has been hard*

and long, the living threads do not merely break. They are drawn out, drunk down, until the land has no thread left in it at all and nothing will grow and nothing will answer a shape. An emptiness with an edge, and the edge moves. That is what walks toward us, ridge by ridge. He would say no more than that, only: *Mind your shape. We have less time than the spring would have you believe.* She took it in, and the lesson went on, but the ease had gone out of the night.

There were harder shapes, and dangerous ones, and Lor-ar doled those out slowly and would not be hurried. The hardest was not a shape at all but a use of one: setting a shape not into the air, where it spent itself at once, but *onto a thing*, so that it stayed. *A shape in the air is a word spoken*, he told her. *A shape laid into an object is a word written. It waits. It keeps. A focus is only an object somebody once wrote patience into.* He had her practise on a flat river-stone, drawing the gentle warming-shape onto its face with a fingertip wet in light, so that the stone held a low heat for an hour after she had walked away. It was finicky, exacting work, slower than anything in the air, because a written word that came out wrong did not simply gutter and vanish; it sat on the object and meant the wrong thing until you scraped it off.

She learned that the hard way. On the nineteenth night she tried to lay the warming-shape onto the iron bench-arm instead of a stone, impatient, hurrying it, and got one stroke of the shape inverted, and the iron did not warm. It went cold, a deep, drinking cold that bit straight through her sleeve and numbed two fingers to the knuckle before she snatched her hand back. The numbness did not lift that night. It did not lift in the morning. For nine days she could not feel the pads of two fingers, and had to watch her own hand when she held a pen, and Lor-ar, who did not often say *I told you*, did not need to. *The air forgives*, he said. *The object remembers. Remember that it remembers.* The feeling came

back, in the end, in a slow prickling tide. But she had learned, in a way no warning would have taught her, that a shape written onto a thing was a different and graver order of magic than a shape thrown into the dark, and she set the lesson with the rest, on the long and growing list kept for a later she was beginning to suspect would not be a comfortable one.

There was, too, a shape Lor-ar would draw and then rub out at once, every time, and would not teach her, and would not name, and when she pressed him he only said *not yet, and perhaps not ever, and certainly not until you have learned that some words are easier to say than to call back*. She filed that away as well.

* * *

Two weeks after he hatched, Raizen spoke.

He had been growing fast, half the size of Drake already, though he kept to a smaller form most of the day and rode her shoulder out of preference rather than need. Viridia had felt him at the edge of her mind for days, the wordless warmth of the bond beginning to gather itself toward something. And then one night by the fountain, while she was struggling with a shape she could not get to sit still in her head, a voice arrived in her mind that was not Lor-ar's: younger, warmer, pleased with itself.

You are doing it wrong, Raizen said. *You are thinking the shape. You should be remembering it.*

Viridia stopped dead. Alice, beside her, had not heard it; it had come down the bond, hers alone. "Raizen?"

Yes. A pause, and then, with the unmistakable delight of a creature trying out a new toy: *I can talk now. I have your memories, did you know? From the bond. So I already know how to. It is very strange, having someone else's words in my mouth before I have grown the mouth properly*. The small head tipped against

her jaw. *You give the shapes too much effort. They are in you already, the way they are in me. Stop building them. Just recall them, the way you recall your own name.*

She tried it that way. She stopped reaching to construct the shape and simply let it surface, the way a memory surfaces when you stop chasing it, and it came up whole and sat still and held, and the magic ran into it clean, and she laughed out loud in the dark with the sheer ease of it.

How do you know that, she asked him, *if you're two weeks old?*

I told you. I have your memories, the ones that came down the bond. And dragons are born already knowing the language; it is in our blood, the way knowing how to fly is, even before the wings are strong enough. A pause, pleased. *So I have your memories and my own knowing, both at once, which means I am, for the moment, cleverer than you. I expect it will not last. Enjoy it with me while it does.*

Lor-ar's whiskers moved. *Two weeks out of the shell,* he said, *and already a better teacher than I am on that one particular point. It is intolerable. I have been alive three hundred years and a hatchling has corrected me.* But there was pride under it, the warm exasperated pride of an old creature watching a young one do well, and Raizen preened shamelessly, and Alice, who had heard none of it, asked what on earth was so funny. When Viridia told her *Raizen can talk now*, Alice shrieked with delight and clapped both hands over her mouth and woke, by the sound of the lamp that came on, at least one indignant girl in the west wing.

* * *

The day-scenes went on around the night ones, the way the ordinary world insists on going on.

Viridia saw less of Alice in the daylight now, and the seeing-less had its own small ache to it, the hairline gap she had first felt the night Alice got her sponsor widening,

gently, into a settled fact of life. Alice spent her free hours in the medical wing, and Viridia spent hers in the library reading things she was not strictly meant to, and they met at the ends of days, two lives that had briefly been one learning to run alongside each other instead.

One afternoon Viridia went and found her there, because she missed her, and stood in the doorway of the long bright ward and watched Alice work before Alice saw her. It was not glamorous work. There was a child with a fever that no spell could quite break, and Alice was sitting with her, wringing out a cloth in cold water and laying it on the small hot forehead and talking, low, the steady inconsequential stream of talk that was Alice's truest gift, naming the things in the room one by one to give the fever something to follow that was not itself. The child's eyes tracked Alice's voice. The healers came and went with their focuses and their bright workings, and did the parts that magic could do, and Alice did the part it could not, which was to be a warm voice in the room so that no one had to be ill alone.

Viridia did not go in. She stood there a while, and went back to her library, and thought about it for a long time.

That evening Alice came back later than usual and sat on the edge of her bed without taking her shoes off. "The man from the coast died this morning," she said. She said it plainly, and the plainness was its own held thing; Viridia recognized the shape of it, having a great deal of that shape herself. "The one with the burns. The healers had done everything there was to do, days ago. There wasn't any more magic for it. So at the end it was just sitting." She looked at her hands. "His own people couldn't reach here in time. So it was me. I held his hand." A silence. "I'm glad it was me. Is that a strange thing to be glad of? I keep thinking it must be. But I am. I'm glad he wasn't on his own."

Viridia looked at her friend, at the steady pale candle that Alice would never know was only half of what she might once have been, and understood, with a clarity that hurt, that whatever the old severing had taken from Alice it had not laid a finger on the best thing in her, the thing that sat with a dying stranger so he would not have to make that particular crossing by himself. There were whole and broken, she thought, and then there was *this*, which the world's accounting had no column for at all.

"It isn't strange," Viridia said. "It's the least strange thing I've ever heard." She paused, and gave Alice a piece of the truth she did not give often, because it was true and because Alice had earned it. "I think you might be the best person I know."

Alice went pink to the ears and told her to shut up, fondly, and hid her face in the green book she had brought, the way she did when a feeling got too large to sit still under, and the moment lifted before it could turn heavy, which was its own kind of gift, the lifting.

And Mrs. Zoran stayed after class one afternoon, and shut the door, and said, with her frizzy hair and her too-big red dress and her glasses pushed up, "I do not think you need this class, Miss Saeren."

Viridia had been waiting for it. She glanced at Lor-ar, curled in cat-shape on the desk. *How much*, she asked him silently. *Everything you wish*, he said, *but nothing of the pact or the dragons' kind*. So Viridia took out her notebook, and drew the shape for growth, and the two shapes that limited it, and explained them, while Mrs. Zoran leaned against her desk and watched with a face that grew slowly more astonished and more hungry. "Our magic is a language," Viridia said. "An old one. If you learn it, you don't need the focus at all. You write your intent directly. It's how I've gotten ahead."

Mrs. Zoran looked at the shapes on the page for a long time.

"Knowledge is power," she said, very low now, the same words she had said the day she risked herself to read Viridia's focus aloud. "I have spent my whole life teaching girls to push their magic through a crutch because no one ever told me there was a pen." She looked up, and there were tears in her eyes too, but different from Alice's, the tears of a person shown, late in life, a thing she could have spent that life loving. "Show me. Show me how to make one."

She got it wrong for a week, the same as Viridia had, and there was something both funny and moving in watching a grown woman fail at the thing in exactly the same order a fourteen-year-old had failed at it. She cursed, quietly, in a way Viridia had not known teachers could. She came in some mornings hollow-eyed from staying up at it. Once she nearly wept with frustration, and caught herself, and said, "Listen to me. Forty-six and crying over a houseplant," and laughed instead, and went back to it.

And then one morning Viridia came into class early and found Mrs. Zoran already there, a pot on her desk, and in the pot a flower that had not been there the day before, small and red and entirely ordinary, and Mrs. Zoran standing over it with her hands shaking and her face wet and lit from within.

"I did it," she whispered. "No focus. I took the ring off and put it in the drawer and I just held the shape in my mind, the way you showed me, and I told the magic the true thing, and it..." Her voice broke. She laughed, a wet astonished laugh that had a whole life in it. "I'm forty-six years old. I have been a mage since I was eleven. And I have just, this morning, in an empty classroom, spoken to my own magic in its own language for the first time. Do you know what that's like? It's like discovering, in middle age, that you'd

been mouthing the words to a song you never actually knew, your whole life, and someone has finally told you what it means."

She wiped her face with the heel of her hand, and looked at the flower, and then she straightened, and Viridia saw the change come over her, the same fierce decided thing she had seen only once before, the day Mrs. Zoran had risked herself to read a dark mage's inscription aloud.

"I'm going to teach the class," she said. "All of them. Every girl who comes through this room. They have a right to their own language and nobody ever gave it to them, and I have spent twenty years handing them crutches and calling it walking." Her jaw set. "Lady Lightwell will let me; she lets me a great deal, that woman, more than I think either of us has ever quite said out loud. And if it disturbs somebody's comfort in the capital, then it disturbs it. Knowledge is power, Miss Saeren. I've said those words to you twice now. It's past time I started living as though I believed them."

* * *

Amber came back from a job at the end of that week, and Viridia knew before she said anything that it had gone wrong, because Amber, who could make a face do whatever she asked it to, had not bothered to ask anything of it at all.

She found Viridia by the fountain after dark, which she had never done before; the night lessons were Viridia's secret and Amber's gift not to ask about, and the breaking of that custom was itself a kind of message. She sat on the bench without a joke ready.

"There was nearly a killing," she said. "In the capital. A dark mage, a baker, three children, never harmed anyone in his life, got named to the magistrates by a neighbour, and the decree was drawn up, and it went all the way to the desk for signing." She turned her pale focus-stone over and over

in her fingers. "It didn't get signed. Somebody on the council lost their nerve at the last, or found a conscience, or counted votes and didn't like the sum. The man's alive. They let him go. This time."

"And if they hadn't," Viridia said.

"Then it would have been the next sanctioned killing." Amber looked at her, and the deflection that armoured her every other hour of the day was simply not there. "You weren't in the office when Lightwell laid it out, so I'll tell you the way she told me. Jazen has sworn that the next time the capital kills one of us by decree, he stops asking for peace. He's said it plainly, to people who carry his words. One signature. That's the whole of the distance left. It came that close this week, and nobody who matters even broke a sweat over how close. They'll draw up the next one. They always do." She stood. "I tell you because you should be training like it's coming, not like it's a story. It nearly came today. It will come on some ordinary Tuesday nobody's marked on a calendar, and the only question worth anything is how ready we are when it does."

She went back toward the dark school. Viridia sat a while longer with the cold fact of it: that the war was not a horizon after all. It was a number, and the number was one, and the count had very nearly reached it while she was learning to warm a river-stone. After that the shapes she practised did not feel like wonders anymore. They felt like a race.

* * *

It was late spring by then, and Viridia had not noticed it arriving, which was itself a kind of news.

She noticed it on a night walk, after a lesson, when Alice was talking. She was always talking, on the walks back, the day's small overflow pouring out of her, this time about something inconsequential, a girl in the medical wing who

had named all the cabinets, and a thing the head nurse had said, and how the windows there fogged up in a particular way in the mornings. Nothing. The kind of ordinary nothing that two people who live together share at the end of a day. And Alice said something, Viridia could never afterward remember exactly what, only that it was small and silly and perfectly timed, and Viridia laughed.

She laughed the way she had not laughed since the morning the world ended.

It broke out of her without her deciding, real and helpless and surprising, and it ran on longer than the joke deserved, and somewhere in the middle of it she understood what was happening to her and nearly stopped from the strangeness of it. She was laughing. In the dark, on the lawn, with a tiger pacing ahead and a dragon on her shoulder and her one friend grinning at her, she was laughing, easily, the way she had used to laugh at her father's burnt toast, the way she had thought, in the cold house, in the first weeks, she would never do again.

The grief was still there. It would always be there; she had stopped expecting it to leave, and there was a kind of peace even in that, in no longer waking each morning to the small fresh shock of it being true. But it had shifted to one side, a little, and made space. She had believed, in the cold house, that loss filled a person edge to edge and left no room for anything else, ever. She had been wrong, the way she was learning she had been wrong about a great many things she had been told. A person could laugh on a spring lawn at a friend's silly joke, and the laughing did not betray the dead. That was the thing no one had told her. It did not betray them at all.

She thought of her mother, suddenly, and of how her mother had laughed, rarely, but fully, the whole of her face giving way to it. She thought her mother would have liked

Alice. The tiger, the dragon, the language, Mrs. Zoran weeping over her flower — her mother would have liked all of it. The thought did not hurt the way it would have a month ago. It sat warm, alongside the grief, in the room the grief had made.

She was healing. She let herself, for one whole night, know it: a tiger and a dragon and a language and a friend and a teacher who had wept over a flower, a strange life assembled in the dark, underneath the grief and alongside it and not instead of it.

She kept the greyness on the second ridge out of her mind, and Amber's *one signature, that's the whole of the distance left*, with it. Not tonight. She had spent the worst weeks of her life arriving at a place where she had something to lose again, and she meant to have one night of it before she counted the cost.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Dangris

"There is a people," Lor-ar said, "who were born with only the light, and who never once minded it."

They were in the clearing the dragons had cleared for them, a wide bare ring deep in the forest where Drake and Varissa had torn out the trees and scorched the ground flat, a place to train where no window could see. The nights had turned warmer. Viridia sat on the grass at the clearing's edge in her training clothes, the soft black trousers and the sleeveless shirt, with Raizen stretched out beside her, larger now, nearly the size of a pony, his prismatic scales throwing back the moonlight in shifting colors. Lor-ar paced before them in his full shape, which he did when he was about to teach something he thought important.

"Only the light," Viridia said. She turned it over. "Then they're." She stopped herself before the word *broken*, because she had stopped using it, even in her head, about people who had no idea they were missing anything. "Then they only have the one half."

"They have the one half, and they were made with the one half, the way the small beasts were, and so there is no wound in it. The Dangris were never severed. They were simply made light, all of them, from the beginning of their kind." His tail swept the grass. "I find them interesting for that reason. Your people lost the dark and grieve it without

knowing they grieve. The Dangris never had it and have built, with the one half, a whole and savage and entirely contented life. There is a lesson in them about what a creature does with what it is given, rather than mourning what it was not." He showed his teeth. "Also they are the finest fighters I have ever seen, and they have agreed to train you, and you are going to need it."

"You almost sound as though you admire them," Viridia said.

"I do admire them. It is possible to admire a thing and to know it would gut you in a heartbeat if the season turned; the two are not in conflict, whatever your gentler poets pretend." He paced. "I admire that they do not waste themselves wishing to be other than they are. Your people spend a great deal of grief on a missing half most of them cannot even name. The Dangris spend none. They took what they were given and they sharpened it to a point, every one of them, and they are happier for it than any people I know, in the savage way of a creature that long ago made its peace with its own nature." He glanced at her. "There is a thing in that worth your learning, beyond the spear. But the spear first."

"Train me to do what?"

Lor-ar looked at her steadily in the moonlight.

"To stay alive," he said, "in the war your Headmistress has already told you is coming. Magic is a great deal, little one. It is not everything. There will be moments when your magic is spent, or bound, or simply too slow, and in those moments what stands between you and the dark will be your two hands and whatever is in them. I would rather you learned that here, from teachers, than later, from an enemy." He turned his head toward the trees. "They are here, in any case. They have been here some while, watching

you sit and talk instead of standing and working. They are too polite to say so. They are not too polite to think it loudly."

* * *

She heard them before she saw them, though only just. It was not the sound of people moving through a wood; it was the absence of the small sounds the wood made on its own. The night insects to the right went quiet in a slow travelling hush, and a bird that had been complaining somewhere in the dark stopped complaining, and then there was a smell on the warm air she did not know, dry and faintly metallic, like sun-baked stone and old iron, and only then, last of all, the soft give of pine needles under weight.

They came out of the pines to the right, six of them, and Viridia got to her feet without being told.

They were the first creatures she had seen that wore a human shape and were plainly not human. They stood between six and seven feet, broad and long-limbed, and from the neck down a person glancing quickly might have taken them for very tall men. But their eyes were wrong, the pupils set vertical in them, slit like a cat's; and where a nose should have been there were only two slits that flared and shivered when they breathed; and their mouths, when they opened, were full of teeth filed each to its own point, so that a smile from a Dangris was a thing that asked the viewer to be brave about it. With the mana-sight Viridia saw the cores in their chests, and they were the purest light she had ever seen, white and spinning fast, light-side only and brilliant with it, no shadow anywhere in them.

The one at their head had pupils blown so wide there was almost no white left around them. He looked at Lor-ar and spoke, a harsh guttural rush of a language Viridia could not begin to follow, and then he pointed at her with one long finger and waited.

Lor-ar inclined his head.

The leader turned to Viridia. "My name is Nargash," he said, in a thick rough accent that she had to lean into to catch. "Your companion has told the Kor-toh of your training, and of the war you ready yourself for. The Dangris have always loved war." His companions, at the word, struck their own chests twice with closed fists and called out two low syllables together, *Kor-toh, Kor-toh*, and went still again. "My tribe has won many fights this season. So it was given to us, the honor of training the true-bonded of a dragon." He bowed his head, fractionally, toward Raizen, who lifted his own head and returned it, grave as a lord.

Then Nargash barked a word, and one of the others stepped forward carrying a long bundle wrapped in dark cloth. He laid it on the grass before Viridia and unwound it and stepped back.

Four short spears lay on the cloth. They were beautiful, and she knew enough now to see how beautiful: the black wood of the hafts was carved its whole length with the same fine scrollwork that ran down her own focus, and the heads were a metal she half-recognized, dense and grey and patterned with fine waves through the steel, watered, layered. Damascus. She had read of it. The strongest and hardest metal there was, and the rarest, and the most difficult to work, so that a single Damascus blade was a thing a fighter might own once in a life and never twice.

There were four of them, lying on the grass, for her. She crouched and lifted one, and the balance of it astonished her. It sat in her hand as though it had been weighed and made to her exact measure, the haft warm from the carrying, the watered grey head catching the moon. It did not feel like a thing she had been handed. It felt like a thing that had waited for her, which was the second object in a

month to give her that feeling, and she did not much like what the pattern might mean.

"I thank you," Viridia said, and the thanks was real, and the size of the gift made her clumsy with it. "This is too much. I'm not skilled enough for weapons like these. I'd shame them."

Nargash laughed. It was a startling sound, harsh and loud and entirely delighted, ringing off the rock at the clearing's edge.

"That is why we are here," he said. "Magic cannot do all things, dragon-friend. You must learn to fight with every tool you carry." He touched his own chest, where the white core spun. "Not only this. This." He touched his temple. "And these," and he held up his two long hands. "Take one up. We will see what you do not know, which is most of it, and then we will teach you. Go there." He pointed a few yards off, to the open center of the ring. "Stand. And do not be afraid of the spear. It is only afraid of you if you are afraid of it first."

* * *

She had read a book on the spear, in the library, on one of the long afternoons. She knew the names of the stances and a handful of the forms, the way a person who has read about swimming knows the names of the strokes. She found out within the first minute what that was worth.

It was not Nargash who tested her. He sent forward another, who introduced himself with a small bow as Venquar and drew a short spear of his own from his back, and set his feet, and beckoned her on. Viridia took the guard stance she had read about, point angled down, weight loose, and circled him, looking for the opening the book had promised would appear.

There was no opening. She lunged left and stabbed right, a feint and a strike, exactly as the book described, and

Venquar turned the spearhead aside with a flick of his own haft so casually that she felt the contempt in it even though there was none in his face.

"Again," he said.

She came again, and again, thrusting and recovering, trying the forms she knew in every order she could think of. Venquar deflected all of it without seeming to move his feet. And then, between one breath and the next, he stopped being patient. He struck like wire and lightning. The spearhead opened a clean hot line down her right forearm before she saw it move. She flinched. The butt of his haft cracked across her thigh. She stumbled back gasping, two wounds she had not felt coming, the pain arriving a half-second behind the blood.

She had never been cut before. Not really. She stood there with her own blood running warm down her arm and her leg throbbing and her breath ragged, and she understood, in a way no book and no lesson could have taught her, that this was real, that the war Lor-ar kept naming would feel like this, that someone would one day try to do this to her in earnest and not stop at a line down the arm.

And then, under the fear, something else got up off the floor of her and stood. She had spent her whole life folding things down small and holding them. She was good at holding. She wiped the blood out of the crook of her elbow with the heel of her hand, and set her feet, and went back at Venquar with the held thing burning steady behind her ribs.

* * *

She still could not beat him. He was decades faster and a lifetime more practiced, and she knew it. But she stopped trying to win and started trying to *land one*, which was a smaller and more honest goal, and she watched him the way

she watched everything, hunting the small wrong thing, the tell, the habit a body keeps without knowing it keeps it.

It took everything she had to find it. Venquar gave nothing away that he did not choose to; his face was as still as the rock behind him, his breathing even, and against his speed she was always a half-step behind, defending and never threatening, her arms burning, her hands stinging from the shock of haft on haft. Twice more he opened her skin, small stinging lines, paying her for her slowness in the only currency that taught. Sweat ran into her eyes. Her shoulders screamed. She kept watching.

And on the fourth real exchange she saw it: a habit so small that only a mind that could not stop cataloguing would ever have caught it. Before a true thrust to the left, Venquar's eyes flicked right, a hair's breadth, half an instant, a lie his face told that his intention could not help but tell first. He had done it before the cut on her arm. He had done it before the bruise on her thigh. He did not know he did it; she was nearly sure of that.

So the fifth time, when his eyes flicked right, she did not believe them. She committed everything to the left a half-beat before the thrust came, inside its reach, and not with the point, because she had no wish to truly wound a teacher who had spent an hour teaching her, she rolled the haft flat in her hands at the last instant and brought the long side of it cracking across the side of his face.

She heard it connect. She saw a flicker of real pain cross Venquar's features, there and gone. They both stepped back. Venquar put a hand to his mouth and spat, and into his palm came a single pointed tooth, with a thread of blood.

For a frozen moment Viridia thought she had given grave offense.

Then Venquar looked at the tooth in his hand, and looked at her, and made a sound that, after a startled instant,

turned out to be laughter. "Not bad," he said, around the new gap in his teeth, and there was nothing in it but pleasure. "Not bad at all, dragon-friend."

"Enough," Nargash said, stepping forward, and there was satisfaction in it. "Now we know what to make of you. Now we begin properly. Guard stance, as Venquar showed you. We will go slowly. You will watch the body."

For the next hour they took her apart and built her back. They came at her one at a time and then two, slow at first, letting her see the movements whole: how a foot drawn back meant a lunge was loading; how a glance one way and a weight-shift the other was a lie the body told before the spear did; how the truth of an attack lived not in the weapon but in the hips and the shoulders and the set of the feet, which could not lie even when the face did. *Always watch the body*, Nargash said, again and again, until it stopped being instruction and became something nearer to instinct. *The weapon will deceive you. The body cannot. It will tell you everything, if you have the patience to read it.*

It was the hardest hour of work she had ever done, harder than anything magic had asked of her, because magic at least lived inside her and answered to her, and this was her own slow stubborn body being asked to learn a new way of being in the world. They drilled the guard stance until her thighs shook holding it. They made her repeat a single block, the same block, fifty times, a hundred, until Nargash stopped barking corrections at it, which she came to understand was the highest praise the Dangris gave. They came at her two at once, slowly, and she learned the particular terror of having to watch two bodies at the same time and the particular small triumph of managing it, once, for three exchanges, before Venquar's haft tapped her ribs to tell her she had let him out of her sight.

They gradually sped up. By the end of the hour she was reading the lunges before they came, not all of them, not most of them, but more than none, and the more-than-none felt like a door opening onto a room she had never suspected was there. She was clumsy and slow and would be for a long time. But she was no longer entirely blind, and the difference between blind and clumsy, she was learning, was the whole of the distance between dead and alive.

It was Nargash who killed the drill mid-stroke.

He did not call a halt; he simply stopped, his haft frozen at the top of an arc, his slit nostrils flaring wide, and every Dangris in the ring froze with him in the same instant, the way a flock turns without a signal. Then his hand came down flat through the air and the moonlit clearing went dark and silent. Raizen's glow snuffed out. Lor-ar dropped to his belly in the scorched grass. Viridia found herself pulled down behind the rock at the clearing's edge with a long grey hand flat between her shoulder blades, holding her there, and over the rock she heard it: voices. Men's voices, off in the trees to the north, and the jingle of harness, and the wet crunch of horses picking their way through undergrowth that was not a path.

"Patrol," Venquar breathed, so close to her ear it was barely sound at all. "Capital colours. They do not come this deep. They are coming this deep."

She lay with her cheek against cold stone and counted them by ear, the way she counted everything: four horses, perhaps five, moving slow, the careful slow of men who were looking for something and had not yet decided it was here. A lantern swung somewhere through the trees and threw long shadows out across the clearing's edge, close enough that she watched the light crawl up the rock a hand's width from her face and stop. A voice said something she could not catch. Another laughed, low. The horses moved on. The

lantern-light slid back down the rock and went away through the pines, north, the way it had come, and the wood's small sounds came creeping back one by one as the men took their noise with them.

No one moved for a long time after the last hoofbeat had faded.

"They have never come past the old ridge before," Nargash said at last, rising, and his voice had lost its earlier delight entirely. "Tell your Headmistress. The line where the soldiers stop has moved. It moves the way the Hollowing on the rim moves, and behind soldiers the Hollowing comes." He looked at Viridia in the dark, slit pupils wide. "You train as though the war is six weeks off. It walked within a spear's throw of you tonight. Train as though it is here." Then, because he was Nargash, and because the Dangris did not let a hard thing sit without a harder joke beside it: "Also you were too slow getting behind the rock. A patrol would have had you. We will work on that."

* * *

When the Dangris left, they did it the way they had come, all at once and almost soundlessly, melting back into the dark of the pines. Nargash paused at the tree line.

"You do your teachers proud," he said, and bowed to Lor-ar, and then, more shallowly but unmistakably, to Viridia herself. "We will come again." And then they were gone, and the clearing was only a clearing in the moonlight, and Viridia's whole body was beginning, now that the work had stopped, to catalogue its own damage.

She sat down hard against Raizen's flank, against the warm hard wall of his scales, and let the trembling in her arms have its way for a moment.

"You did well," Raizen said, the new voice warm in her head and aloud both at once, for he could do either now. "You hit Venquar. He did not expect that. None of them did."

"I think I just got lucky." She looked at the long cut down her forearm, beading red, and the spreading bruise blooming dark across her thigh, and was distantly surprised at how little either of them frightened her now that the fight was over. An hour ago her own blood had been a shock. Now it was only information, a record of what she had got wrong, written on her in a hand she was learning to read.

"You watched the body," Raizen said. "That is not luck. Luck does not look for the feint twice and remember it. Luck does not study a thing until it gives up its secret. You did that. You have always done that, with everything, since before you ever held a spear. It is the same thing you do to a room when you walk into it, and to a person when they lie to you. You only put a weapon in your hand and called it fighting." He nosed at her injured arm, gently. "Anything that keeps you alive is worth doing. Even getting cut, if the cut teaches you. Even losing, if you lose the right way."

"You sound like Lor-ar."

"I have his sense and your memories and my own temper, which is better than either of yours. It is a very wise combination, and slightly smug, I am told. I am wasted on a shoulder." There was a smile in it, the dragon's particular dry warmth, and despite the pain Viridia felt her own mouth answer it.

She set her hand over the cut on her arm, and called up the shape for healing, the one Alice was learning too over in the bright ward, and fed her magic through it. The skin drew itself together under her palm, the parted edges knitting, the bleeding slowing and stopping; she felt the strange deep itch of muscle closing, and then it was a thin pink line and then it was only a smear of dried blood over whole skin. She did the

same for her thigh, breathing through the odd discomfort of healing a deep bruise from the inside, until the throb faded and the leg was her own again. She was careful, now, to leave nothing. A single faint pink line she could not quite close had cost her an awkward lie to Alice last week — *caught it on a hedge*, which Alice had let lie the way she let everything lie, but which had sat badly in Viridia all the same, because the list of things she was keeping from the one person who told her everything was getting longer, and each new lie made the next one easier, and that ease was the part she did not like. She healed the leg until there was nothing left to explain. The not-leaving-marks was, she had begun to understand, its own kind of spear-work: a discipline she was learning because the alternative was being found out.

"Damascus," Raizen said, watching the spears where they lay. "It's nearly the only metal that can cut me. My scales, I mean. They overlap, so it is not as bad for me as a cut is for you, but it can be done, with that. The Dangris prize it above everything they own. A single spear is a thing a warrior earns over years, a mark of standing in the tribe." He let it sit. "They gave you four. Do you understand what that means? They have honored you the way they would honor a war-leader of their own. They do not do that for cleverness, or for a dragon on your shoulder. They do it for the cut you took without complaint and the one you gave back."

* * *

When she had healed herself and her hands had steadied, Lor-ar came and sat in front of her, and she knew from the set of him that the night's first lesson was not finished, only changed.

"While the Dangris taught your hands," he said, "I will go on teaching your head. A fighter who can read a body and not a battle is a sharp knife in a fool's grip. So." He settled.

"Tell me what you know of how your army fights. Their habits. Their advantages. The shape of them."

So she told him what she had, the things from Mr. Cote's dry books and the things she had gathered in the library on the restricted floors and the things Lady Lightwell had said in the warded office. That most dark mages could not touch the elements at all, only spirit, the death-trait, which every dark mage carried; and that this gave the light-mage army the open advantage, fire and stone and lightning theirs to throw while the resistance had to fight some other way.

"And what other way," Lor-ar pressed. "If they cannot answer fire with fire."

"Spirit's in everything," Viridia said slowly, thinking it through as she said it. "To a degree. In the ground, in the dark, in the dead. So they've learned to use that. To work on the properties of things. And stealth. The short shadow-walk, to move between cover where the light mages can't follow. They can't go far with it, only as far as they can see, into a shadow, but it makes them very hard to pin down." She frowned. "Their whole strength is that you can't find them and you can't predict them. And." She hesitated, because it was the thing the light mages spoke of with real fear. "If a dark mage is powerful enough, they can raise the dead. Not many. Not for long, mostly. But the strongest ones can."

"Do you know how to kill a thing that has been raised?" Lor-ar asked. "Truly raised, and standing."

Viridia ran through everything she had read, and came up empty, and said so.

"Pure life-fire, carried on spirit," Lor-ar said. "The light to fill the dead thing with life it cannot hold, and the spirit to draw it back across the veil after. One half will not do it. It needs both, which is why almost no one alive can do it, and why you should remember it, and tell no one that you can."

He let her sit with that. "Now. The army uses life-fire freely. It is their favorite cruelty. Do you know its flaw?"

"It's stronger than ordinary fire," Viridia said. "It drains you more to throw it, but it hits harder, it..." She stopped. Something turned over in her, the cataloguing part finding a shape it liked. "It stays connected. To the caster. Until the flame goes out. That's why it costs so much to throw. The mage is still feeding it the whole time it burns."

"And what does that mean," Lor-ar said quietly, "for the mage, while the flame still burns?"

"It means their core is open," Viridia said. The realization arrived cold and clean. "While they're holding the fire on me, there's a thread running back to them, all the way to their core. If I knew how to follow it, if I had something to send back down it..." She looked at him. "I could reach them. Through their own fire."

"You could," Lor-ar agreed. "It is a thing the dark mages have always known and the light mages never trouble to learn, because they have never had to fear an enemy who could read the thread. You can read the thread. You can do a great many things they have never had to fear, little one, which is exactly why you must never, ever let them learn that you can, until the one moment when letting them learn it is the last thing they ever do." He held her gaze a beat longer than was comfortable. "File it. You will want it one day. I hope you will not, but you will."

Viridia filed it. It went onto the long list, the one reserved for the uncomfortable later, and she had the cold sense, sitting in the scorched clearing with her healed arm and her aching shoulders, that the later was coming closer.

Lor-ar drew the rest of it out of her the same way, question by question, where the army was strong and where it was blind, where numbers helped and where they hindered, how a small force that could not be found might

still strike a large one that could; and where she was wrong he corrected her, and where she was right he made her say *why*, until the loose facts in her head settled into something with edges. A map of how the war would actually be fought. And, faint but unmistakable upon it, the place where a girl with both halves of the gift and a spear and a dragon and a list of filed and terrible things might come to matter.

"Good," he said at last. "Enough for one night. You are tired in your body and your mind both, and a tired student learns the wrong lessons." He rose. "Ride Raizen back. He is large enough now, and you have earned the easier road."

She climbed onto Raizen, into the natural seat between the great prismatic scales, and he stood, and she did not feel the cold of the height because the bond kept it from her, and Lor-ar watched them lift and then turned and ran for the school below, a streak of storm-colored fur threading the dark. From Raizen's back the forest fell away beneath her, black and endless and, she knew now, full of more life than anyone had ever told her; and off to the west, low against the mountain, the small red glow of Varissa's fire burned where it always burned. Farther still, past the fire, on the very rim of what the sight could reach, the land lay greyed and thinning, the Hollowing Lor-ar had named for her, that same distant wrongness. It sat on the second ridge now, where a fortnight ago it had sat on the third; she had a fixed mark for it tonight, the same as Nargash had a fixed mark for the patrol, and the two marks were moving the same direction, toward her, at a speed she could nearly put a number to. Raizen felt her notice it and asked, down the bond, *What is that. The Hollowing*, she said, giving him the name and not the dread under it, *where the war has drunk the land empty*. Lor-ar says it is getting closer, and it is, I can measure it, and they flew the rest of the way without speaking of it. Viridia ached in

every limb. Her arm where the cut had been still tingled with the healing. And she was, to her own mild surprise, happy.

"It was fun," she admitted, into the wind, knowing he would hear it down the bond. "The fighting. God help me. It was actually fun."

"Of course it was," Raizen said, and she felt his amusement run warm along the link between them. "You are good at it, and you are alive, and the two together are one of the best feelings there is. Do not let it frighten you that you enjoyed it. Let it frighten you only if you ever stop minding the cost." A wingbeat, and the school's dark roofline rose ahead. "Anything that keeps you alive is worth doing," he said again, softer. "But it is better when it is also worth doing for its own sake. Tonight it was both."

And against the wind, aching, healed, and carried, Viridia laughed, and the dragon laughed with her, a low rolling rumble she felt through the scales and through the bond at once, and the two of them came down out of the dark toward the one lit window together, laughing, as if the war were a thing that happened to other people, in some other and later night.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Ranking Test Is Announced

Mrs. Zoran kept her back to the class while she wrote the morning's symbols on the board, and Viridia knew before the woman turned around that she was going to be sent away.

She knew it the way she knew most things now, by the detail that did not fit. Mrs. Zoran's hand was steady on the chalk. Her dress that morning was the green one with the silver hoops, the cheerful one. But she had not once, in the long minute of writing, glanced back over her shoulder at Viridia the way she always did, the small checking look she gave the strange quiet girl in the third row, as if to confirm she was still there and still all right. This morning she would not look. A person who would not look at you had already decided something about you and did not want to watch your face while they said it.

"Viridia." Mrs. Zoran set the chalk down and brushed the white off her fingers, and then she did turn, and her smile was real and a little sad at once. "Stay a moment after, would you? The rest of you, page forty. The hardening of organic matter. I want the first symbol copied three times before I come round."

The class bent over their slates. Viridia felt the attention slide toward her anyway, the way attention always found her now, a heat at the back of the neck. The girl beside her, a

thin first-year named Petra who had never spoken to her, copied her symbol very carefully and did not look up, which was a way of looking too.

She had come to Hazel to be the girl no one saw, and instead she had a tiger that slept on the dining-hall bench, a dragon everyone had heard of and not quite been allowed to see, and a teacher who pulled her aside after class. She did not like it, and could not have said when it happened. She only knew the room arranged itself around her now, and a girl built to disappear does not know what to do with a room that will not let her.

When the bell rang and the others filed out, Mrs. Zoran came and sat on the edge of the desk in front of Viridia's, which put them nearly at eye level. Up close her glasses were smudged at one corner. She had a habit of cleaning them on her sleeve when she was nervous, and she did it now.

"I'm going to tell you something," she said, "and I want you to hear the whole of it before you make a face."

"I don't make faces."

"You make one face. It's very small and it means you've decided I'm wrong and you're being polite about it." Mrs. Zoran put the glasses back on. "You don't need this class anymore, Viridia. You haven't needed it for some weeks. I have been teaching you to harden a leaf and you have been hardening it and being kind enough not to mention that you could harden the whole tree if I asked. It's not fair to you. And, if I'm honest." She paused, and the honesty cost her something; Viridia watched it cost her. "It isn't entirely safe for me, either, to have you sitting in my front rows being twice the mage I am where the others can see and start to wonder why."

There it was. Not unkindness. The opposite. She was being protected, and being moved out of the light at the same time, and the two were the same act.

"All right," Viridia said.

"That's the face."

"It isn't. I understand. You're right." She did understand. She had spent her life understanding the reasons people had for not wanting to look directly at her, and being grateful when the reasons were good ones. "Thank you. For the class. You taught me the first magic I ever did on purpose."

Something in Mrs. Zoran's face wobbled and held. "Knowledge is power," she said, which was the thing she always said, but quieter than usual, as if she were saying it to herself this time and meant the cost in it as much as the comfort. "Now. The real reason I kept you. There's an announcement at assembly today, and I wanted you to hear part of it from me first, because it concerns you more than it concerns anyone else in this school, and I'd rather you had a minute to set your face before three hundred people watch you hear it."

* * *

The dining hall at assembly was the dining hall with the tables pushed back, the long benches lined up in rows, the high windows throwing slanted bars of dust-lit morning across the stone floor. Viridia sat where she always sat now, near the end, with the small warm weight of Lor-ar curled against her hip in his cat shape, his eyes half shut, every part of him radiating the appearance of sleep and none of it real.

Something is coming, he said down the bond, not moving. I can hear it in the Headmistress's breathing. She is composed. She is composed the way a person is composed when they have practiced being composed about a particular thing.

Mrs. Zoran tried to warn me.

Then listen better than the room does, little one, and let me listen to the room.

Lady Lightwell rose. She wore the rose-tinted spectacles and a dress the color of dark wine, and her blue shoes, the same plain scuffed blue shoes she always wore, the one human thing about her, the detail that did not fit the rest and so Viridia trusted it more than anything else she presented. She let the hall settle. She was very good at letting a room settle. She did not raise her hands or call for quiet; she simply waited, and the waiting did the work, the talk dying out row by row until the only sound was the wind in the high windows.

"Two pieces of news," she said. "One you will enjoy. One you will pretend to enjoy, and I won't blame you for it."

A ripple of laughter. She rode it out.

"The fourth-years' ranking test will be held this Friday."

The hall came alive. Viridia felt it more than saw it, the particular electric stir of a hundred and more young people all at once afraid and excited about the same thing. Down the benches the fourth-years had gone rigid in the middle of the noise, a quiet that carried further than the clamor around it. The ranking test was the thing the older girls had been preparing for since the year began, the thing that decided which of the post-Hazel schools would take them and on what terms, the thing their whole futures pivoted on. Viridia had heard them speak of it in the corridors in low voices, the way people speak of something they have decided to be brave about.

"You know the shape of it," Lightwell went on. "An examination of judgment, conducted privately, one student at a time, with the scenario-disc. A combat assessment. Both are scored by examiners from the capital, not by your teachers, and the scores follow you into the world. I will not pretend the day is not important. It is. But it is a day, and you have had a year, and a year of work does not unmake itself

because you slept badly the night before. Do the thing you have practiced. That is all the test has ever asked."

She paused. Viridia felt Lor-ar go fractionally more alert against her hip, a tightening of attention with no movement in it at all.

"The second piece of news. This year, the test will be overseen in person by the High Chancellor himself."

The silence that followed was different from the first silence. The first had been anticipation. This was the indrawn quiet of people who did not entirely know why the news frightened them and were frightened anyway, the instinct arriving ahead of the reason. Viridia did not have to manufacture the small careful arrangement of her own face. She let it be what the room's was: surprised, impressed, a little overawed. Underneath it, out of anyone's sight, the cold cataloguing part of her began very quietly to work.

The High Chancellor did not visit schools. She knew that much from Mr. Cote's dry books and from the way the older girls spoke of the capital, a place that sent letters and decrees and examiners but did not, itself, arrive. The man who sat at the very top of the light-mage world was going to walk into Hazel on Friday and sit in a chair and watch.

Why, she thought, not to Lor-ar, to herself.

That, said Lor-ar, who had heard it anyway, *is the correct question. Hold on to it. Do not let the rest of the day make you forget you asked it.*

"He will, by tradition," Lightwell said, and here her voice did something so small that Viridia was perhaps the only one in the hall trained to catch it, a flattening, a deliberate evenness laid down over something her voice wanted to do and must not, "observe the top-ranked student through a final exercise, privately, after the public results are read. It is an old honor. It has not been offered at this school in my time here." She looked out over the hall, and for a quarter of

a second, no longer, her gaze crossed Viridia's, and there was a whole sentence in it that Viridia could not yet read. "Prepare well. Sleep when you can. You're dismissed."

The hall rose into noise and motion. Lor-ar did not move from Viridia's hip.

She is afraid, he said. *Of the man, and for you, and she has hidden it from a roomful of children who needed her not to be. That woman would make a magnificent general. It is a great waste that she is spending herself running a school.*

Viridia turned the sight, once, toward the tall windows and the country beyond them, the way she did now without deciding to. Far off, past the lawns and the trees, where the living threads of the world usually lay thin and steady, a smudge sat low against the horizon, a dimness, a thinning, the Hollowing drinking the light out of the land the way Lor-ar had said it would. It held for a breath. Then a cloud shifted, or her attention did, and it was gone. She told herself it meant nothing. She filed it regardless. She had stopped trusting the things she most wished to call nothing.

* * *

She found a corner of the library that afternoon where the shelves made an alcove the librarian's desk could not see, and she opened a book on the history of the ranking examinations and did not read it. Raizen was at the school, for once, curled small in the rafters of the alcove, all his colors gone muted and shadowy in the dim, a trick he was getting good at. Lor-ar lay along the windowsill. She had brought them here to talk, in the only way the three of them could talk in daylight inside the school, which was barely above a whisper, with a book open as cover and the mana-sight up to watch for anyone approaching.

"He's coming for me," she said. "The Chancellor. The top student gets the private exercise, and we all know who's

going to be the top student, and so the most powerful man in the country is travelling for days to watch a fourteen-year-old do an exercise. That's the shape of it."

"That is one shape," Raizen said. His new voice in her head was getting steadier by the day, less wonder in it, more him. "Tell me the others. You always make me say why. Make yourself."

She almost smiled. He did do that, took her own habits and turned them on her, and it was unbearable and exactly what she needed in roughly equal measure.

"The other shape is that it means nothing," she said. "That he visits a school each year and this is our year and I'm reading a threat into a coincidence because I've spent a month learning that everything is a threat." She turned a page she had not read. "But I don't believe that one."

"Why."

"Because of Lightwell's voice when she said it. She flattened it. She does that when she's holding something down. And because of the glasses."

Lor-ar opened one eye. "What glasses."

"I don't know. There aren't any glasses yet. I just." She stopped, surprised at herself, at the thing her own mouth had reached for ahead of her thinking. "Powerful men who want to know what someone is have tools for it. That's all. If I were him, and I'd heard there was something strange at a school, I wouldn't come to ask questions. People lie. I'd come to *look*." She set her hand flat on the open page. "And I'd bring something to look with."

There was a silence in the alcove. The dust turned in the bar of window-light.

"That," Lor-ar said at last, very softly, "is the cleverest fear I have heard out of a human mouth in a long while. You are right to assume he will bring a tool. You cannot know what it sees. So you will give it nothing to see." He rose,

stretched the length of the sill, resettled. "From now until Friday, and on Friday most of all, your core stays banked. You will damp the light side down to what a clever first-year might have and no more. You will hold the dark side closed as if it were not there at all. You have learned to do this in the night lessons. Now you do it in daylight, in front of the most dangerous man you will ever meet, for as long as he chooses to look. Can you?"

"Yes," she said. The flat one-word yes she gave when she meant it most.

"Then we will practice it until yes is true and not only brave." He looked at Raizen. "And you stay away from the school on the day. You are the one thing about her that cannot be hidden or explained, and a dragon on her shoulder is a sentence he can read across a room."

She felt the bond tighten with Raizen's refusal before he spoke it, the flare of it, the not-leaving-her, and she pressed back along it without words, *please*, and felt his colors dim further in the rafters, the protest folding down into a hard unhappy obedience.

"I'll be near," Raizen said. "Out of sight. The instant you are afraid in the true way and not the careful way, I will know it, and I will come, and there will be nothing left of his arena. Do you understand me? That is the agreement. I will hide for you. I will not hide if you are dying."

"I understand," she said, and meant that too, and was, in a small private place, fiercely glad of it.

* * *

She did not tell Alice everything. She had decided some weeks ago what Alice could carry and what she should not have to, and the line was not where Alice would have drawn it, and Viridia knew that and held it anyway, and that was its

own quiet loneliness, the keeping of a friend safe by keeping part of yourself shut to her.

But she told her about the test.

They were on Alice's bed with the lamp turned low, Alice in the middle of a great many small jars from the medical wing that she was supposed to be labelling and was mostly not. Alice had taken to the healing work the way Viridia had taken to nothing, openly, joyfully, with her whole chest. She came back from the ward most evenings smelling of the green astringent they used and full of small triumphs, a fever broken, a bone she had been allowed to help set, a third-year who had stopped crying because Alice had sat with her.

"Friday," Alice said, when Viridia told her. "*This* Friday. And the Chancellor himself." She put down a jar. "Viridia. They only do the private exercise for the top student, everyone knows that, and you're going to *be* the top student, you've been the top student since the second week, even the fourth-years say so when they think no one's listening..."

"They don't say that."

"They absolutely say that. Della heard Regina say it in the washroom, and told me you didn't hear it from her, which from Della means the whole school's already heard it. Regina! Who hates everyone!" Alice's eyes were shining, with no edge in it, no envy, only the uncomplicated pleasure she took in good things happening to people she loved. It undid Viridia a little, every time. She had not known, before Alice, that a person could simply be glad for you, with nothing held back and nothing wanted in return. "You're going to do something with the Chancellor watching that no one's done in fifteen years. Aren't you even a little bit excited?"

"I'm a little bit something," Viridia said.

Alice laughed, then caught herself, and put her hand over Viridia's on the bedspread, light, the way she did everything. "You're worried," she said. Not a question. Alice missed a great deal, on purpose, the way you miss things to be kind. She had not missed this. "You always go very still and very polite when you're worried. Like now."

"I'm worried I'll do badly with him watching."

It was not the true worry. But it was a true worry, near enough to the shape of the real one that it did not land as a lie, and Alice took it and turned it over and gave it back gentled.

"You won't," she said. "And even if you did. Even if you did the worst exercise anyone's ever done, in front of the whole capital." She squeezed Viridia's hand. "You'd still be the person who walked into that room. The disc doesn't score *that*."

Viridia looked at her friend in the low lamplight, the freckles, the one tooth turned a little out of line, the open undefended face of her, and felt the want to tell her everything rise up hard and pressing behind her ribs, the want to say, *your core is broken and mine is whole and I see it every time I look at you and I have never told you and it is the loneliest thing I carry*. She held it down. She was good at holding. She turned her hand over under Alice's and gripped it once, which was the most she would let herself do, and Alice gripped back, and that was a whole conversation in a language only the two of them spoke.

"I'll be in the ward all day Friday, you know," Alice said, returning to her jars, the moment passing the way she let moments pass, easily, on her terms. "They've got us all on for the test day. Overflow, in case anyone hurts themselves in the combat part. I won't even get to watch." She made a face. "Some friend I am. You face down the entire capital and I'll be three corridors away counting bandages."

"You'll be doing something useful," Viridia said. "I'll be doing a trick for a man in a robe."

"It's not a trick." Alice threw a wad of label-paper at her. "It's *you*. Go to sleep, you've got a tiger and a country to outwit and you snore when you're tired."

"I don't snore."

"You little bit snore. It's very dignified. Goodnight, Viridia."

* * *

Lady Lightwell excused her from her ordinary classes for the three days before the test. She did it by note, slipped to Viridia in the corridor by a fourth-year Viridia now knew to be one of the runners, a girl with a pale stone at her throat and, under it, when Viridia looked, the slow black swirl of a hidden core. The note said only: *You are excused Wednesday through Friday to prepare. Use the time. Notice quietly.* It was unsigned. Lightwell never signed anything Viridia might be searched for carrying.

So she had three days, and she spent them the way Lor-ar told her to spend them, which was not at all the way the fourth-years spent theirs.

The days she gave to the library, and to learning the public exercise as the fourth-years learned it, the scenario-disc and its judgments, the forms of combat the examiner would look for, building the convincing surface of a gifted ordinary girl. She read until her eyes ached and then she practiced the banking, sitting cross-legged in the alcove with the mana-sight turned on herself, watching her own core, learning to throttle it. It was harder than any spell. The core wanted to be itself. Damping it was like keeping a shout swallowed while she talked and walked and smiled, hour after hour, the whole of her bent to the work of seeming less. By the third day she could hold a first-year's glow for an

hour at a time without slipping. She practiced the small things too, the right amount of effort to show, the right amount of strain on her face for magic that cost her nothing, the performance of a limit she did not have.

The nights she gave to the clearing.

The Dangris had been coming most nights since the first, and Nargash had been as good as his word, taking her apart and building her back, slower and surer each time. Her body had changed under the work. She could hold the guard stance now until the stars wheeled and not shake. She could read a lunge most of the time and a feint half the time and what had once been pure blindness had become, by degrees, only ordinary clumsiness, which Nargash said was the whole of the road from dead to alive. On the second night, Venquar had opened her skin only once the whole session, and had seemed, around the gap in his teeth, almost insulted by how hard it had become.

On the third night, the night before the test, Nargash sent the others back into the trees early and came and crouched before her himself, his vertical pupils catching the moon, his pointed smile a thing she had stopped flinching from.

"We will not train hard tonight," he said. "The night before a true test, the body must rest, not learn. I came to give you a thing instead."

He held out his hand. On the broad rough palm lay a small triangular blade of the watered grey metal she now knew on sight, Damascus, no longer than her thumb, ground to a wicked point, with a hole bored at the wide end and a thong of dark leather knotted through it.

"This," Nargash said, "is the Heart of the Spear. Among the Dangris it is given only to one who has shed blood and not run, and given back blood, and laughed about neither. It is made from the head of a spear that has killed in defense of the tribe. The metal remembers." He set it in her hand and

closed her fingers over it, his hand swallowing hers whole, hot and dry. "Mark me: it is not given for skill. You have a season's skill, and the manners to know it is a season's. It is given for bearing, for the cut you took without complaint and the one you gave back. Skill we can teach you, and will, for years yet. Bearing a warrior is born with. You have it. I have looked, dragon-friend. There is no Heart in your people. They are very fine at building and very fine at growing and they have forgotten how to give a young warrior the thing that says: you are one of us, you have been tested, you will not stand alone. So. The Dangris give you ours. You are Kor-toh now, in the only part of it that matters, which is the part that comes when you call."

Viridia looked at the small grey blade in her hand, warm from his, and felt its enormity settle on her the way the spears had, too large, undeserved, a weight she did not know how to set down or take up. She had no people. She had had two, and they were three weeks dead, and she had said goodbye to no one and buried no one and the place where her people should have been was a cold open door inside her she kept her back turned to. And here was a creature with filed teeth and slit eyes, a thing her whole world called a monster, giving her a name and a token and a promise that she would not stand alone.

Her eyes burned. The pressure came up behind them, sudden and hot, the body reaching past her for the release she never let it have. She set her jaw and clenched everything down, and the wave crested and broke against the inside of her face and did not get out, and she breathed, once, slow, through her nose, and won.

Nargash watched her win it. She knew he saw. The slit pupils did not miss things; he was a hunter, and grief on a face was only another body telling its truth. But he said

nothing about it, and that was the kindest thing he could have done, and she understood that he knew that too.

"Thank you," she said, when her voice was hers again. She tied the thong around her neck, beside her mother's dark-blue stone, the two of them resting cold together over her sternum, the only two things she wore that anyone had ever given her because of who she was. "I'll keep it with me."

"It will keep you," Nargash said. He rose. "Now. Sleep, Kor-toh. Tomorrow you stand before a man who fears what he cannot rank, and you will let him rank you a little above the rest and far below the truth, and you will smile while he does it." His teeth flashed in the dark. "We hate him too, you know. He has hunted our south tribes for sport. When your war comes, and it is coming, send word. We have always loved a war." And he was gone into the pines without a sound, the way they always went.

* * *

She rode Raizen back, because it was the last night she would have him near for some days and she could not make herself give up the height and the wind and the great warm engine of him under her. They flew low over the black sea of the forest, the school's one lit window growing ahead, and she held the small grey blade at her throat in one hand and thought about Friday.

"You're quiet," Raizen said. "Quieter than the flying makes you. What are you turning over up there?"

"Everything Lor-ar said. Bank the core. Give him nothing. Smile." She watched the window come closer, the warm yellow square that was her room, where Alice would already be asleep, smelling of green astringent, dreaming of broken fevers. "I keep thinking I'm preparing for a test. I'm not. I'm preparing to be *examined*. Those aren't the same. A test wants to know what you can do. An examination wants to

know what you *are*." The wind took the words and she let it. "I've spent my whole life making sure no one finds out what I am. And on Friday I'm going to walk into a room and let the most powerful man alive look right at me for as long as he wants, and the whole of my life is going to depend on him not seeing it."

Raizen was silent under her for the length of three wingbeats. When he spoke, the dry warmth had gone out of his voice, and what was left was older than him, his father's grief and his mother's iron and his own newborn ferocity all braided together into something that did not sound newborn at all.

"Then he will not see it," he said. "Because you have hidden in plain sight since the day you walked through those gates, hidden from a school full of mages, hidden from the woman who runs it for half a season before she ever caught you out. You are the best liar I have ever been bonded to, little one, and I mean that as the highest praise my kind can give. Tomorrow you do the thing you have always done. Only the stakes are honest now."

The window was very close. She brought him down onto the dark roof above her dormitory wing, soundless, his colors gone to slate and shadow, and slid from his back, and stood a moment in the cold with her hand on his neck.

"Something's about to change," she said. The words were out before her will caught up with them. It had been sitting in her all day, under the library and the banking and Nargash's gift, a low certain note she had been refusing to name, and now in the dark above her sleeping friend it came out of her quiet and flat and sure. "I can feel it. After Friday nothing is going to be the way it is now. I don't know if it's a door opening or a door closing. But it's going to move."

She waited for him to argue. He argued with her about most things, for the pleasure of it and because he thought she let too much go unargued. He did not argue now.

"I feel it too," Raizen said. "Down the bond, where your fear lives. It has been getting louder for days." He pressed his great blunt head once, gently, against her shoulder, and the contact ran warm all the way down the link between them. "Whatever moves, it moves with both of us standing in it. Remember that, tomorrow, whatever he is. You have a tiger and a dragon and a tribe of monsters who love war, and a friend three corridors away counting bandages who would set the world on fire for you if she knew how. You are not the girl who came through the gates with a stone she could not read. Go and sleep. Bank the core. And in the morning, let the door move."

She climbed down into the warm and the dark, and lay beside Alice's even sleeping breath, and held the cold stone and the colder blade against her chest, and lay awake well past the moon, listening to the low certain note that something, tomorrow, was going to open or close.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Day of the Test

The arena had been swept clean of leaves overnight, and that was the first wrong thing Viridia noticed when they brought the fourth-years out into the cold bright morning to see it.

It was the open ring at the school's eastern edge where the older girls did their physical drills, a wide floor of pale packed sand inside a low ring of stone benches, and it was always, every morning of the year, scattered with the first fallen leaves of the season. Today it was bare. Someone had been out before dawn with a broom and the care of a person preparing a room for an important guest, and the sand lay raked in long even lines, and the emptiness of it, the deliberate swept emptiness, sat in Viridia's chest like a warning she had no words for yet. They had cleaned the place. People cleaned a place when they wanted nothing about it to draw the eye except the thing they meant you to see.

While they waited she let the sight drift out past the eastern wall, over the bare trees toward the far ridges, the small unbidden habit she could no longer stop herself making, and found the thing she had been finding for a week and wishing she would not. The Hollowing. The grey thinning in the living threads of the world, the country where the light was being drunk out of the land. It had

crossed to the third ridge now. She was sure of it this time; she had counted ridges the way she counted everything, and a week ago it had stopped at the second. It came on the way the swept sand had been swept, patiently, before dawn, by a hand that wanted nothing left to draw the eye. She drew the sight back in and banked her face and told no one, because the two clocks she could feel running, the grey one creeping over the ridges and the unsigned one she had no eyes for at all, a decree on a desk in the capital, were the same clock told two ways, and both were counting down toward whatever was about to walk into this arena.

The thing they meant her to see arrived an hour after breakfast.

He came not by the gates but by portal, which she had not known the capital allowed, a vertical seam of light that opened against the far wall of the arena and let three figures step through before it sealed itself away. For the half-second the seam stood open, the mana-sight showed Viridia what lay on the other side of it. Not the bright ordered capital she had pictured, but a stretch of country gone wrong, its threads of life thin and greyed, the same low dimness she had glimpsed from the assembly window, only nearer now, and worse. Then the seam closed and took the sight of it with it. She marked the cold that went down her at the look of that land, and turned her face back to the careful nothing it was wearing. Two were examiners, an old woman and a wiry young man, both in the grey the capital's testers wore. The third was a short bald man in a white robe with a light-gold sash, and Viridia knew him before anyone announced him, because the whole assembled school went quiet around her in a wave that started at the front and reached the back, and because Lady Lightwell, standing at the head of them all, did a thing with her face that Viridia had been watching for and almost missed.

She smiled. She inclined her head in welcome. And for the space of a single breath, before the welcome arranged itself, her composure was not warmth but armor, a stillness laid down hard and fast over something she would not let move, and Viridia, who knew that particular stillness because she lived inside it herself, understood that the Headmistress of Hazel was looking at the man crossing the sand the way a person looks at a snake in a room with a child.

There, Lor-ar said, from his place against Viridia's ankle in his cat shape, every line of him sleepy and false. *That is the warning. She gave it to you on purpose. She let you see the armor for one breath because she could not say the words aloud. Heed it.*

"Lady Lightwell." The Chancellor's voice carried without seeming to rise, a warm dry voice, grandfatherly, a voice built to put children at their ease. "What a very fine morning you've kept for us. And what a fine crop." His pale eyes moved over the assembled school, unhurried, pleasant, and where they passed the girls stood a little straighter without deciding to. "I do so love a test day. The whole future of our art, gathered in one cold courtyard, not one of them yet knowing what they'll become. Marvelous." He let his gaze travel the rows, slow, and Viridia kept her own face turned a few degrees down and to the side, the face of a first-year too shy to be looked at, and banked her core to a small ordinary flicker, and did not let the tightness in her chest become anything he could see.

His eyes passed over her. They did not stop. She counted that, filed it, did not trust it.

"You all know why we are here," Lightwell said, taking the morning back into her own hands with the ease of long practice. "You will be called one at a time. While one of you tests, the rest will wait inside the dining hall, where it is warm, and where you will not, I'm told, be able to see or hear

what passes out here. Eat something. Try not to frighten one another with stories. The test is not the monster the older girls have made it. Go on."

* * *

They were called by ranking, lowest first, which meant Viridia waited the longest. She sat in the dining hall through the whole of the morning and most of the afternoon while the fourth-years went out one by one and came back changed, some pale, some shaking, one girl crying without sound into her sleeve, one boy laughing too loudly with relief. No one was allowed to speak of what they had seen. The not-speaking filled the hall like water.

Lor-ar lay across her lap and slept, truly slept, or did a thing so close to sleep she could not tell the difference, and she sat unmoving under his weight and watched the door and banked her core and rehearsed, somewhere behind her careful face, the girl she was going to be when her name was called. Competent. A little nervous. Bright but not unnatural. A first-year who had studied hard and had a knack. Nothing that wanted looking at twice.

The fourth-years came and went, and Viridia, who could not help reading a room, read them. A tall girl named Regina, who hated everyone and was rumored to be the best of them, went out with her chin high and came back grey and would not meet anyone's eye, and the meaning of that traveled the hall without a word being spoken. A small round girl came back beaming and could not hide it and was ashamed of not being able to hide it, which meant she had passed and feared the others would think her boastful for being glad. One girl did not come back to the hall at all; a runner took her things out to her, and no one asked. Della, who was a first-year and not being tested, had wedged herself onto the end of Viridia's bench and kept up a low

running commentary about everyone, which was Della's way of being frightened on Viridia's behalf without saying so. "Regina cried," she whispered, scandalized and delighted and worried all at once. "Regina. I didn't know she had the water in her." Viridia let the chatter run over her like the wind in the high windows and kept her eyes on the door.

When at last a grey-robed runner put her head in and said, "Viridia Saeren," the hall went quiet again, that now-familiar quiet that arranged itself around her, and she felt every eye and pretended she did not, and lifted Lor-ar gently down onto the warm bench, and went out alone into the swept and waiting arena.

* * *

The old examiner stood by a plain table at the arena's center, and on the table lay a row of rods.

"Viridia Saeren," she said. Her hair was white and her teeth were yellow and crooked when she smiled, and she leaned on a runed cane Viridia could not help reading, the carvings half-familiar, old work, real. "I do be Quina. Do not be minding the Chancellor; he do be watching, but it do be me that scores you, not him." She said it lightly, but her pale eyes flicked once, very fast, to the bench at the arena's edge where the Chancellor sat with his hands folded, and Viridia understood the old woman was telling her something true under the lightness, the way Mrs. Zoran told her things, the way everyone who meant her well had learned to tell her things sideways. "Come. Look at the rods. Tell me what each do be for, near as you can."

Viridia went down the row. She had read about most of them, and the mana-sight told her the rest, the enchantments hanging on each like frost-patterns she had learned in a month to read. A rod for finding water. A rod for the slow growth of stone. A heavy one, near the end, dense

with layered work, that would show the holder where gems lay buried under the earth, and would take more magic to wake than most mages had to give. She named them one by one, careful to name them a half-beat slow, a first-year working it out, and not in the clean instant rush in which she actually saw them.

The last rod was bone-white, twisted along its length, and carried more enchantment than any single object she had ever seen, and down its haft ran writing she knew. Not the same words. The same hand. The Moravian script, the old language, the one her own focus wore and her mother's spellbook used and almost no one else alive could read.

Quina watched her find it. "Ah," she said, pleased. "Drawn to that one, do you be?"

"No, ma'am," Viridia said, and made herself look away from the writing, which cost her, because every part of her wanted to lean close and read it. "I can tell it's powerful. It just has more on it than I've ever seen on one thing."

"Aye, it do be powerful. Could one use it." Quina's crooked smile widened. "Do you be knowing what that says?"

Viridia let her eyes travel the script as if it were strange to her, and shook her head, and lied with her whole face. "No, ma'am."

"I no be surprised. There do be few these days who study such things." The old woman traced the words herself with one yellowed nail, and read them out in a voice gone suddenly soft and old and careful. "It do say: *Dust to dust, from whence we came; so all may fear he who wields this cane.*" She looked up. "That do be a strange thing to find in a light mage's hand, do it not."

"Yes," Viridia said, and the word was true, and she set it away among the things she kept for the uncomfortable later, because a light-mage school did not keep a rod inscribed in

the dark mages' tongue with a promise of fear and death unless the line between the two was thinner and older than anyone said. "Where did it come from?"

"The vaults. For the test, all rods do be brought from the vaults, even such as that one." Quina drew a flat silver disc from her pocket, set it on the table, and the moment for questions closed. "Now. Five scenarios do be in this disc. I push the button; a memory do come into your mind; you choose the rod that best do solve what you find there. It do test your knowledge, your reading of magic, and your judgment when there do be no clean answer. Do you be ready?"

"Yes."

She pushed the first button.

* * *

The first memory took her standing on the bank of a flooding river, and it was not like watching a memory; it was like being poured into one. She was someone else, a light mage in a grey cloak, and the river was brown and vast and roaring and full of people, and on the far bank more people stood screaming for the ones the water had taken, and the grief of the mage she was wearing came up through her own chest until she had to set her feet against it. The task was clear and the clock was the water. She looked at the rods, the real rods on the real table that her real hands could feel even inside the memory, and chose the one for the slow growth of stone, and the memory took her choice and ran it forward: bridges of stone rising from the flood, but built with sieves beneath, so the water poured through and the people caught against them and held. The mage's satisfaction warmed her like sun. Then it faded, and she was in the arena again, breathing hard.

Quina's white eyebrows had risen. "That do be an interesting solution. Most do dam the river. You let it run and caught the people instead." She tilted her head. "Well done. On."

The second memory put her before a stone wall covered in glyphs, a scholar's problem, how to carry the wall's knowledge back to camp when the wall could not be moved. The other testers, she could feel in the borrowed mind, had always copied it laboriously by hand. Viridia chose differently. She took up the rod that worked on memory and the mind, and the memory ran her choice: the mage pressing the rod to his temple, drawing the whole wall into himself to be studied later at leisure. When it faded, Quina was frowning.

"That do be a dangerous path," she said, not unkindly. "Magic that do touch the mind or the soul do go wrong easy, without great care. You do be clever. Cleverness without caution do dig its own grave. Mind that." She pushed the third button before Viridia could answer, and Viridia kept the warning, because it was a good one and freely given.

The third was a sick child and an unknown fever, and she chose the healing rod and chose well, and felt, distantly, that Alice would have chosen faster and surer, would have known the fever by smell, and missed her three corridors away in the bright ward. The fourth was a building to enter and a secret to take from it without being caught, and she chose stealth and shadow and patience, and passed. They were straightforward. She began, foolishly, to feel the shape of the test, to think she had its measure.

Then Quina pushed the fifth button, and Viridia knew at once it was not like the others.

It was older. She felt the age of it the way you feel cold come off stone. She was sitting at a polished marble table, and nine others sat around it. The light through the high

windows was the light of a century she had only read about. The faces around the table were grave and tired and powerful, and she understood, with a lurch that was entirely her own and not the borrowed mind's, that this was the Great War. The real one. The severing. And the question on the table, the question the nine grave faces were turning over in their low certain voices, was whether to end the war by destroying the strongest dark families to the last child.

The task was simple. Pick up the rod for *yes*, or the rod for *no*.

She sat in the borrowed body at the borrowed table and the cold cataloguing part of her, the part that had banked her core all day and arranged her face all day and kept her alive all month, said clearly and without cruelty: *Say yes. The test wants the historical answer. The light mages voted yes; that is why you exist; that is why the world is the way it is. Say yes and pass and the Chancellor watches you pass and you are safe.* It was the survivor's answer. It was the answer the girl she had built all day would give without a flicker.

And Viridia, who was that girl on the outside and had never once been her underneath, looked around the marble table at the grave faces deciding to murder children for the crime of what they might become, children with cores like hers, whole or half or hidden, children who had done nothing yet but be born wrong in a frightened world, and felt Mrs. Zoran's dead brother in the room, the dark-mage beekeeper killed for what he might one day be, and felt the open door inside her where her own people had been, and could not do it.

She knew it might fail her. She knew the Chancellor was watching her face. She banked her core a fraction tighter so that the size of what she felt would not show, and she let her face be the careful girl's face, troubled but composed, and

underneath, where it was only ever hers, she was not careful at all. She reached out and picked up the rod for *no*.

The memory did not run forward. It simply faded, the marble table dissolving, the grave faces going out one by one. And as it went she heard, clear and close and unmistakably *aimed*, a voice that was not Quina's and not the borrowed mind's and not anyone's she knew, a voice that seemed to come from the disc itself, dry and ancient and faintly, terribly, pleased.

Well done, it said.

She came back to the arena with her heart going hard, and the first thing she did, before she let herself feel anything at all, was check her own core, because she had felt the size of the *no* swell up in her at the table and a thing that large could slip the banking if she was not careful. It had held. She had voted to spare the children with her whole hidden heart and shown the watching man at the bench's edge only a girl who looked troubled by a hard question, and the gap between those two things was the whole of her, and she had kept it, even there, even then. Some cold part of her was proud of that and some warmer part was sick at having had to be.

On the table, the silver disc was no longer silver. It had turned, in the cold afternoon light, to a deep and steady gold.

Quina stared at it. The old woman's lightness was entirely gone. She looked at the gold disc and she looked at Viridia and she looked, once, fast, at the bench where the Chancellor sat, and then back at the disc, and when she spoke her voice had dropped so that it would not carry across the sand.

"I do be betting," she said quietly, "you'll be the only gold today. The test do not give perfect marks but rare. And it do not give them for the answer I expected." She picked the disc up, and at her touch the gold drained slowly back to blue. "It

do score itself, child. Not I. Every memory, it do choose. And on the last, it did choose to ask you the one question with no safe answer, and you did give it the dangerous one, and it did say *well done*." She slipped the disc into her pocket. Her crooked-toothed face had gone grave and a little afraid. "I do not know what you be. But I do know the test liked it. Mind who else you let see that." And she turned Viridia toward the far side of the arena, where the wiry young examiner waited with two spears, before Viridia could ask any of the questions crowding up her throat.

* * *

The combat test was almost a relief, because it asked nothing of her but her body, and her body she had spent a month learning to trust.

The young man's name was Tobias, and he sat cross-legged on the sand with a spear across his knees until she came, and then he rose in one easy motion that told her, before he ever set his feet, that he was very good. He asked to see her spear. She passed it to him butt-first, the way Venquar had drilled into her, and Tobias turned it in the light and his eyebrows climbed.

"This is a beautiful weapon," he said, and ran a thumb down the watered grey of the head. "The balance is true. The scrollwork is old work, real work. Your others match it?"

"All four."

"Four." He looked at her differently then, the appraising look of one fighter recognizing the marks of another's standing. "Someone thought you were worth a great deal. Damascus, and four of them." He handed it back. "Let's see if the weapon was wasted. Forms first."

She gave him the forms, the stances, the blocks she had repeated a hundred times in the dragons' ruined ring until Nargash stopped correcting them. Tobias found little to fix.

When he told her to attack him, she set her feet and watched his body the way Venquar had drilled into her, reading the truth that lived in a fighter's weight and stance rather than the lies his face could tell, and she went at him.

She could not touch him. He was a prodigy and he knew it and he was right, faster than Venquar and nearly as practiced, and he turned everything she had aside with an economy that was almost gentle. She circled him on the swept sand, the raked lines scuffing out under her feet, watching his weight ride between his hips, and she tried the feint and the underhand sweep that had once nearly worked on Venquar; Tobias read it before her weight had shifted and was simply not where the spear went, drifting half a step that put her point in empty air and his own haft resting, light as a question, against her ribs. He let her pull back. He did not press the touches. He was testing, not fighting, and the difference showed in the mercy of it.

She changed her plan, because Nargash had taught her that the first plan was only a way of learning the enemy. She stopped trying to win and tried, instead, to make him reach, to draw the small habit out of him the way she had drawn it out of Venquar. She hunted his eyes, his shoulders, the set of his back foot. But Tobias had no tell she could find, or none she had grown fast enough to read, and twice when she over-committed he let her feel exactly how dead she would have been, the flat of his spearhead laid for an instant against her throat, against the inside of her wrist, gone before she could flinch. After ten minutes she had landed nothing, and her shoulders were burning, and she understood the lesson the way she understood all the best lessons, in her body, which was that there was always someone faster, and the only question was whether you had learned enough to make him work for it. She had made him work for it. She had seen, twice, the small recalculations

cross his eyes when she did something he had not expected. It was not winning. But it was not nothing, and she knew the difference now.

She grounded the butt of her spear and stepped back and conceded.

Tobias grinned, and the grin was not unkind. "Don't take it hard," he said. "I'm what they call a prodigy, which is a polite way of saying I've done nothing my whole life but this. You're good. You're *young*, and you're already good, and that's rarer." He sobered. "But hear me. The spear is not a thing you learn once and set down trusting it'll be there. If you want it to save your life one day, you practice it as hard as you do your magic. Harder, if you can. The day you need it, it will be the day you have no magic left to spend." He nodded toward the school. "You pass, easily. Go on in. And keep up with those four spears. They deserve a hand that's earned them."

* * *

The dining hall fell silent when she came in, and then filled with the strained hush of two dozen fourth-years and a hundred younger girls all wanting to know and none allowed to ask. She found her bench. Lor-ar uncurled and made room and she sat, and he pressed warm against her side, and down the bond he said only, *Later. Eat something. Your hands are shaking and you have not noticed.* They were. She made them stop.

She did not see Alice. The Chancellor's order had sent all the helpers to the medical wing for the day, so Alice was three corridors away, and the test-day drawing the two of them had laughed over weeks ago, who would get to watch whom, had come to nothing. Viridia hoped she was happy in the bright ward, breaking fevers, missing nothing she needed to miss.

When the last fourth-year had been tested and returned, the Chancellor rose, and the two grey examiners came to stand at either side of him, and the hall went still in earnest. He asked if they had reached their decisions. They had. Quina spoke first.

"Of the students tested today," she said, and her voice had its lightness back, the public lightness, but Viridia heard the care underneath it, "one did complete my examination to the test's own satisfaction. One only." The old woman's pale eyes found Viridia in the rows. "Viridia Saeren. Step forward."

She rose. The not-looking of the whole hall became looking, all at once, a weight she walked through to the front, and stopped before the teachers' table, and kept her face the careful girl's face though her heart was loud.

"Miss Saeren." Quina inclined her head. "You did impress the test with your reading of magic and your judgment where there was none easy to be had. Top marks." Tobias, beside her, added that her combat wanted only practice and a few more years, and passed her, and Viridia murmured her thanks, and the hall stayed silent, because everyone in it understood now what was coming, the old honor that had not been offered at Hazel in fifteen years.

The Chancellor looked at his two examiners. "You both choose her?" They both nodded. He was quiet a moment, the grandfatherly warmth of him unbroken, his folded hands serene, and Viridia, banking her core down to almost nothing, watching him through her lowered lashes the way she watched everyone, saw the thing she had been afraid she would see and had hoped she would not.

He had reached up, while the examiners spoke, and put on a pair of glasses.

They were thin and silver-framed and they were soaked in magic, the same frost-pattern enchantment hanging off

them that hung off the rods, but stronger, woven through the very lenses, an intent rather than a glyph. She could not read what they did. She only knew that they were a thing made for looking, and that he had put them on at the exact moment he was about to look at her alone, and that everything Lor-ar had drilled into her for three days had been for this, for the next few minutes, for the man in the white robe who was rising now from his bench with a kind warm grandfatherly smile on his face and a tool for seeing what people were sitting on the bridge of his nose.

She did not let her core flare. She did not let her face move. She breathed, and banked, and held, the way she had held everything her whole life, and let nothing at all reach the surface where it could be read.

"Everyone else is dismissed," the High Chancellor said pleasantly, and the hall began, in a rustle of relief and curiosity, to rise. He let it. He smiled at Viridia over the silver rims of the glasses, and the smile reached for grandfatherly and fell short of it by a distance she could measure, and behind the lenses his pale eyes were doing something she could not see and could feel, a pressure, a looking.

"Miss Saeren," he said. He gestured, courteous, toward the door behind the teachers' table, the one that led back out to the swept and waiting arena. "If you would. There is a small tradition for the student who earns top marks. A reward, from the capital, for doing so very well." The glasses caught the light and went briefly, blankly silver, two coins where his eyes had been. "Follow me back to the arena."

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Portal

There is a moment she would return to for the rest of her life, and she did not know, walking out into the swept arena behind the High Chancellor, that she was walking toward it.

She knew only the back of him, the white robe, the gold sash, the bald head bright in the low afternoon sun, and the silver glasses he had not taken off. He had kept them on through the dining hall and through the door and out into the cold, and that was the thing she watched, the kept glasses, because a man did not keep on a tool for seeing once the thing he meant to see had left the room, unless he had not finished looking.

"Sit," he said, kindly, and gestured to the stone bench at the arena's edge, and she sat, and banked her core down to the small steady ember she had held all day, and folded her hands, and was a tired clever first-year and nothing else.

The Chancellor did not sit. He paced. The sun glared off his head as he went back and forth across the raked sand, and he talked, and the talk was warm and grandfatherly and entirely without warmth underneath, a performance of kindness laid over an instrument taking a reading.

"I cannot recall," he said, "another first-year who has done what you did today. Truly. The disc has not gone gold in this school in living memory. It is a remarkable thing." He stopped and looked at her, and behind the silver lenses his

pale eyes did the pressing, looking thing she could feel and not see. "Quite remarkable. Tell me. When the test asked you the last question. The old one, the war council. You chose to spare them. Why?"

She had known some version of this would come. She gave him the careful girl's answer, the one she had built. "It seemed cruel," she said. "Killing children for what they hadn't done yet."

"Mm." He resumed pacing. "A soft answer. A young answer." He was quiet a moment, and when he spoke again the grandfatherly warmth had thinned to something that sounded, briefly, almost like grief. "I was a soft young man once, with soft young answers. Then I watched a dark mage open a marketplace full of people from the inside out, children among them, because he had decided his conscience outranked the law, and I learned what mercy costs when you are wrong about who deserves it. I do not enjoy this work, whatever your headmistress will have told you. I do it because someone competent must, and because I have buried enough of the people mercy failed to be certain, now, which side of it I stand on." He let that settle, and the warmth came back over it like a lid. "You'll grow out of the soft answer, I expect, when you understand what those children grow into." He said it pleasantly. "Still. The test rewarded it, and the test is wiser than I am, so we will call it wisdom and not softness. It is tradition, you know, that the student who earns top marks receives a reward from the capital. A great honor. Very prestigious." He drew a scroll from inside his robe and held it out. "Here."

She took it. She unrolled the vellum, and made her face do mild puzzled interest, and underneath read it cold and fast and exactly. It was a portal spell, a real one, modified, the destination folded into glyphs she could not unpick but could recognize for what they were. Whoever had made it

had built it so that a touch of light magic would catch like fire in dry grass and set the whole of it alight.

"I can tell it's magic," she said, tracing a glyph as though it were strange to her. "I don't know the spell."

"No. You wouldn't." He watched her face for the lie and she gave him none, because the lie was not on her face; the lie was that she could read every glyph she was pretending not to. "It is a portal. It opens onto a place we keep as a state secret, and it is forbidden to speak of what lies beyond it, even to your friends. *Especially* to your friends." The grandfatherly smile. "One of our ancestors found it, long ago, in his studies. We have used it ever since, for the very best of our students, and only them. It will admit one person. The place insists on it. I will wait here." He sat, at last, on the far bench, and folded his hands, and became patient. "Step through. Everything will make sense on the other side."

She stood, and walked to the center of the swept ring, and set her feet, and let one thin thread of light touch the activation glyph.

The scroll caught. The glyphs lit one after another in a racing chain until the whole of it shone even against the sun, and a tearing sound went across the arena, and the air a few feet in front of her split open along a vertical seam and showed her dark on the other side. She looked back once. The Chancellor watched her, impassive, his glasses two blank coins. *Everything will make sense*, he had said, and she did not believe him, because nothing he had said all day had been the truth entire, and she stepped through anyway, because the only way to learn what he wanted hidden was to go and see it.

* * *

There is a moment she would return to.

The cave was dark, and cold, and the only light in it came from a stone pedestal a few feet ahead, where something glowed. The portal sealed shut behind her without a sound. She stood motionless and let her eyes find the shape of the place: a low rough chamber, older than old, the walls unworked stone, the air still and dry and tasting of nothing, of stone, of the deep places of the world that had never had weather. There was no sound. Not the drip of water, not the stir of air. The silence had a weight to it, the silence of a room that had been waiting a very long time.

She went to the pedestal.

In its hollowed top lay a pool of liquid, and the light came from the liquid itself, a clean pale glow with no source above or below it, only the liquid shining of its own accord. She leaned over it, and as she did she felt the light side of her core stir, the way a struck bell stirs another bell across a room, a resonance, a recognition. The liquid felt her. As if it had been waiting for exactly her, the split symbol rose to the surface of the pool, the same mark her focus wore, the same her mother's book wore, the mark of the two halves of the gift, and where it touched the surface the pool divided, light to one side and dark to the other, and both sides of her core, the hidden whole of her, leaned toward it at once and ached.

There was no decision in the touching. Her hand was simply, suddenly, reaching, drawn the way iron is drawn, and she reached out with her magic and laid it against the surface of the pool, and the world came apart.

* * *

This is the moment.

It was not water. She understood that in the first half-second, before the rest of it arrived: this was not magic water, not enchanted, not a thing a mage had made. This was magic itself. The source. The thing all the rest of it came

from, the thing every focus and glyph and core in the world was only a borrowing of, and she had put her bare unguarded magic into it, and it answered her with everything it was.

The knowing came in like a tide and she could not have stopped it if she had tried. She felt, all at once, the thread that tied every living thing to this place, every mage and every beast and every blade of grass, a vast lattice of fine bright lines running out from the pool to the whole of the world and back, and she was one of the lines, and so was Lor-ar, far away and suddenly close, and so, brilliant and singular, was Raizen, the bond between them lighting up like a struck wire all the way to wherever he hid. She felt the size of the world for the first time and nearly drowned in it.

And then the source showed her what it was for. It poured its memory into her, because she had asked it the only way it understood, by touching it whole, and almost no one had ever touched it whole.

The pact. The first one, made in the second war, between the people and the great beasts, the agreement that bound human and creature and let a girl summon a tiger and bond a dragon, and the grief in it, the cost, the thing each side gave up. The severing came after. The council of frightened mages at the marble table, the real one this time and not the test's echo of it, deciding the dark was too dangerous to be left whole in the world; their hands reaching into the source itself and *cutting*, deliberately, mankind's connection to the dark half of the gift, so that fewer children would be born able to touch it, so that the thing they feared would dwindle out of the world a generation at a time. So that was why dark mages were rare. Not rarer by nature. Made rarer, on purpose, by people afraid of what they could not rank, and the wound of that cut was still here, in the source, a place

where the bright lattice ran thin and frayed where it should have run full.

There was more than the fact of it. The source did not give her dates or names; it gave her the feel of the thing, the way a memory gives you a kitchen before it gives you a year. The fear that had driven the cut was not the fear of monsters. It was the fear of equals. The dark mages of that age had not been more cruel than the light. They had been, some of them, more powerful, and harder to govern, impossible to count and rank and file into the neat shapes a frightened council liked. So the council had not fought them in the open, where it might lose. It had reached down into the root of the world and quietly throttled the supply of them, a generation at a time, a slow strangling dressed up as peace. And the satisfaction of the mages who had done it was the same satisfaction she had felt at the marble table in the test, the clean warm certainty of people who believe they are saving the world by deciding who gets to be in it. It made her sick in the way only true things made her sick. Her knees had found the cold stone floor without her deciding to kneel.

The light mages had not won the second war. They had simply made sure no one would ever be strong enough to start a third, and called the silence afterward a victory, and built schools to teach the children of the survivors that the dark had always been the smaller, lesser thing, a defect, a brokenness, when in truth it had been a garden the gardeners had poisoned because it grew taller than the wall. The beekeeper, Amber on the kitchen floor, Alice's stunted candle, every girl at Hazel wearing a pale stone over a dark one: every grief she had touched in a month ran back to this room and this cut.

And she understood that the cut had not fully taken. The connection to the dark was tenuous now, starved, but it was

not gone. It was still there, frayed and faint. A thing that had been cut could, perhaps, be mended. The thought arrived whole and enormous and she had no idea yet whether it was hope or hubris, and she held it, and the source held her, and her own core, she felt, was changing under the contact, swelling, its capacity opening outward like a fist uncurling after a lifetime closed, more room in her than there had been a minute ago, a hundredfold more, the reason, she understood, that the Chancellor sent his best students here: they came back stronger. A larger core. That was all the others ever got. A larger core and no idea what they had touched.

She had got more. She had got everything. And she knew, even drowning in it, that she must never let him learn that she had.

* * *

She came back to the moment again, because that is what the moment did; it would not let her pass it cleanly. While the source poured itself into her she became aware, slowly, of a thread within the flood that was not like the others.

The lattice ran out to all the living things of the world, bright and even, a hum of belonging. But one line was different. One line ran not outward into the world but down, into the source's own deep memory, and it was warmer than the rest, and it was *hers*, personally, pointed, the way a letter has your name on it. She followed it with her attention and it led her toward something she could not see the whole of, a presence in the depths of the source's memory, faint and familiar, a stillness she knew, a deep-water stillness, a way of being quiet that she had spent fourteen years living beside and three weeks grieving.

Mother, she thought, with her whole opened heart. *Bella*.

The thread quivered, as if it heard her. She reached for it. She poured herself down it, toward the warm familiar stillness, toward the answer to every question she had not let herself ask since the morning the world ended, *what happened to you, what were you, were you like me, did you touch this place too, why did you tell me to be careful who I let see me do it*. She reached, and reached, and the thread led on and on into a depth she could feel had no bottom she could reach, not today, not like this, not yet. She could see that it connected to her. She could not follow it to where it led. The source held the far end of it somewhere she could not go, behind something she had no name for, and the harder she pulled the clearer it became that she was a girl with her hand in a pool and the thing at the other end was older and deeper than the world, and would not be pulled.

She wept. She did not decide to. In the cave, alone, with her hand in the source of all magic and her mother's stillness shining faint and unreachable at the end of a thread she could not follow, the held thing in her finally got out, hot and silent, running down her face in the dark where there was no one, no one at all, to see her do it. She let it. For once in her life she let it, because the only witness was the source itself, and the source did not count, the source was not a person, the source would not love her differently for the water on her face. She knelt at the pedestal and cried for her mother into the oldest magic in the world, and the world did not end, and no one saw, and the thread shone on at the edge of her reach and did not come closer and did not go away.

* * *

And then, at the very edge of the moment, she felt the other thing, and the crying stopped cold in her throat.

It was an absence.

She had become, in three weeks, a girl who could feel the shape of magic in a room, the cores and the threads and the bright lattice of the living world. And here, at the far rim of the source's vast humming awareness, off past the place where her mother's thread ran down into the dark, there was a place where the lattice did not run thin, the way the dark-side wound ran thin. There was a place where it simply was not. A patch in the great bright weave of everything where there was nothing, no line, no hum, no glow, not even the cut and frayed faintness of the severed dark. An absence shaped like a hole, and the hole was not empty the way a clear sky is empty; it was empty the way a held breath is empty, a waiting emptiness, a nothing that had an edge to it, as though something on the other side of the world's weave were pressed up against the underside of it, in a place the source's memory flinched from and would not show her.

She felt it for less than a second. The source seemed to feel her notice it and drew her attention away, gently, the way you turn a child from a window. But she had noticed. She buried it in the deepest and most uncomfortable place she kept, the place she did not visit, and she thought, with a cold that had nothing to do with the cave: *there is something the oldest magic in the world is afraid of.*

She drew her magic back out of the pool, and let go.

* * *

She came back into the cave whole, and shaking, and changed. The pool's light had returned to its even pale glow. The split symbol was gone from its surface. The thread to her mother was gone, or rather hidden again, sunk back down into the source's keeping, and she stood at the pedestal with her hand wet and her face wet and her core, when she checked it, vast, a thing that had been a hearth and was now nearer a furnace, and she understood she would

have to learn it all over again, how much she could do, how little it cost her now.

She wiped her face on her sleeve, twice, carefully, until there was no trace. She breathed until the shaking stopped. She put the careful girl's face back on, settled it, tested it. *No one sees you do it.* The cave had seen. The cave did not count. By the time she turned back to the portal she was, on the outside, only a top-ranked student who had been to a strange place and got a bigger core, which was the whole of what the Chancellor expected to walk back through the seam, and she gave it to him.

The portal opened to her touch from this side, an easy thing now, almost nothing, and she stepped back through into sunlight that struck her like a blow after the dark, and stood squinting in the swept arena while her eyes remembered the day.

The Chancellor rose from his bench and came toward her with a searching look, the glasses still on. "Did it go well?"

"What was that place?" she asked, before he could read too long, giving him a question to answer instead of a face to read.

He shrugged, easy, practiced. "No one truly knows. The prevailing theory is that an artifact lies hidden there that strengthens a mage. The pedestal holds a kind of liquid magic. All anyone has ever gained from it is a larger core." His pale eyes moved over her. "Yours has grown. I can see it has. Good."

"Does it only work once?"

"Once. Even if you found your way back, it would do nothing more." He had marked her glance toward where the portal had been. He marked everything. "It should not need saying that this is not a thing to discuss with your school friends. The reason we send only the top student is that we trust such a one to use new strength wisely. You strike me as

wise." A pause she felt as a hook. "Do you believe you have that wisdom?"

"I'll try to," she said, which was not quite yes and not quite no, and was the truest thing she had said to him all day.

"Good. Good." He put a hand on her shoulder, light, steering her toward the school, and as they walked he asked her, pleasantly, what she meant to do once she had graduated, and she said she hadn't decided, it was years away. "Ah, but the years fly," he said. "It will feel like only tomorrow that you leave *this place*" that did not fit the kindness around it, a flatness, a thing laid down over a thing he knew and she did not, and she walked the rest of the way to the dining hall watching him from the side of her eye and adding it to the list.

He asked her one more thing, at the door, with his hand still light on her shoulder. He asked it as though it were nothing, an afterthought, the kind of small pleasant question a kindly old man asks a clever child.

"The pool," he said. "When you touched it. Did you see anything? Hear anything? Some students report a sort of dream. Voices. Pictures. It's quite harmless. I only ask because the testers like to know."

It was a trap, and she saw the whole of it in the half-second she had to answer. If others saw nothing and she said she had, she marked herself as different in the one way she could least afford. If others *did* see something and she said she hadn't, she might mark herself as a liar to a man wearing glasses built to catch lies. She did not know which it was. So she gave him the answer that was true of the surface and false of the depth, the answer that fit either shape.

"I felt my core get bigger," she said. "That's all. It was just dark, and cold, and then I felt bigger when I came out. Was I supposed to see something?" She let a thread of worry into it, a good student afraid she had done the special thing wrong. "Did I do it wrong?"

The Chancellor studied her for a long moment over the silver rims, and she held the worried face and banked the furnace down to an ember and let him look his fill. Whatever the glasses told him, his own expression did not change; it stayed grandfatherly, stayed warm, gave her nothing in return for what he was taking. "No," he said at last. "No, child. You did it exactly right." And he opened the door, and the noise of the hall came out to meet them, and she understood two things at once: that she had passed whatever that last question was, for now, and that a man did not ask a question that careful unless he had a reason to think the answer might be *yes*, which meant someone, sometime, had come back from that pool seeing more than a larger core, and the Chancellor knew it, and had been watching her the whole afternoon to find out whether she was another one.

* * *

There is a moment she would return to for the rest of her life, and this was the end of it: the doors of the dining hall opening, and the whole school on its feet, the teachers too, applauding, the warm roar of it breaking over her, the top student returned in triumph from the secret honor. She let her face be pleased and overwhelmed and shy, which was not hard, because she was overwhelmed, only not by what they thought.

She found her bench through the noise. Lor-ar was curled on it in his cat shape and lifted his head as she sat, and pressed against her side, and down the bond, quiet

under the clamor, he said, *You are weeping behind your face. I can feel it. What did you see in there.*

Later, she told him. *Not here.* She looked out over the clapping hall, the rows of girls she had eaten beside for a month, who thought they had just watched a gifted first-year do well on a test. Down the high table the Chancellor stood among the teachers, and he had taken the glasses off at last, and was talking to Lady Lightwell with his grandfatherly smile, and Lightwell was smiling back with her armor on, and neither of them was looking at Viridia at all, which she trusted least of everything that had happened that day.

That night, in the dark of her room with Alice not yet back from the ward, she told Lor-ar. She told him all of it in a low voice with the mana-sight up to watch the door, the cave and the pool and the pact and the cut in the world, and he listened the way he listened to the things that mattered, not moving, not interrupting, his lightning-blue eyes fixed on her in the dark.

"So now you truly know," he said, when she had finished, "how broken your people have made themselves. I have known it three hundred years. I did not think to see a human girl learn it in an afternoon." He was quiet a moment. "And the thread. The one you could not follow."

"My mother." She had not been able to say it in the cave, even to the cave. She could barely say it now. "It was her. I know it was her. The source has her somewhere in it and I couldn't get to her." The pressure rose up behind her eyes again and she breathed it down. "Lor-ar. Why would she be there. People aren't *in* the source. You said yourself we're only threads off it. Why does she have a thread that goes *down*, into it, that none of the others have?"

"I do not know," Lor-ar said, and the honesty of it was its own kind of cold comfort, because he did not soften it. "I have never heard of such a thing. It may be a great gift in

your line, or a great wound, or both; in my experience the two are usually the same object seen from different sides. I know only that you must not try to follow it again until you are far stronger and far less alone, because a thread that runs into the source runs into something with no bottom, and a girl who falls into a thing with no bottom does not come back to tell anyone what was down there." He let that sit. "Ask Drake. Or Varissa. They were alive when the pact was made; Drake was *there*. If anyone living knows what your mother was, it is one of them. Do not ask in writing. Do not ask where the school can hear."

She nodded in the dark. And then she told him the last thing, the thing she had not told the Chancellor and had hardly let herself look at, the absence, the waiting empty place at the rim of the world's weave that the source itself flinched from. Lor-ar went very still when she described it, stiller than his usual false-sleep stillness, a real stillness, the stillness of an old animal that has heard, far off, a sound it learned to fear before it learned anything else.

"Say that again," he said. "Slowly. The shape of it."

She said it again. A hole in the lattice. Not thin like the dark-side wound. Not there at all. Empty the way a held breath is empty, with an edge to it, with something pressed against the underside.

Lor-ar was silent for a long time.

"I do not know what that is," he said at last, and for the first time since she had known him there was something underneath his voice she had never heard in it before, a thing she would not have a name for until much later and would wish, then, that she had named sooner. "But I know that the source is older than my people, and my people are older than yours, and in three hundred years of walking the spirit road I have never once heard of a thing that the source is afraid of. File it where you file the worst things. Tell no

one. And hope, little one, that you never feel it again." He came and pressed his great head once against her chest, over the stone and the small grey blade. "Sleep, if you can. You have carried more today than anyone should carry in a year, and you have carried all of it alone, and you will go on carrying it alone, because there is no one else who can. That is the cost of what you are. I am sorry for it. I would not change you."

She lay down with him curled against her, and sleep stayed away a long while, and somewhere past midnight Alice came in carrying the sharp clean smell of the ward and whispered, "Are you awake? I heard you did *amazing*," and Viridia said, "Go to sleep, Alice," in a voice gentle enough that Alice laughed and did, and the wrongness of it, the loving warm wrongness of being congratulated for the surface while the depth sat uncarried beside her, was the loneliest she had felt since the morning the world ended.

She had been alone in the loudest room she had ever stood in that afternoon, the whole school on its feet and clapping for the wrong thing, none of them knowing what she had truly carried back through the seam. She was alone now too, with a tiger at her chest and a sleeping friend within reach. The aloneness was not the room. It was what she carried, and it would go where she went.

Somewhere in a guest wing of the school the High Chancellor was sleeping, or not sleeping, behind his grandfatherly face. He had sent a clever first-year into the oldest magic in the world to make her stronger and more grateful and easier to keep. He had asked his careful last question to find out whether she had seen too much, and she had lied to him with a worried face, and he had let her, for now. But he had asked the question. Which meant he half suspected the answer. Which meant the most dangerous person at Hazel that night was not the white-robed man

asleep behind his glasses, for all the power the capital had handed him, but the silver-blond girl in the dark who had come back from the well *knowing* – knowing the cut in the world and the chance it might be mended, knowing the thread to her mother she could not follow, knowing the one waiting empty place the source itself was afraid of. She held all of it alone. And she lay awake holding it, and somewhere past her reach the thread to her mother shone on in the deep, and on the far rim of everything the absence waited with its terrible edge, and the not-knowing of the man who had sent her in was, for now, the only thing keeping her alive.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Amber Returns

She had slept badly, the well and the thread and the waiting empty place turning under her all night, and woke before the bell and lay watching the grey light come up and sent the sight out once, low, toward the ridges, the way she could not stop herself doing now. The thinning was still there. It had not crossed in the night; small mercy. But it had not gone back either, and somewhere past it a pen was being held above a line. Two clocks, both running. She banked the dread down where it lived and got up to dress, because the day did not care what she had carried back through the seam, and the day still wanted a careful first-year in it.

Amber came to the door before she had finished, and she did not knock so much as arrive, the door opening a hand's width on her grin and her dark chipped nails curled around its edge.

"You're alive," Amber said. "I had a bet with myself. I won."

"You didn't think I would be?"

"I thought the Chancellor would take one look at you and put you in a box and ship you to the capital with airholes." She came in and dropped onto the end of Viridia's bed in her usual lounging sprawl, all loose limbs and no apology, and propped her head on one hand. But the joke was a thin skin over something else, and Viridia, who read people the way

she read everything, saw under it the relief, real and large and badly hidden, the relief of someone who had spent a whole afternoon not knowing and pretending she wasn't counting the hours. "You went into the arena with the most dangerous man alive and you came out and they clapped. I heard about the gold disc. The whole school's heard about the gold disc. Della's telling people you made the test cry."

"The test didn't cry."

"Don't tell Della that. It's the best version." Amber's eyes moved over her, quick, the appraising flick of an older girl checking a younger one for damage she might be hiding. "Are you all right? Truly. Not the face you give the room. The other one."

Viridia paused with the second sock half on. It was a strange thing, to be asked the real question by the person who had taught her, by example, how to deflect it. Amber deflected everything. Amber turned sincerity aside with a joke the way Venquar turned a spear. And here she was, asking it straight, with no joke under it, which meant she meant it, which meant Viridia owed her something true in return.

"No," she said. "But I'm all right enough to do today. I'll be more all right tomorrow."

Amber looked at her a moment longer, then nodded, satisfied, and the grin came back. "That's the most honest thing anyone's said to me all week. God, it's exhausting here. Everyone's so *brave*." She rolled onto her back and addressed the ceiling. "I came to take you to breakfast, by the way. The proper way. As your sponsor. I have spent this entire year being the worst sponsor in the history of Hazel, I sponsored you and then immediately got you a tiger and a dragon and a tribe of monsters and never once told you which fork to use, and I intend to make it up to you by

buying you a second breakfast and watching people be afraid to sit near us."

"You don't buy breakfast. It's free."

"Then I shall *acquire* you a second breakfast, at no cost, through the ancient art of taking it." Amber sat up. "Come on. Get your tiger. Let's go be the most frightening table in the room."

* * *

They were, in fact, the most frightening table in the room, and it was the best morning Viridia had had since the morning the world ended.

She did not realize that until later, the way you never realize you are inside the good hour while you are inside it. At the time it was only breakfast: Amber at one elbow ticking off on her fingers the entire faculty's secret weaknesses ("Mr. Cote's terrified of his own wife, you can tell by how he stands when she visits; Mrs. Vicks keeps a flask in the creatures' shed, don't tell, it's the only thing that gets her through the molting season"), Lor-ar curled on the bench between them being passed pieces of sausage and pretending, for the benefit of the room, to be an ordinary if oversized cat, and then Alice arriving in a rush from an early ward shift, her hair coming out of its plait, dropping onto the bench across from them with the particular tired glow she got from the work she loved.

"I *missed* it," Alice wailed, reaching for the toast. "I was three corridors away with my arm in a bucket of cooling salve and you were making the test go *gold*, and I missed the entire thing, and now everyone's talking about it and I have to pretend I was there. Tell me everything. Don't leave out the part where the Chancellor's face did something."

"The Chancellor's face didn't do anything," Viridia said.

"That's the most frightening sentence I've ever heard. Amber, isn't that frightening?"

"Deeply," Amber agreed. "A face that does nothing is a face that's busy underneath." She caught Viridia's eye for half a second, just half, the warning in it gentle and real, *be careful what you say even here*, and then turned it back into a joke before Alice could catch the weight of it. "Speaking of busy. Pembroke. I hear you set a third-year's wrist yesterday and didn't faint."

Alice flushed with pleasure and tried to hide it and failed, the way she always failed to hide a good thing. "Healer Brun let me do it myself. She said I had," and here Alice dropped her voice, reverent, *"calm hands"*. She's never said that to anyone. Petra's been doing the helper rotation for two years and Healer Brun told *her* she had hands like a startled goose."

"You have calm hands," Viridia said. It was true. She had watched Alice work, once, through the ward door, and the thing that struck her most was not the skill, which was real, but the stillness of her, the way the chatter fell off her the moment a person needed her, the way her whole loud anxious wonderful self went quiet and certain over a hurt that needed mending. Alice did not believe she belonged anywhere. Alice belonged, completely, over a wounded wrist, and did not know it, and it was one of the small private griefs Viridia carried that she could not make Alice see herself the way the work saw her.

"You both have," she said, looking from one of them to the other, Amber sprawled and dry and damaged, Alice glowing and tired and certain, the two of them bickering now about whether a startled goose had calm hands or not, and Lor-ar warm against her hip, and the bond with Raizen humming low and content from wherever he hid in the hills, and Viridia felt, all at once and without warning, something

that had been absent from her since a kitchen that no longer existed, a feeling she had no word for that morning and would spend the rest of her life trying to get back.

She belonged. Here. At this frightening table, with these two impossible people, in a school built to destroy what she was. For the length of one ordinary breakfast she was not the only whole person she had met or the most dangerous girl at Hazel or the keeper of a thread she could not follow. She was a girl whose friend had calm hands and whose sponsor was acquiring her a second breakfast through theft, and she was, against every odd and every grief, happy.

She did not know it was the last morning. The good hour never announces itself; it only becomes precious afterward, when you would give anything to be bored at that table again, listening to two girls argue about geese.

There was a moment, near the end of it, when she almost told them.

Not everything. She could not have told everything; there was too much, and some of it was Lightwell's to give and not hers, and some of it would have put a weight on Alice that Alice should not have to lift. But she came close, for one breath, to telling them about the well. About the thread with her mother's name on it. The want to set it down rose up in her so hard her throat ached with it, the simple animal want to not be the only one who knew, to look across a table at two people who loved her and say *I touched the oldest magic in the world and it had my mother in it and I could not reach her*, and to let them carry even an ounce of it with her.

She watched the want crest. She watched Alice laugh at something Amber said, freckles bunching, the one crooked tooth showing, entirely unguarded, entirely safe in the belief that the worst thing in her world was a startled goose. She watched Amber watch the room from under her lashes, already carrying more than anyone her age should, already

cracked along a fault Viridia could see and could not mend. And she let the want crest and break and go back down unspoken, because telling them would not have lightened her; it would only have darkened them, and she loved them too much to do it for the sake of her own loneliness. So she said nothing, and reached for the toast, and the moment passed, and only she knew it had happened. It was, she thought, the truest thing she could do for them, and the loneliest, and the two were, as Lor-ar said, usually the same object seen from different sides.

* * *

It was Amber who told her about the war, later, when Alice had gone back to the ward and they had walked out to the cold edge of the eastern lawn where the wind would take their words before any window could catch them.

"You should know where things stand," Amber said. She had stopped lounging. Out here, with no room to perform for, she became someone else, someone older and tireder and harder, the someone who had found her parents dead at eight and shattered her own core to say goodbye. "Lightwell would tell you herself but she's being watched now, with the Chancellor still here, so it falls to me. You're one of us, whether anyone's said the words to you or not. You have a right to know what you're standing in the middle of."

"Tell me."

"You know about Jazen." Not a question; Lightwell had told her some of it, in the warded office. "The resistance. The fourth-years running supplies. You know there's a peace, of a kind. A bad peace, but a peace." Amber pulled her thin chain out from her collar and turned the pale stone over in her fingers, the artificial light-core that hid the shattered dark one beneath. "Here's the part you don't know. The peace is held by a single thread, and the thread is this: Jazen

has sworn there will be no war, no march on the capital, nothing, so long as the capital does not kill another dark mage by decree. Not in a raid, those happen, those are war already in everything but name. By *decree*. An official killing. A sanctioned one, signed and stamped, the state saying out loud that being born with a dark core is a crime worth death." Her jaw worked. "He's terrified of himself, Jazen. Two years ago they burned his sister Jan in a raid, and he—" she stopped. "He killed a great many soldiers. Alone. In about a minute. He's spent every day since trying to make sure he never has a reason to do it again, because he knows what's in him and he's more afraid of it than the capital is. So he holds the line at the decree. One more sanctioned killing, and he says he stops holding."

Viridia stood quiet in the wind, doing the cold arithmetic of it. "And the Chancellor's here," she said. "Now. After hearing rumors that Lightwell trains dark mages. After watching me make a test go gold." The shape of it assembled itself in her, ugly and clear. "He's not here for the ranking test. He's here to decide whether the rumors are true. And if he decides they're true—"

"Then he goes home and signs a decree," Amber said quietly. "And the line breaks. And the war Lor-ar keeps telling you is coming, comes." She let the stone drop back under her collar. "That's why everyone's so brave, Viridia. That's the brave you've been smelling all month. We're all standing on a frozen lake in spring listening for the crack."

"What's the plan? If it breaks."

"If it breaks, Lightwell pulls us. The dark-mage girls. You, me, the others with the pale stones. We go to Jazen's camp through whatever doors we can make or find, and we don't come back, because there won't be anything to come back to." Amber said it flatly, a thing she had clearly said to herself many times until it stopped being able to frighten

her. "She's been ready for it since before you came. She's a general running a school, that woman. She's been ready for the bad day the whole time she's been pouring everyone tea."

Viridia thought of Lightwell's blue shoes, the one human thing, the scuffed plain blue under all that composure. She thought of the armor that had crossed the woman's face for one breath when the Chancellor stepped through the portal. *That is the warning. She let you see it on purpose.*

"How will we know," Viridia said. "If it breaks. How will we know in time."

Amber looked at her, and something crossed her face that Viridia would remember later with terrible clarity, a flicker of the dark humor she used for armor, deployed one last time against a thing too large to look at straight.

"Oh, you'll know," she said. "That kind of thing doesn't sneak up on you. It comes through the front door."

They stood a while in the wind without talking, which was, Viridia was learning, the thing Amber found hardest, the not-filling-silence-with-a-joke. She let her have it. The lawn ran down to the tree line and beyond it the forest went on dark and endless toward mountains Viridia could not see, and somewhere out there was a hidden camp full of people afraid for their lives, and somewhere beyond that was a capital full of people afraid of those people, and the whole of it balanced on one frightened man's promise and one frightened school's secrets, and Viridia, fourteen years old with both halves of the gift, was somehow standing near the center of it.

"Why did you sponsor me," she said. She had asked it once before, in the office, and Amber had deflected it with a joke. She asked it again now, in the wind, where there was no room to perform for.

Amber was quiet a long moment. "Because of the stone," she said finally. "Your mother's stone. The dark-blue one. I saw it the day you came through the gates, before I saw anything else about you, before I knew you were quiet or clever or any of it. I saw a girl holding a grief the exact size of mine and holding it the exact way I learned to, so that not a soul would catch her at it." She looked out at the trees. "I was given a chance, when I was younger than you. Someone took a risk on a shattered girl and it's the only reason I'm alive. I told myself, when I came here, that if I ever saw a kid carrying what I carried, I'd give them the chance I got. I didn't think it'd be a three-day first-year with a stone and a face like a closed door. But there you were." The grin came back, but slower, with the truth still under it this time. "And then you went and summoned a tiger, so I think the universe was showing off. Don't let it go to your head."

It was the most Amber had ever given her at once, and Viridia took it carefully, the way you take a thing someone does not give easily, and did not spoil it by saying too much back.

"Thank you," she said. The flat one-word-plus-one she gave when she meant it most. "For the chance."

"Don't thank me yet," Amber said, turning back toward the school. "The chance I gave you was the chance to be in the middle of all this. It may turn out to be the worst gift anyone ever handed you." She bumped Viridia's shoulder with her own, once, rough and brief and real. "Come on. It's cold and I've performed enough sincerity to last me a season."

* * *

The Chancellor left the next day, by portal, the way he had come, with his two grey examiners and his silver glasses folded away. Viridia watched the seam of light close behind

him from the dining-hall window and did not let herself feel relief, because relief was a thing you felt when something was over, and she did not believe this was over. He had asked the careful question. He had let her lie. A man like that did not let a lie go because he believed it. He let it go because he had not yet decided what to do about it, and a man deciding is more dangerous than a man decided, because you cannot see the moment the deciding ends.

But the days that followed were ordinary, and ordinariness, she was learning, was its own kind of mercy. Her classes resumed, the ones she still attended; the night lessons went on in the scorched ring; Raizen came back from the hills, larger again, his speech surer, and slept curled in the rafters of her room or, when the night was warm, took her flying low over the black forest while the school slept. The Dangris came twice and took her apart and built her back. She learned her new core, the vast one, learned how little the old spells cost it now, learned to hold its hugeness down to a flicker by daylight as she had taught herself to hold the dark side closed. She was getting good at being less than she was. It was the most important skill she owned.

Once, midway through those two weeks, a runner came in at dusk, mud to the knees, and was taken straight to Lightwell's office and not seen again that night, and the next morning Amber found Viridia at the spear-corner and said only, low, "They named another one. In the capital. A weaver, this time." And when Viridia asked, *signed?*, Amber said, "Not yet. Drawn up. Sitting on the desk for the second time this month," and went away again before the dread could find a face to wear. The deciding Viridia had felt in the Chancellor was not idle, then. Somewhere a pen was being held above a line, set down, picked up again. The greyness on the ridge and the decree on the desk were the same clock

told two ways, and both hands were moving, and neither was moving back.

And in the evenings there were the three of them, when the rotations allowed it, in the warm lamplit room: Alice with her jars and her ward stories, Amber drifting in to lounge and steal and deflect, Lor-ar holding court from the pillow on the worst and best subjects, Raizen offering dry commentary down the bond that Viridia relayed and that made Alice shriek with laughter and demand to know what the dragon had said about her hands. For a span of perhaps two weeks, the worst peace in the world held, and inside it, in a lamplit room in a doomed school, four people and a tiger and a dragon built a small ordinary happiness, the kind nobody writes down because nothing happens in it, the kind you only understand the value of when it is gone.

One of those evenings, the rotations left just the two of them, Viridia and Alice, in the lamplit room, which had not happened in weeks and which Viridia noticed the way she noticed everything she had been quietly missing without letting herself say so.

Alice was sorting her medical jars, holding each up to the lamp and squinting at the half-faded labels, and she said, without turning around, "We don't do this anymore. Did you notice? Just us."

"I noticed."

"I thought it was me being daft." Alice set a jar down a little too carefully. "You've got the tiger, and the night things you don't tell me about, which is fine, it's *fine*, I let people have their things, I'm good at it. And I've got the ward, and the night rotation now, and Amber's always about. So there's never just." She gestured at the small space between their two beds, the populated half and the once-bare one, both lived-in now. "Just the room. The way it was the first night, when neither of us knew anybody and we had to make do

with each other." She tried to make it light and did not quite manage it. "I miss it. Is that allowed? You're my best friend and I see you least of anyone I love."

It landed in Viridia the way the truest things did, under the ribs, where she kept the held weight. She thought of the well, and the thread, and the hearth wheeling vast and secret under her own breastbone, and the whole long list of things she carried that Alice would never feel the shape of, the lonely kindness she had chosen in this same room three weeks ago and chose again, silently, now. She could not give Alice the truth. But she could give her the thing under the truth, which was that the not-telling had never once been a not-loving.

"It's not because I don't want to," Viridia said. It was as close to the whole of it as she could come. "Everything I keep from you, I keep *for* you. I need you to believe that, even when I can't show you why. You are not a thing I outgrew. You are the thing I'm trying to keep safe." She heard how much it gave away and did not take it back. "The first night was the best thing that happened to me here, and it happened before any of the rest of it. I haven't forgotten which order it went in."

Alice's eyes went bright, and she let them, because Alice never hid anything. "Now look what you've done," she said thickly. "I was going to be cross with you and you've gone and said a thing." She crossed the small floor and sat down on the edge of Viridia's bed, where Lor-ar made a put-upon noise and resettled, and she leaned her head, briefly, on Viridia's shoulder, the wordless *I'm here* of the very first morning given back the other way around. "All right," she said. "I forgive you for being mysterious. But I want one of these. Just us. Once a week, no tigers, no Amber, no wards. You and me and a closed door and nobody being brave at each other." She lifted her head. "Promise."

"I promise," Viridia said, and meant it with everything she had, and did not know, could not have known, that the week the promise was meant to be kept in would not come.

* * *

She talked about the threat with Raizen, in the night air, where it was safe to say true things. He had a way of cutting through her careful arithmetic to the bone of a thing that she had come to rely on, the way she relied on Lor-ar, only younger and fiercer and without the patience the centuries had taught the tiger.

"You keep saying *if* the war comes," he said one night, the two of them high over the forest, the wind taking her words the moment she spoke them. "You have stopped believing the *if*. I feel it in you. You believe it is *when*. So why do you still say *if*?"

"Because saying *when* makes it real," she said. "And while it's *if*, I get to have the breakfasts."

She felt his understanding come warm down the bond, and under it, his disagreement, which he did not soften, because he had her temper as well as Lor-ar's sense. "That is the one place your cleverness fails you," he said. "You think if you do not name a thing it cannot come. You have it backwards, little one. The unnamed thing comes anyway, and finds you unready, because you spent the time you might have used to ready yourself pretending the time was longer than it was." A slow wingbeat. "Name it. *When* the war comes. Say it, and then go on having your breakfasts, but have them knowing. The breakfast is not made worse by knowing. It is made dearer."

She was quiet, riding the long muscled warmth of him through the dark, turning it over. And because she was high, and the night was clear, she sent the sight out toward the rim of the world the way she had at the assembly window,

and found the dimness again, that thin grey wrongness on the horizon, the Hollowing, the country where the threads of life had begun to fail. It sat nearer than a week ago. She was almost sure of it. The greyness had crept in toward the mountains the way a stain creeps up cloth, slow enough to doubt and quick enough to dread, and she marked it and held her tongue, telling Raizen nothing, because she had only fear to describe it with and no fact, and she drew her attention back to the warm certain body beneath her.

He was right, and she hated that he was right, and she loved that he would tell her so without dressing it up.

"When the war comes," she said, at last, into the wind. The words cost her. They made the cold lake under her feet realer, the crack she was listening for nearer. But he was right; the world did not feel worse for the saying. If anything the warm room and the calm hands and the ruffled hair felt more precious held against the *when*, the way a candle is brightest in the room it cannot fill.

"Good," Raizen said, satisfied. "Now we are both standing in the truth. It is a colder place than the lie. But you can build on it, which you cannot build on the lie, and when it comes through the door we will not be the ones it surprises." He banked toward the school, the one lit window growing below. "And it will come through the door. Everything that matters does. You only get to choose whether you are standing ready behind it, or asleep with your back to it." He set down soft on the dark roof. "Tonight you may sleep with your back to it. You have earned one more night of that. Tomorrow we ready ourselves in earnest."

She had meant to. In the days that followed she did begin, after a fashion, drilling harder in the scorched ring, learning her vast new core, making lists in her head of doors and escapes the way Lightwell had taught her to notice things. But readiness is a slow craft, and the worst peace held a little

longer, and a little longer, and lulled her, the way a long calm lulls you into thinking the weather will never turn.

* * *

The last night came dressed as nothing at all.

It had been a good evening, an unremarkable one. Alice had come back early from the ward, yawning, full of a story about a second-year who'd turned his own eyebrows blue trying a glamour and come in mortified.

"Healer Brun offered me the night rotation," Alice said, climbing onto her bed, picking at a loose thread on her sock. "The long one. Sit-up-with-the-bad-cases one. Most people swap out of it." She said it the way she said the things she had already decided and wanted, a little, to be talked out of and would not be. "I told her I'd take it. Standing. Every night they'll have me." She caught Viridia's look and lifted her chin, that small brave push of the shoulders Viridia had watched her make on the first day. "I know. It's the hard one. But somebody's got to be the warm voice in the room at three in the morning, and I'm good at it, Viridia, I'm actually good at something, and I'm not giving it up just because it's hard." She softened. "Don't make the face. I want it. It's the first thing I've ever wanted that's only mine."

Viridia did not make the face. She thought, looking at her friend choose the difficult work with her whole open chest, that there was a kind of courage the world never put on its walls, the courage of a person who walks toward the hurt on purpose because someone has to. "It's a good thing to want," she said. "You should have it."

Amber had drifted by and stayed an hour and gone, ruffling Viridia's hair on the way out, which she had never done before and which Viridia had pretended to hate. Now the lamp was low and Alice was asleep in the next bed, one arm flung off the edge of it, breathing the deep even breath

of someone who has done good work and is tired in the right way.

The room held the small ordinary clutter of two girls who lived in it: Alice's medical jars in their crooked row on the sill, half of them still unlabelled; Viridia's four Damascus spears stood in the corner where the spears went, and her quiver beside them; the dark training clothes folded on the chair for the morning's drill; the stub of the candle Alice read by; the dark-blue stone and the small grey blade where Viridia had set them on the nightstand within reach of her hand, the way she set them every night. It smelled of the ward salve Alice carried in her hair, and of lamp oil, and faintly of the cold pine that came in under the window from the forest. It was not a grand room. It was the first room in three weeks that had felt like hers.

Lor-ar lay across the foot of Viridia's bed in his full size tonight, too big for it, his tail hanging off the end, the warm weight of him a wall against the dark. Raizen was curled against her chest, cat-small for sleeping, his prismatic scales gone soft and dim, the bond between them a low steady warmth like a banked fire. Viridia lay in the middle of all of it and could not sleep, not from fear tonight, only from the fullness of the thing, the wanting to stay awake inside it a little longer.

She thought of the thread in the well. She did that most nights now, before sleep, reached toward the memory of it, the quiet familiar presence at the far end she could not follow. *Mother*. She did not cry. She had cried in the cave, the once, where no one could see, and that had been enough to last her a long while; the held thing sat quiet in her tonight, almost peaceful, the grief gone soft at the edges the way a wound goes from a scream to an ache. She thought, *I have a tiger and a dragon and a friend with calm hands and a sponsor who ruffled my hair, and somewhere there is a thread that goes*

down into the oldest magic in the world with your name on it, and one day I will be strong enough to follow it, and I will come and find out what you were, and what I am, and why you told me to be careful. It was almost a prayer. It was the most hopeful thing she had let herself think in three weeks.

Lor-ar shifted at the foot of the bed and opened one eye, the lightning-blue of it catching the last of the lamp. *You are awake,* he said down the bond. *Sleep, little one. There is nothing to keep watch for tonight.*

I know, she said. *I just don't want to stop being here yet.*

Here, he repeated, not a question, turning the small word over the way he turned over the things she said that interested him. *You mean this room. This bed. The dragon at your heart and the girl across the way.*

I mean all of it, she said. *I mean today. The breakfast. Amber ruffling my hair. Alice and her goose. I keep thinking if I stay awake I can keep today from being over.*

You cannot, Lor-ar said, gently, without cruelty, the way he told her every hard true thing. *No one can. The day ends whether you watch it or not. But I will tell you a thing three hundred years has taught me, which your books have not, because your books are written by people who die too soon to learn it.* He settled his great head down. *The good day is not lost when it ends. It becomes a thing you carry. You have a kitchen you carry. You will carry this. When the cold times come, and they come for everyone, little one, you reach into yourself and you take out an ordinary breakfast where two girls argued about a goose, and you hold it, and it warms you, and no one can take it from you, because it has already happened, and what has happened cannot be unhappened.* A low rumble, almost a purr, ran the length of him. *So. Stop trying to keep the day. Let it end, and keep it forever instead. That is the better bargain.*

She lay with that a long moment, and felt it settle into her the way his true things did, slow and permanent.

He understood her, she felt; three centuries had taught him the worth of an ordinary hour. *Then be here a little longer*, he said. *I will keep the watch you do not need to keep.* And he settled his great head down on his paws, and the watch he kept was the watch of a creature for whom nothing in three hundred years had ever come through the door without warning.

Viridia lay in the warm dark between the two of them, the tiger at her feet and the dragon at her heart and her friend asleep an arm's length away, and let herself, for once, simply be happy, and unafraid, and held. The lamp guttered and went out on its own. The room breathed. Outside, the school slept, and the forest slept, and the worst peace in the world held one more night, the way ice holds right up until the moment it doesn't.

She fell asleep smiling, which she had not done since a kitchen that no longer existed.

It was the last time for a long while.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Attack

The morning it happened began like any other, which is the thing no one tells you about the worst day of your life: that it wears the same clothes as all the ordinary ones, right up until it doesn't.

Viridia woke before the bell. Alice was already up and gone, on an early ward shift; her bed was made, badly, the way Alice made it, the corner left loose. Lor-ar was a warm cat-shaped weight on the pillow. Raizen was away in the hills, hunting with Drake; he had gone two nights past and would not be back before tomorrow, and the place in her where the bond lived hummed low and content and distant, his wordless wellbeing reaching her across the miles like a hand held loosely in the dark.

She dressed. She ate breakfast at the frightening table without Amber, who had a job that morning, and without Alice, who was three corridors away with her calm hands. She went to her one remaining class. The day did its ordinary work.

And under the ordinary, all morning, something was wrong, and she could not find it.

It was the thing she did, find the detail that did not fit. All day it itched at her and would not come. A core in the dining hall that should not have been there, glimpsed and gone, a flicker of someone's magic with a wrongness in it she could

not name fast enough before the crowd swallowed it. A man she passed in the east corridor at midmorning, in plain clothes, a delivery man perhaps, except that he walked the way the Dangris had taught her to walk, balanced, ready, his weight always under him, a soldier's discipline worn under a laborer's coat. She caught it for half a second and lost him around a corner and told herself she was inventing threats out of a frightened month, the way she had told herself about the glasses, and she had been right about the glasses.

There were other things, small things, that she would line up afterward into the shape of a warning she had failed to read. The kitchens had been short-staffed at breakfast, two of the serving women simply not there, and no one had said why. A wagon had come up the drive midmorning that did not look like the wagons that usually came, the horses too good, the driver too still. At lunch Mrs. Vicks had not come to the hall at all, and Mr. Cote had stood near the doors the whole meal with his arms folded, watching the windows, in a way she had filed and not understood. And over all of it, all day, a feeling she could not name then and would only name much later, the particular dropped-stomach hush of a place where someone has already decided what is going to happen to you and is only waiting for the hour.

In the late afternoon she stopped overruling it. The wrongness had stacked up past the place where she could call it a frightened month, and so she did the thing her whole life had taught her to do: she acted on the detail that did not fit. She went to Lightwell.

She stood outside the warded office with the soldier-in-a-laborer's-coat and the too-good horses and the short-staffed kitchen all lined up in her, and she knocked, and when the voice told her to come she came, and she said it plainly. "Something is wrong. There's a man in the east corridor who walks like a soldier. The kitchens are short and

no one will say why. A wagon came up the drive that wasn't right. I don't have proof. I have the feeling I get before a thing, and I've learned not to argue with it." She heard how thin it sounded, laid out, and laid it out anyway, because the cost of being wrong was a foolish hour and the cost of being right was everything.

Lady Lightwell took off her rose-tinted spectacles and looked at her for a long moment, and what was in her face was not surprise. That was the thing Viridia would turn over forever, after: the woman had not been surprised. "You see clearly," she said, after a silence that lasted too long. "You always have. It is the most dangerous thing about you, and the most useful, and I am sorry for both." She folded the spectacles in her hand. "It is handled, Viridia. Do you understand me? What is coming, I have known was coming, and I have made what arrangements can be made. There is nothing you can add to it but yourself, and yourself is the one thing I will not spend. You will go back to your room. You will keep hidden, exactly as you have learned to. You will not draw a single eye. That is not me dismissing you. That is me giving you the only order that keeps you alive. Will you obey it?"

"Alice is on a ward shift," Viridia said. It came out before she had decided to say it. "If something is coming, I should get her out. Bring her back to the room, or—"

"Alice is where she is needed, and where the wards are thickest, and where I would put a girl I wanted safe." Lightwell's voice did not soften, because softening it would have made it a lie. "Moving people tonight is how people are found. You will leave her where she is, and you will go to your room, and you will trust that I have counted the same heads you are counting. Go, Viridia. And whatever you hear in the night, you stay hidden. Promise me that."

And Viridia, standing in the warded office with every instinct in her screaming to gather the two people she loved and run, made the choice to obey. She told herself it was the disciplined choice, the survivor's choice, the choice Lightwell had earned the right to ask of her. She went back to her room and she left Alice three corridors away behind the thickest wards in the school, because the Headmistress had said the wards were thick and the heads were counted and the moving of people was how people were found, and because some part of Viridia, the tired grieving part, wanted very badly to be told that it was handled, that for once she could set a thing down and let an adult carry it.

She should not have left her. She would think that, after, on a great many sleepless nights, and she would never be able to prove it would have gone differently, which was the particular cruelty of it: not the certainty that she had chosen wrong, but the never-knowing. She had read the night right and then handed the reading to someone else to act on, and trusted the thickness of wards over the pull in her own chest. The wrongness she had been right about all day she had finally named out loud, and then she had walked away from it, on an order, because being told to do nothing was easier than deciding to do nothing herself.

* * *

The screams came in the deep middle of the night.

She had not meant to sleep at all. She had lain on top of the blankets in her training clothes with a spear within reach, obeying the letter of the order and breaking its spirit, ready, listening, certain she would not go under. Exhaustion had taken her anyway, the way it takes a body that has spent a month learning to be less than it is, and she went down into a thin grey doze full of corridors. And then the sound reached into it and dragged her up, muffled screams

through stone, the wrong sound for a school at night, and Lor-ar was already off the bed and changing, swelling from cat to the full storm-colored bulk of him with a sound like a growl and a sound like the air before lightning, his fur crackling blue in the dark.

"Up," he said. "Now. Dress. Quickly."

She did not think. The month of drills thought for her. She was off the bed and reaching for the dark training clothes folded on the chair, dragging them on over her nightshirt, and her hands were steady, which surprised some far-off watching part of her, her hands were perfectly steady while the rest of her roared. From the corridor outside came crashing, and running feet, and more screams, closer now, and a smell she knew from the clearing, dry and metallic, the smell of fire about to be more than fire.

No one sees you do it, said the old mantra, surfacing on its own. *You decide who sees*. She did not have time to wonder why grief's mantra had come to her in a battle. She shoved her feet into her boots.

The door splintered inward.

It came apart on a single heavy blow, wood bursting inward in a spray of splinters, and a man filled the broken frame, white and gold, the capital's army, a sword already swinging, and Lor-ar did not hesitate. He was across the room before the man had cleared the threshold, three hundred years of killing in one fluid leap, and his jaws closed on the man's throat and tore, one hard wrench of the great head, and the man's blood went up the wall in a long arc and across Alice's badly-made bed and the man folded down into the doorway with his sword unswung.

Viridia froze for one half-second with her own breath loud in her ears and a stranger's blood spattered warm across the foot of the bed where she slept, and the world

narrowed and went cold and clear, the way the source had gone cold and clear, the way everything went when the cataloguing part of her took the helm because the rest of her could not be trusted with it.

She grabbed the quiver. She slung it across her back. She took a spear in her hand. The balance of it was the one familiar thing in a room gone wrong, and she held to it.

"Come," Lor-ar said, blood on his muzzle. "This place is finished. We go."

* * *

The corridor was firelight and smoke.

Lamps had been knocked from the walls. Flame climbed the old dry panelling. Smoke lay along the ceiling and reached down. There were bodies. Viridia made herself not look at them, made herself look only at the next thing and the next, because the cataloguing part could keep her alive but only if she did not let it stop on a girl she had eaten breakfast beside, face-down and still in the burning hall.

Keep moving. Watch the bodies that are standing.

They came at her from a side room, two of them, fast. The first flung himself at her and she met him the way Venquar had taught her, not with the point but with the whole of her body and the whole of the spear, knocking his blade wide with the haft, ducking under the return, and as he overbalanced she swept his feet from under him and put the spearhead through his heart while he was still falling, a thing she would have said a month ago she could never do, a thing she did now without deciding to, her body fluent in a grammar her mind refused to translate.

The second was on Lor-ar. He had blasted the tiger in the side with a gout of pale fire, life-fire, the cruel kind, and Lor-ar had gone into the wall and lay there stunned and smoking, his fur burning where the fire had struck, not

moving, and a cold spike of terror went through Viridia that was entirely her own and not the cataloguing part's at all. She turned. The man who had hit Lor-ar was smiling at his companion, the one she had already killed, not yet knowing he was dead, and another man stood beyond them watching her with his hands loose at his sides and silver cord braided at his shoulders.

A captain.

* * *

"Well," the captain said, conversational, while the hall burned around them and Lor-ar lay smoking against the wall and Viridia stood between them with a stranger's blood drying on her hands. "So one of you dark-mage brats has teeth. Good. It would have been a dull night otherwise, putting children to the sword."

She did not answer. She was looking at Lor-ar, at the slow rise and fall of his side that told her he lived, and she was buying time with her silence the way she bought everything, by watching, by reading, by hunting the detail that would keep her alive. The captain held out his hand and a staff appeared in it, carved white wood, dense with enchantment, and she read it before he had finished summoning it, because reading it was the only weapon she had that he did not know she carried.

A protection rune. A bubble of it, layered and strong: while it held, nothing magical could pass into it, and nothing could pass out.

"These girls weren't dark mages," she said, to keep him talking, to keep his hand off the staff one more breath while she thought. "Most of them. You're killing children who can't even touch a shadow."

"You can plead all you like." He turned the staff in his hand, idle, certain. "The decree is signed. The punishment

for harboring dark mages is death. All of you. The law is the law."

"I have girls of my own," he added, and the dreadful thing was that he meant it, that the cruelty had a tenderness folded into it that made it worse, not better. "Two. About your age. I came so that they grow up in a world where a dark mage is not free to do to them what your kind did at Harrow Field. You think you are the wronged one tonight. So does every soldier in this hall. That is what makes it a war and not a murder."

She understood it then in one cold beat, the whole shape of it dropping into place without his having to lay it out: the careful old man and his silver lenses, the visit that had never been about a ranking test, the headmistress read true through the glass and the decree that followed as surely as night. He had come for Lightwell. He had never seen Viridia at all. She had hidden exactly right, the way her mother taught her, and she had lived because of it, and everyone she could not hide was dying tonight because the woman at the center of it had finally run out of ways to hide herself.

While he talked, she worked.

She did it as Lor-ar had drilled her in the scorched ring, the thing the light mages never learned to fear because they had never had to: she reached out with the dark side of her gift, the hidden half, the half this whole school was built to pretend out of existence, and she inscribed a new rune onto the captain's staff from across the burning hall, fine and fast and silent, linking it to his own protection rune. An explosion rune. She had laid shapes onto objects a hundred times in the scorched ring, onto river-stones and bench-irons until her fingers learned the grave slow patience of it, *the object remembers*, and she had never once done it on a moving target in a burning room with her own

death three strides off. The work was the same. The cost of getting it wrong was not.

And she got it wrong. The third stroke went in inverted, the way it had gone in on the iron bench-arm the night the cold ate two of her fingers, hurry doing to her hand now what it had done then; she felt the line take the wrong meaning the instant she set it, felt the rune turn from a thing that would feed the shield to a thing that would feed *her*, the drinking-cold already reaching back up the link toward the hand that had drawn it. There was no scraping it off. There was only laying a second, truer line over the first before it finished, fast, far too fast for the grave slow patience the work demanded, and she did it with the captain's hand already closing on the staff, did it with the cold biting up her wrist, did it knowing that if this stroke went wrong too she had just built her own death and handed it to a burning room.

It went in true. But the inverted line had already begun to draw, and it took its price on the way out: a fierce drinking cold bloomed up her left forearm and the skin there went white and then split, a long shallow burn-that-was-not-a-burn opening along the muscle where her own botched rune had fed on her before the true line smothered it. She bit down on the cry and locked it behind her teeth. Her arm hung wrong at her side, two fingers numb again and the forearm screaming, and she shifted the spear into the hand that still answered her. She tied the two runes together so that the one would feed the other, so that when he raised his shield, the shield itself would become the bomb, and the bubble that let nothing out would let nothing out.

It was, she understood even as she did it, a death symbol. Not the death-magic Drake had only begun to teach her. A simpler, colder thing. A killing made of someone's own

defense. She did it anyway. She thought of Lor-ar smoking against the wall and the girl face-down in the hall and she did it anyway, and she felt something in her that she would have to look at later, much later, when there was a later, the ease of it, the way the cold clear cataloguing part of her had not flinched at all.

"So you've been sent to wipe us out," she said, evenly, the careful girl's voice even now. "Dark mage or not."

"The law is the law," the captain said again, and raised his staff, and activated the shield.

The protection rune lit. And her rune, riding it, lit half a breath behind.

The blast was a wall of sound. She threw her arm across her face. Inside the bubble that let nothing out, the explosion had nowhere to go, and it ate the captain whole, fire swirling inside the golden shell of his own protection with no seam to escape through, and when it guttered out there was nothing inside the bubble at all, no body, no staff, nothing, only scorched air, and then the bubble itself winked out and the smoke rushed in to fill the space where a man had been.

She did not look at the space. She ran to Lor-ar.

* * *

She pushed healing into him, the vast new core pouring through the shape Alice had taught her, and Lor-ar shuddered and coughed and got his legs under him, the worst of the burn closing under her hands. She put nothing into her own arm. There was not time, and the rune-cold was the cruel kind besides, the kind that resisted mending the way life-fire did; she had felt that even as it bit her. The arm would have to keep until later, or not at all. She wrapped it once, hard, in a strip torn from her own sleeve with her teeth and her good hand, to keep the wrongness in it from spreading down into the fingers she still needed, and let it

be. And where the captain's life-fire had struck the tiger a long seam of skin stayed bare and scarred, the storm-colored fur refusing to come back over it however much of her core she poured in. She had seen that resistance once before, on a fourth-year's arm laid open by a dragon's claws, a lifetime ago. She stopped pouring. Some things did not knit, however whole the one doing the mending. She would have to learn that tonight along with the rest. She smothered the life-fire spreading up the wall with a slap of earth magic that buried it under a fall of conjured soil.

"Up," she said, her own word back at him. "We go."

The ceiling shook. Plaster came down. Somewhere below them, deep in the school, the real fight was happening, the great magics, the building shuddering with each exchange.

"The main hall," Lor-ar said, finding his feet, his voice rough with smoke. "They are fighting in the main hall. That way is out, and out is where the others will be driven. Quickly, little one. Stay behind me where you can. Kill what I miss."

They ran. The corridors were chaos and firelight and Viridia stopped looking for faces because looking for faces was how you died, and she followed the storm-colored bulk of Lor-ar through the smoke.

The school she had learned in a month was unmaking itself around her. The hallway-paintings she had been walked past on her first day, Verrane, the hawk portrait, all of it, were burning in their frames or already gone. The stones underfoot were hot. The smoke had a taste now, more than wood, a sweetness she refused to name. Twice soldiers came at them from side rooms and twice she met them, but the spear was a two-handed grammar and she had a hand and a half, the left arm answering late and weak where the rune-cold had eaten it, and the second man nearly had her

for it. Her parry came a fraction slow; his blade slid off the haft and laid her open across the ribs, a hot line of pain, shallow only because Lor-ar hit him from the side the same instant and turned a killing thrust into a graze. She finished the man with the butt of the haft cracked across his temple and then the point while he reeled, and she came away knowing, in the cold clear part that did the counting, that without the tiger that one would have ended her, that the shield she had felt around herself all month was a thing she had imagined, that tonight she was exactly as killable as the girls face-down in the hall and only luckier. Each time her body did the thing her mind would not watch, the cold clear grammar of the Dangris, *watch the body, the body cannot lie*, and each time she came away with a little more of someone else's blood on her and a little more of her own, and a little more of herself folded down and put away. She did not let herself feel any of it. She banked it the way she banked her core, down into the place she did not visit, for the later that might or might not come. There would be a reckoning for what her hands were learning to do without flinching. There would not be one tonight. Tonight she only had to live, and get them out, and not look at the faces.

They came to the gallery above the main hall and stopped.

* * *

Below them the hall was full of fighting, and it was going to be lost.

She saw it in one sweep, the way she saw everything, the small knots of fourth-years holding clusters of younger girls behind shields, the soldiers coming on in disciplined waves, the fourth-years fighting better than anyone had a right to and still, slowly, being overrun, because the soldiers were seasoned and many and fought with the ferocity of people

who believed they were doing right. And at the center of the hall, on the dais, the two great magics: Lady Lightwell and the High Chancellor, face to face, throwing power at each other faster than the eye could follow, light against shadow, each spell answered by a counter before it landed, two masters so evenly matched that a single faltered breath would end one of them.

Lightwell had her necklace off. Viridia saw it in the mana-sight, the thing she had only ever glimpsed under the false light-core stone: the headmistress's true core, a great black swirling mass, unhidden now, blazing dark, and she was magnificent with it, terrible, a general at last with no more reason to pretend she was anything else.

The two of them moved across the dais in a kind of horrible dance. The Chancellor threw light, hard bolts of it and sheets of white fire, and where the fire fell the dais blackened and the air screamed; and Lightwell answered each with shadow, hands of dark reaching up out of the floor, walls of nothing that swallowed the light before it landed, and between her castings she shaped the shadow into spears and sent them at him so fast that Viridia, who could read magic faster than anyone in the building, lost the thread of who was attacking and who defending. The Chancellor's robe was scorched at one shoulder. There was blood at the corner of Lightwell's mouth. Neither of them gave any ground at all. It was the most skilled and most frightening thing Viridia had ever seen, two people who had clearly known and hated and respected each other across many years, trying with their whole enormous power to end one another, and she thought, watching, that Lightwell was perhaps winning, by a hair, by a breath, and she thought it the way you think a thing you desperately want to be true and do not quite believe.

"You cannot win," the Chancellor was saying, dodging a reaching hand of shadow, his grandfatherly warmth gone entirely, his voice flat and cold and certain. "Even now your students die in the halls. Your treachery ends tonight, Isolde. It was always going to end."

And Lightwell, between one spell and the next, turned her head, and found Viridia in the gallery, and her composed face did not change, but a thought arrived in Viridia's mind, clear and direct and unmistakably the headmistress's, the woman who had been a general all along reaching past a duel to give one last order.

You cannot help me here. Do not try. Save as many as you can. This school is finished. Get them out, and find Jazen. He will shelter you. A beat, and under the order something else, something that was almost, almost the thing a person says to a child they will not see again. *You were chosen, Viridia. I knew the day you came. Go.*

Viridia hated it. Every part of her wanted to go down those stairs and put her vast new furnace of a core into that fight beside the only adult who had ever seen her clearly and not flinched. And every part of her knew the woman was right, knew it the way she knew all the hardest things, in the place that kept her alive. She could not turn the duel. The Chancellor would win it; she could read that much in the patient economy of his castings, a man spending exactly enough and no more, while Lightwell spent everything and was magnificent and was, by inches, losing. *Do not try*, the order had said. She decided, crouched in the smoke of the gallery, to disobey one word of it in a way she could live with.

Not to fight him. She would lose that and be seen losing it. But the alcove was not yet sealed; the eight were not yet gathered; the portal was not yet cast, and all of it needed seconds Lightwell did not have to give, because the moment the Chancellor broke her the soldiers below would turn and

the children would have no one between them and the fire. So Viridia did the small hidden thing instead of the large seen one. She reached out across the burning air with the dark half of her gift and read his thread as Lor-ar had drilled into her across a month of scorched-ring nights, the open core, the bright braided line of a mage's intent laid bare to anyone who knew to look and almost no one did. She found the rhythm of his attack, the half-beat where he gathered before each bolt of white fire, the breath a master takes without knowing he takes it. And into the floor of the dais beneath his lead foot, fine and fast and silent, she laid a single rune, the smallest she had, not a weapon, only a hitch, a thing to make the stone remember to be uneven for one stride. *The object remembers.* She had laid a hundred of them onto river-stones on quiet nights. She had never laid one under a man who could end her with a glance.

He gathered. He stepped. The stone caught his heel, the half-inch she had bought it, and his next bolt went wide of where Lightwell would have been and scorched the dais instead, and Lightwell, given the breath, drove a wall of shadow up between them and held. One beat. Two. It was nothing. It was everything: it was the seconds in which eight children could be put through a hole in the world.

And it nearly cost her the one thing she had left. The Chancellor's head came round, slow, the way a man turns at a sound behind him in an empty house, and his attention swept the gallery, and Viridia felt it pass over her cover like a cold hand laid flat against a door. After a month of being no one, of being less than she was, she had reached out and touched the most dangerous man alive, and for one suspended instant she felt him almost feel the place she was reaching from. She let go of the thread as if it had burned her and pressed flat into the dark behind the balustrade and did not breathe, and the cold hand moved on, finding nothing,

returning to the duel it could not afford to lose. She had not been seen. She had been a hair from it.

She knew, crouched there with her heart slamming, what she had just done and what it meant. She had a furnace in her chest and a craft no one in that hall would have thought a fourteen-year-old carried, and she had spent it, the once, deciding the children's seconds, and she had spent it on the eight. She had not spent it reaching three corridors toward Alice. She would not be able to say, ever, whether she could have. Only that with the one decisive thing she had to give that night, she had aimed it at the many, from cover, and turned away from the dais before she could watch the price of it come due on Lightwell. She nodded once, though Lightwell had already looked away, back into the storm of the fight, and she turned and ran for the stairs with Lor-ar at her heels.

* * *

She found Amber at the foot of the hall, holding a shield.

Amber had backed herself into the alcove under the gallery stairs and thrown up a dome of protection, and behind it huddled the survivors she had managed to gather: three second-years, five third-years, all of them shaking, all of them crying or past crying. Amber's face was grey with strain, her chipped nails dug into her own palms, the dome flickering as soldiers threw spells against it from the open hall, and she was holding it, just, the artificial light-core stone at her throat blazing and the true shattered core beneath it screaming with the cost.

There were no first-years.

Viridia's eyes went over the huddled girls once, twice, the part of her that did the counting already counting and the rest of her refusing the count. Three second-years. Five

third-years. No first-years. No long blond hair coming out of its plait. No freckles. No one with calm hands.

Alice.

The want to turn and run for the medical ward was a physical thing, a hand closing on her heart and pulling. The ward was three corridors away. Alice was on shift. Alice was in the ward with the other helpers, the overflow, *they wanted everyone nearby in case they were needed*, and the ward was three corridors of burning school away, three corridors full of soldiers, and behind Amber's failing shield were eight children who would die in the next minutes if Viridia went after the one.

She had left her once already tonight. That was the thought that came, unbidden and merciless: she had stood in a warded office hours ago and been told the wards were thick and the heads were counted, and she had believed it because believing it was easier, and she had left Alice three corridors away. This was the second time the night had set the one against the many in front of her, and she already knew, sickly, what the cold counting part of her was going to choose, because it had chosen it once before sundown.

She stood at the edge of Amber's shield with the whole of her life narrowing to a single unbearable point.

She ran the arithmetic, because the arithmetic was the only thing that could carry her through it. Three corridors. Burning. Held by soldiers in disciplined ranks who had already killed everyone they had reached. Alice, if Alice still lived, on the far side of them, in a ward they had likely come to first, because a ward full of helpers was exactly the kind of room a captain clearing a building would mark for early. The odds that Alice was alive were already poor. The odds that Viridia could reach her through three burning soldier-held corridors, alone, and bring her back, were poorer. And every minute she spent on those odds was a minute Amber's

shield came closer to failing, a minute eight living frightened children stood between an emptying alcove and a hall full of killers.

The cold clear part of her, the part that did the banking and the face-arranging and the staying-alive, the part that had carried her through every hour since the morning the world ended, laid it out without mercy and without cruelty: *You cannot save the one. You can save the eight. You do not get both. Choose, and live with it, because there is no version of this where you do not have to live with it.*

She made the choice. It was the worst thing she had ever done, worse than the captain, worse than the man in the doorway, worse than any of it, because the captain had been an enemy and this was Alice, this was the girl who had said *Walk with me?* to a silently drowning stranger on the first day of the worst month of her life, this was the only person at Hazel who had ever loved her without wanting anything back.

She did not go for the ward.

She would carry that for the rest of her life, the not-going, the turning away from the three corridors with her friend somewhere at the end of them, and she would never once be sure she had been right, only that she had been responsible, that eight living children were a number larger than one, that Lightwell had said *save as many as you can* and *as many as you can* did not mean *the one you love most*. She made the choice with her face perfectly still and the cold clear part holding the helm and the rest of her drowning silently behind her eyes, and Amber, seeing her, let a gap open in the shield.

"Through," Amber gasped. "Whatever you've got. Now. I can't hold it much—"

Viridia stepped inside and Amber sealed it behind her and the girls crowded in, clutching at her, asking what they

would do, all of them at once, and Lor-ar threw back his head and roared, a sound that shook the alcove, and the girls went silent.

"I have a way out," Viridia said. "But we go now. All of you, close to me. Don't let go."

She raised her hand and opened a portal.

* * *

It tore into being beside her, the well's gift, easy in the scorched ring on a quiet night and not easy now: a portal was a shape held open by a steady hand, and her steady hand was the wounded one. The seam shuddered as she made it, edges crawling, wanting to close on the rune-cold that ran up the arm holding it open, and she had to pour core into it past what it should have cost, far past, to keep the hole in the world from guttering shut while children were standing in it. Lor-ar leapt through it and vanished and came back a breath later.

"Safe," he said. "Woods. No one near. Go."

She pushed the girls through, one and two at a time, three second-years and five third-years stumbling out of the burning hall into somewhere dark and cold and elsewhere, until only she and Amber and Lor-ar were left inside the failing dome, and the soldiers were pressing closer now, sensing the kill, their spells hammering the shield so that Amber staggered with each one.

"You next," Viridia said. "The second you step through, your magic cuts off. The portal won't carry a spell across. So the shield drops when you do. I'll close it the instant you're through. Go."

"Lightwell—" Amber's eyes went up to the dais, where the two great magics still warred, light and shadow, the headmistress's black core blazing in the smoke.

"She told me to get who I could out," Viridia said. The flat voice. The voice that had no room in it for the thing underneath. "You're spent, Amber. We go now or we don't go."

Amber looked at her, and for one second the dark humor was there, the armor, deployed against the unbearable one final time. "Worst gift I ever gave you," she said. "Told you." And she nodded, and stepped backward through the portal with her hands still raised holding the shield, and the moment she crossed, the golden dome winked out, and the whole hall came in at once.

For a heartbeat Viridia was alone in the open with the seam shuddering at her elbow and a wall of soldiers' fire already loosed at the dropped shield, and the portal, fed by a failing arm, began to close on its own a beat before she meant it to, the edges rushing inward toward the gap she still had to fit herself through. The seam narrowed against her shoulder as she went, the cold of it dragging at her wounded arm like a closing door on a sleeve. She threw the last of what she had down into it, not to hold it open but to fling herself through before it ate her. She went through sideways and falling, the spellfire lighting the air white behind her. The seam sealed shut on the heel of her boot, shearing the leather clean off, a hair ahead of the fire that came screaming into the space where she had just been.

The burning hall vanished.

* * *

Moonlight. Cold air. The smell of pine instead of smoke.

They were in the woods, tall trees black against a bright full moon, and the rescued girls were crowded together a little way off, shivering, some of them sitting down hard in the leaf litter, some of them weeping openly now that the running was done. Amber had slumped to the ground where

she stood, the drain hitting her all at once, the holding finally over, her face the color of ash. Lor-ar stood at Viridia's side, the long bare scar across his flank where the life-fire had been and would always be now, a mark that no amount of her would ever take back, his head up, scenting the dark. Viridia stood barefoot on one foot in the leaf litter, her left arm bound in its bloodied strip of sleeve and held against her, the ribs under her other side burning where the blade had grazed her, and she understood, standing there, that she had walked out of that hall by the width of a tiger's leap and a boot heel, and not by anything that deserved to be called safety. The arm would scar like Lor-ar's, she thought distantly. The rune-cold had gone too deep and was the resisting kind. She would carry the night on her skin the way he would, the two of them marked the same, and there was a grim small comfort in that she did not examine.

The school was gone. The portal was closed. There was no thread back to it, no way to know where they were in relation to it, because a portal spanned any distance and she had not chosen the destination so much as fled toward the only camp she knew. She stood half-leaning on Lor-ar with her hands buried in his thick singed fur, and she let herself, for one moment, feel the size of what had just happened, the school burning, the bodies in the halls, the man she had unmade inside his own shield, Lightwell on the dais throwing shadow at the most powerful man alive.

And the empty space.

She turned and counted the girls again, slowly, in the moonlight, though she already knew. Three second-years. Five third-years. The faces white and wet and young, looking to her now, because she was the one still standing, because Amber was down and there was no one else. She counted them, and her eyes moved past the last of them to the dark trees beyond, hunting, the way she hunted everything, for

one more shape that was not there. Long blond hair. A wide smile, one tooth turned a little out of line. A girl who had calm hands and did not know she belonged anywhere and belonged completely over a wounded wrist.

The space where Alice should have been stood in the moonlight, exactly the size and shape of her, and held nothing at all.

She did not cry. There were children watching, and Amber on the ground, and a tiger who needed her, and a long dark walk to a camp that might not take them, and no one, no one, would see her do it. She pressed the want down into the cold place where it would have to wait, beside the captain and the bodies and the choice she had made in the alcove, all of it filed for a later she was not at all sure would ever come, and she straightened, and took her hands out of Lor-ar's fur.

"Up," she said gently, to the shivering girls, the same word she had given the soldiers and the tiger, gentler now, the only word she had left. "We can't stay here. There's shelter. I know the way. Come on."

She helped Amber to her feet, and Amber leaned on her, silent, deeply shaken, and Viridia gathered the children with her quiet steady voice and turned them toward the deeper dark, toward the hidden camp, toward whatever came next, and somewhere far behind them and unreachable the school burned down to its stones, and somewhere among the stones, or out in the dark, or gone, was a girl named Alice Pembroke, and Viridia did not know which, and the not-knowing walked beside her into the woods and did not leave her, then or for a long time after.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Forest and the Camp

They walked through the woods for a long time before anyone could see the school burning, and then they could see it, and Viridia made the girls keep walking so they would not have to watch.

It was a glow first, low and orange behind the black trees, the kind of light that should have been a sunrise and was coming from the wrong place and the wrong direction and far too soon. The children slowed when they saw it. One of the third-years, a girl with a soot-streaked face whose name Viridia did not know and did not ask, stopped entirely and turned to look back, and her mouth opened, and Viridia stepped between her and the glow before the sound could come out.

"Keep walking," Viridia said. Quiet. Even. The voice that had no room in it for the thing underneath. "Don't look at it. Looking at it won't put it out, and we have a long way to go, and I need you walking." She put her hand on the girl's shoulder and turned her, gently, as Lor-ar had once turned her from a window in a cave, and the girl let herself be turned, and walked, and did not look back again, and Viridia did not tell her that she was grateful, because the girl had done the brave thing and naming it would have undone her.

She let herself look, once, over the children's heads.

Hazel was burning. The school founded in 1735 by a woman named Hazel Greenwich, the school with the painting of Verrane in the entry hall and the hawk portrait and the orientation room with nowhere to hide, the school that had been the most dangerous place she could possibly have been and had also, somehow, against all of it, become the first place since the kitchen where she had built a life. It was burning down to its stones, and everyone she had not gotten out was inside it, and she looked at the glow for exactly as long as it took to make herself believe it, and then she turned her back on it and did not look again.

She thought, walking away from it, of all the things the fire was eating. Her mother's spellbook, with the family tree a thousand years deep and the one name on it that carried no dates, the name that fit no pattern, the riddle she had meant to take apart some safer night and never had. It was ash now, and for one cold moment she believed the question had gone into the ash with it, the single thread back into her own blood burned out of the world before she had learned to read it.

Then she made herself think clearly, the way the cold part of her thought, and saw that the book had only ever been a copy. The names were older than the paper they were written on. The blood that carried them was still walking through the dark wood in her own two legs, and the well under the world had held her mother's thread plain and whole and waiting; whatever that dateless ancestor had been, the well would know it, because the well knew everything that magic had ever touched, and her mother's line ran straight down into it. And there was Drake, six thousand years old, who kept the oaths of families further back than any book; and Varissa, who had handed a dragon to her bloodline for reasons no one had yet explained. The book was gone. The question was not. It had simply lost its

easiest door and would have to be opened by a harder one, and she was learning, this year, to open harder doors. She named the loss, and beside it, deliberately, she set the route around it, so that grief would not be the only thing she carried out of the fire. And the letter from Bella she had read every night and held to her chest in the dark. Her focus, the silver rod with the Moravian inscription, the cane Mrs. Zoran had primed for her, gone. The bright ward where Alice had learned she had calm hands. The scorched ring in the forest where the Dangris had taught her, though that at least was outside the walls and might still stand. The frightening table. The lamplit room that had been, for a span of two weeks, the first place that felt like hers. All of it, burning, behind her, while she walked away with a spear and a quiver and a tiger and the clothes she had died in, almost, and nothing else. She had arrived at Hazel with three suitcases and a grief she could not name. She was leaving it with less luggage and more grief and a great deal she had not had before, and she could not yet decide whether that was a fair trade or the cruelest one imaginable, and she suspected she would not be able to decide for a long time.

* * *

The trek went quickly, which surprised her. Fear was a kind of fuel; the children walked faster and complained less than children should have been able to, driven by a thing too large for them to argue with. They talked among themselves in low voices, the way frightened people do, and Viridia let them, because the low talk was keeping them together and keeping them moving, and those were the only two things that mattered.

Amber walked beside her and did not talk at all.

That was the wrong thing, and Viridia noticed it the way she noticed all wrong things, but she did not push, because

she knew exactly what the silence was. Amber, who deflected everything with a joke, who could not bear a quiet without filling it, had gone entirely silent, walking with her arms wrapped around herself and her eyes on the ground, and Viridia understood that the joke-armor had finally run out, that somewhere in the burning hall Amber had spent the last of the thing that let her perform being all right, and that what was left was just a girl who had once found her own parents dead and had now watched a second home burn with people she loved inside it. Viridia tried twice to talk to her, low, careful, *are you hurt, do you need to rest*, and got nothing back but a small shake of the head, and after the second time she let her be, because there was a grief that wanted company and a grief that wanted to be left alone to walk it off, and Viridia of all people knew the difference.

She retreated into her own thoughts instead, and her thoughts went, as they always went now, in two directions at once.

The first was Raizen. He was alive; the bond told her that, a steady warm thread running off into the dark, and she clung to it. But he was far, hunting with Drake in hills she could not place, and he would come back to the school and find it burning and find her gone, and the True Bond would tell him she lived, but a bond was not a map. Portals span any distance. He could feel that she was alive and have no idea where on the turning earth she was. She did not know how he would find her. She held the warm thread and sent down it, wordlessly, again and again, *alive, alive, I'm alive*, and hoped it carried, and could not be sure it did.

The second direction was the one she did not let herself walk down, and walked down anyway, over and over, helplessly, the way a tongue goes to a broken tooth.

Alice.

She did not know. That was the whole of it and the worst of it. If she had seen Alice die she could have begun, in the cold clear way, to carry it. If she had seen Alice get out she could have set the fear down. She had neither. She had an empty space the exact size and shape of her friend, and a ward three burning corridors away that she had chosen not to cross, and no body and no goodbye and no knowing, only the not-knowing, which was its own particular animal, which did not lie down, which walked beside her through the dark woods and would, she already suspected, walk beside her for a very long time.

So she did the only thing she could do, which was ask.

She worked her way quietly down the line of walking children as they went, falling into step beside one and then another, and she asked each of them, low, so as not to start a panic, the same question. "When you came down from the dormitories. Did you come past the medical ward? Did you see anyone come out of it?" She asked the second-years and she asked the third-years, one by one, the soot-faced girl and the small one and all the rest, and she kept her voice even and kind and gave no sign of what the answer meant to her, because they had enough to carry without carrying her fear as well.

None of them had seen. They had been roused from their own halls, on the other side of the school from the ward; they had run the way they were driven, toward Amber's shield, away from the fire; the ward was a wing none of them had passed. One girl thought she had seen helpers running, earlier, before the screaming, but could not say where to or whether Alice had been among them, and Viridia thanked her and did not press, because a frightened memory pressed too hard gives you what you want to hear instead of what was true, and Viridia needed the truth more than she needed comfort.

So that was the sum of it. Nobody knew. Nobody had seen Alice fall and nobody had seen Alice flee, and the wound stayed exactly as open as it had been, and Viridia folded the asking away with everything else and kept walking, and did not let any of them see that with each *no* the empty space the size of Alice had grown a little colder.

* * *

They cleared the tree line into a wide dark meadow under the full moon, and the shadows came alive and took them.

It happened fast. One moment they were stepping out of the pines, and the next the moonlit ground itself seemed to rise up in reaching hands of dark, wrapping the children, wrapping Amber, wrapping even Lor-ar before he could spring, grasping shadow-bonds that pinned them where they stood. The girls cried out, terrified, not understanding. Amber struggled weakly and could not break free. Lor-ar snarled, his fur sparking, straining against the dark and held fast by it.

Viridia did not struggle.

She had felt the shape of the magic the instant it touched her, the cold clear part reading it before the fear could take her, and she understood at once that the shadows were holding, not harming, that there was no killing intent in them, only the intent to immobilize and assess. So she stood still inside her bonds, and saved her strength, and waited for whoever had cast them to show himself, watching the dark with the mana-sight up, hunting the core that had thrown the spell.

She found it before she found the man. A great dark core, swirling black, larger than any she had seen except Lightwell's, larger perhaps than Lightwell's, blazing in a chest somewhere out past the edge of the moonlight. And

then the man stepped out of the trees, and the core walked with him.

He was younger than she expected, mid-twenties, lean and lanky, with close-cropped hair that might have been dark brown or black, she could not tell in the moonlight, and quick eyes that took in the whole huddled, bound group of them in a single sweep. The eyes reached Lor-ar, snarling in his shadow-bonds, and stopped, and the man's whole posture changed, and he swore, low, and swept his hand through the air, and the shadows let go all at once.

"Sorry," he said, stepping closer, the apology rough and real. "I'm sorry. Lightwell didn't tell me you were coming. I saw a group come out of the trees at night, this close to the camp, I assumed—" He stopped himself. His eyes went over the soot-streaked children, the slumped exhausted Amber, the great singed tiger, the slight silver-blond girl unmoving at the center of it with a spear in her hand and a quiver on her back and a stranger's dried blood on her arms, and something in his face shifted, a careful man recalculating. "My name's Jazen," he said, and held out his hand.

Viridia took it. His grip was dry and quick. "Viridia," she said. "This is Lor-ar." She looked back at the children, at Amber sitting down hard in the meadow grass with her head bowed. "Are we close to your camp? They're done in. Some of them are barely standing."

Jazen looked at the children, and his hardness eased into something kinder. "Close," he said. "Follow me."

* * *

He led them on through more woods, and every so often he stopped to disable a ward, a complex knot of magic strung across their path, and then to reset it behind them once they had passed. Viridia watched him work the first few, and recognized most of the runes, and did not recognize all of

them, and filed the unfamiliar ones to ask about later, because even now, even soot-stained and grieving and walking into the unknown, the cataloguing part of her would not stop working; it was the only part of her that never tired.

"Isn't it dangerous," she asked, as they came at last over a rise and she saw, in the valley below, a village lit up with bonfires, far too much light for people hiding from an army, "to burn that many fires at night?"

"Not at all." Jazen was unraveling another ward, his brow furrowed with the work. "I've found a way to make a fixed place invisible. Properly invisible, from the outside. It costs an enormous amount of magic to hold, so there are only three of us in the camp who can power it, which is why one of us has always to be inside the wards." The last of the magic dissolved under his hands and he let out a breath, and a flicker of real pleasure crossed his tired face. "It's the trickiest piece of magic I know. It feels good every time it works. Go on. Get your people down to the fire in the middle of the village and warm them. I'll set the wards again and meet you there."

She got her people down to the fire.

The villagers came out as they passed, and word had clearly run ahead, because some of them murmured condolences to the children, and offered blankets, and a heavy woman with kind eyes scooped up the smallest of the second-years and carried her toward the warmth without being asked. The kindness undid the children where the fear had not; several of them began, finally, to cry, now that it was safe, now that there were arms and blankets and fire. Viridia got them to the central bonfire and saw them settled, and Amber sank down by the fire and stared into it and still did not speak, and Viridia stood a little apart with Lor-ar pressed against her leg, watching the flames, too wired to sit,

the watchful part of her still on duty even here, even now, even where it was finally safe.

Jazen came out of the dark into the firelight, wiping sweat from his forehead with a kerchief he then folded into his pocket, his grin not quite reaching his eyes. He wore plain brown trousers and a dark blue shirt, and he looked, in the firelight, very young and very tired and like a man holding a great many things up by main force.

"Well," he said. "That's the wards set. Now the important part. How did you come to be at my tree line in the middle of the night, and why are you here?"

So she told him. She told it plainly, the cold clear way, because there was no other way she could have gotten through it: the screams in the night, the soldiers, the white and gold of the capital's army, the decree. The fight in the halls. The escape by portal.

And she watched Jazen go still as she spoke, stiller and stiller, until by the end of it he was not moving at all.

* * *

"So she's dead," Jazen said. Softly. He closed his eyes for a moment, and a thing crossed his face that Viridia knew on sight, because she had worn it, because she wore it still, every day, under the careful surface. "She's dead."

"I didn't see her die," Viridia said. Three weeks had taught her exactly how much and how little to give a grieving person. "She was alive and fighting the Chancellor when I left. She told me to get the others out. It's possible she—"

"No." Jazen shook his head, hard, once. "They wouldn't have let her escape. Not her. They'd have made sure of her before anything else." He opened his eyes, and they were wet, and he did not bother to hide it, which told Viridia more about him than anything he had said. "They've taken everything from me now. First my sister. Now my mother."

Viridia went rigid.

"Your mother," she said.

Jazen looked at her, and understood, from her face, that she had not known. "Lady Lightwell," he said. "Isolde. She was my mother. I wasn't given her name; it would have ended her at the school the day she took the post. She put me out into the world under another name and ran her resistance from inside the place that would have killed us both if it knew, for fifteen years." His voice was steady and his face was not. "It nearly broke her when they burned my sister Jan. After that she stopped being careful in the small ways. She helped more. Took more risks. I think part of her had already decided how it would end." He looked into the fire. "And now it's ended, and I wasn't there, and the last thing I have of her is a girl I've never met telling me she died throwing shadow at the man who killed my sister."

Viridia did not say she was sorry. She had hated being told she was sorry, in the days after the kitchen; the words were a door people shut so they would not have to stand in the cold with you. So she said the only true thing she had.

"She gave the last order I'll ever take from her to save eight children and find you," she said. "She was winning when I left. I want you to know that. Whatever they did to her after, when I last saw her she was a general on her own ground and she was winning, and she sent me here knowing you would take care of what she couldn't anymore." She paused. "She trusted you with the people she died saving. That's what she had left to give, at the end. She gave it to you."

For a moment she thought she had said too much, or the wrong thing, the way the wrong thing was so easy to say to grief. Jazen's jaw worked. He looked down into the fire and a single tear cut a clean line through the soot and sweat on his face and dropped off his chin into the dark, and he let it, did

not wipe it, the way a man does not wipe a thing he has decided he has a right to. Viridia thought of her own face, dry, always dry, and felt something almost like envy of him, that he could stand in firelight in front of a stranger and let his grief run down his face and not be ashamed. She had never once been able to do it. Grief was grief, she decided, and took the shape the vessel gave it; his shape and hers were only the same water poured into different cups.

"She used to write to me," he said, after a while, his voice gone rough and low. "Twice a year. Never signed. Never said anything that could be read by the wrong eyes. Just—weather. How the school was. A line about a student now and then, the ones she was proud of. I burned every letter the day it came; we both knew the rule. But I'd read them ten times first." He drew a slow breath. "There won't be any more letters. That's the thing I can't get my head round. Not that she's gone. People go; I know that better than most. That there won't be any more letters." He looked up at Viridia, and his wet eyes were steady. "Was she one of them? The students she was proud of? Did she ever say a word about a quiet first-year with a stone she couldn't put down?"

"She told me I was chosen," Viridia said. "Twice. The first day, and the last. I didn't understand it either time." She held his gaze. "I think I'm one of the things she was keeping. I don't know yet what for."

Jazen looked at her for a long moment across the fire, and something passed between them, the recognition of two people who carried the same weight, and he nodded, slowly, and straightened, and put the grief away the way she put hers away, into the place you visit later, when there is time, if there is ever time.

"Enough," he said, his voice rougher now but level. "You've all had the worst night of your lives. I'll take you to quarters. We'll talk about what comes next in the morning."

He led them to two houses at the end of a narrow lane, with a fire burning low in front, and held the door of one open for the children and Amber to file through, silent and stumbling and spent. As Viridia moved to follow, he caught her by the shoulder, lightly, careful of the bound arm he had already noted and said nothing about, and stopped her.

"Come find me when you wake," he said, low. "Not the others. You. There are things I think you and I should say to each other without an audience." He let go. "You got eight children out of a burning school through a portal you cast yourself, at your age, with the capital's army at your back. My mother didn't sponsor people lightly, and she didn't tell me your name, which means she was keeping you for something. I'd like to know what." A ghost of the grin, real this time, exhausted. "In the morning. Sleep first. You look like I feel."

* * *

The quarters were a single long room with bedrolls laid out on the floor, enough of them, which someone had thought to prepare, which meant the camp had been ready for refugees the way Lightwell had been ready for the bad day, the whole secret machine of the resistance turning over even now to make a place for eight crying children and a silver-blond girl with blood on her arms. Viridia pulled her own bedroll to the far wall, away from the others, out of long habit, and Lor-ar, still in his great storm-colored shape, lay down along the wall beside her like a barrier between her and the room.

The children's breathing slowed, one by one, into the deep even rhythm of exhausted sleep. Amber lay among them, finally still, her face slack and young in sleep in a way it never was awake. The fire outside threw moving light across the ceiling.

She thought about Jazen's last words to her, *she was keeping you for something*, and turned them over, and found she did not resent them the way she would once have resented being a thing kept for a purpose. A month ago she had wanted only to be unseen, to slip through the school like water and be no one's business and survive by being too small to notice. That girl was gone, burned up somewhere in the halls with the paintings and the spellbook. The girl in the bedroll against the far wall had killed three men and unmade a fourth and carried eight children through a portal she had taught herself to cast, and she was, she understood with a kind of cold clear surprise, no longer trying to be small. What she was trying to be instead, she could not yet say. But it was not small, and it was not unseen, and there was no going back to the girl at the gates who had only wanted to disappear. Viridia lay in her bedroll by the far wall and did not sleep.

Her mind would not stop, and the things it would not stop on were the things she had been holding all night, and now, in the dark and the safety and the quiet, with no children to keep walking and no fire to tend and no portal to cast, they came for her, all of them at once, the man in the doorway and the captain unmade inside his own shield and the bodies she had refused to look at and the choice in the alcove and the empty space the size of Alice. She lay there and let them come, because there was nowhere left to put them, and she did not cry, because Amber was an arm's length away and a child stirred now and then in the dark, and even here, even now, even when it would have cost nothing but to let it out, she held it, because holding it was the last wall she had left standing and she was afraid of what was on the other side of it.

Instead she reached for the bonds.

She reached first for Raizen, down the warm thread that ran off into the dark, and he was there, distant but there, and she felt him feel her, felt the surge of his relief come back down the link, wordless, fierce, *alive, you're alive, I'm coming, I don't know where you are but I'm coming*, and she held to that, the one certain thing, the dragon at the other end of an unbreakable thread, and it steadied her, a little, enough.

And then, before she could stop herself, the way you reach with a hand for something that is no longer there, she reached for Alice.

There was no bond. There had never been a bond. Alice was a friend, not a true-bonded creature; there was no thread between them, no warm certain link, no way at all to reach across the dark and feel whether she was alive or dead. Viridia knew that. She had always known that. And still, in the worst hour of the worst night, her grieving mind reached for Alice the way it reached for Raizen, expecting the thread, needing the thread, and found only the place where a thread would have been if the world were kinder, an absence, a nothing, her reaching hand closing on empty dark.

She reached, and there was nothing there.

She reached again, because the first nothing could not be believed, and there was nothing there.

It was not like reaching for the dead. She had reached for her parents a hundred times in the small hours and met the closed finality of a thing that was over, a door that would not open because there was no longer a room behind it. This was a door she could not find at all. Alive somewhere in the dark and needing her, or dead in a burning ward and past all needing, and no way to know which, the two of them braided into one unbearable cord. The dead you bury. The missing you carry.

And she lay in the dark of a stranger's camp with a tiger at her back and a dragon at the far end of one thread and her best friend at the far end of no thread at all, reaching and reaching for a bond that did not exist, for the only person who might tell her whether the person she loved most in the world was alive, and finding, each time, only the silence where the answer would have been, and that silence was the loneliest thing she had ever held, lonelier than the kitchen, lonelier than the cave, the specific and bottomless loneliness of not knowing, and being unable, by any magic in the world or out of it, to find out.

Sleep was a long time coming. When at last it came, it was Lor-ar's slow breathing she used to find it, the way she had once used her father's, in a house that no longer existed, the rise and fall of a sleeping thing she loved, counting it, until the counting carried her down into the dark.

Her last clear thought before it took her was Jazen's, low at the door. *Come find me when you wake.* He had buried his mother tonight without a body, the same as she was burying Alice, and he had still looked at her across the fire like a man who had recognized the start of something. Whatever Lightwell had been keeping her for, it had not burned with the school. It was waiting for her in the morning, in a camp full of people the capital had sworn to end, and for the first time since the gate she found she wanted to know what it was.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

What Comes Next

There is a particular kind of morning that comes after the end of the world, and Viridia woke into it not knowing, at first, that the world had ended, which is the cruelty the body does to protect you: it forgets, for the length of one breath between sleep and waking, and gives you the old ordinary morning, and then it remembers, and gives you the new one.

She lay in the borrowed bedroll where she had dragged it the night before, hard against the far wall, and had her one merciful breath, and then she remembered, all of it, the fire and the choice and the empty space and the no-thread, and she lay still and let it arrive rather than fighting it, because six weeks had taught her that grief fought at the door only comes in through the window. The room was grey with early light. The children still slept, tangled in their bedrolls. Amber was awake, sitting up against the opposite wall with her knees drawn to her chest, staring at nothing, and when Viridia met her eyes Amber did not perform anything, did not reach for the joke, only looked at her, hollow and honest, and nodded once, and Viridia nodded back, and that was the whole conversation, two survivors confirming for each other that they had, against the odds and against some part of their own wishing, survived.

Lor-ar lifted his great head from the floor. *You are awake,* he said. *Jazen asked you to come find him. The camp is already*

stirring. Eat something first; you ate nothing yesterday and a tired and hungry mind makes a coward of a brave one. Then go.

The camp in daylight was a real place, lived-in, which surprised her; some part of her had expected a desperate huddle and found instead a village, ramshackle and crowded and entirely alive. Houses built close together. Washing on lines. Children, dark-mage children, playing in the lanes, the ones the resistance had managed to save over the years, growing up in the one place in the world that would have them. Some of the rescued girls from Hazel had found them already and were being folded into a game whose rules Viridia could not follow, and the ordinary sound of children playing in the morning after the worst night of their lives struck her as the bravest thing she had heard in a month. People nodded to her as she passed, some of them offering low condolences, which meant the story of their arrival had already run through the camp, and she received the condolences the way she gave them, briefly, without leaning on them, and moved on.

She saw, as she went, the shape of the life these people had built in their box of invisible air. A blacksmith's shed, the fire already going. A woman teaching three small children their letters on slates at a long table in the open, and Viridia slowed at that without meaning to, because the symbols on the slates were not the ones she had been taught at Hazel; they were older, rounder, and one of them, with a small jolt, she knew for a Moravian character, taught here to dark-mage children as a matter of course, the language the light schools pretended was dead being passed to six-year-olds over breakfast as though it had never been anything but alive. A whole world, hidden under the wards. A whole way of being that the capital had spent six hundred years trying to convince itself it had already destroyed, going on, quietly, teaching its children to read. It steadied

something in her she had not known was unsteady. Whatever happened on the road to the capital, this had survived. People like her had found a way to go on being people, in secret, in the dark, and they had not gone small; they had gone hidden, which she was learning was a different and braver thing.

Before she went, she sat a while with Amber by the cold ashes of last night's fire, and they did not say much, because there was not much to say that either of them could bear to say yet. Amber had a blanket round her shoulders that one of the village women had given her, and she held a cup of something hot and did not drink it, and watched the rescued girls being absorbed into the camp's games, and at last she said, not looking at Viridia, "I keep thinking I should have held the shield longer. That if I'd held it another minute we'd have gotten more out."

"You'd have died," Viridia said. "And then the eight you did get out would have died too, when it dropped. You held it exactly as long as it could be held."

"I know that." Amber turned the cup in her hands, the chipped black nails catching the grey light. "Knowing it and believing it are different rooms. I'll get from the one to the other eventually. I always do." She almost smiled. "I've had practice." It was the closest she had come to the old armor since the woods, and Viridia was glad of it, because it meant the Amber she knew was still in there, climbing back. "Go on. Jazen wants you. And Viridia." She caught her arm, briefly. "Whatever he asks you to be part of. Think about it before you say yes. You're fourteen. You're allowed to not be the one who carries it, just this once."

"So are you," Viridia said.

Amber let go, and looked back at the fire, and said nothing, which was its own answer, and they both knew it.

She found Jazen at the town hall, where she was told he was meeting with the council.

* * *

The town hall was a large old stone building near the center of the camp, its windows dusty, its wooden porch sagging and grey. An old man with a graying beard and a balding head opened the scuffed double doors at her knock, studied her a moment with sharp tired eyes, grunted, and motioned her to follow. Down a long hallway she could hear raised voices, one of them Jazen's.

"We must do *something*," Jazen was saying, as she came in behind the old man. "We cannot sit here while he kills our people one village at a time. He has just burned a *school*, Coram. Children."

He glanced up as Viridia entered, nodded to her, and turned back to the three others in the room. They sat at a long table: a woman on the left in a pale blue dress, older, with silver-and-gold spectacles; a broad sunburned man in the middle, a few years older than Jazen and built like someone who worked outdoors; and on the right a stately older woman with silver hair pulled into a tight bun, a hooked nose, eyes the cold grey of her hair. The old man who had led Viridia in took the seat beside the stately woman, and the council was complete, and Viridia stood at the back by the wall and made herself small and watchful, the old habit, and listened.

"We understand what you're saying, Jazen." The sunburned man's voice held the worn patience of an argument had many times. "It isn't that simple. We have people here who can't fight. Children. The old. Someone has to protect them."

"Brutus is right." The woman in blue spoke gently, but firmly. "We're grieved about your mother. Truly. But grief

isn't a strategy. And now that she's gone, we've lost our eyes inside the capital's reach. Our position here is more precarious today than it was a week ago, not less."

"That is *exactly* my point." Jazen's voice cracked and steadied. "We've lost our inside eyes. We've lost the early warning that kept this place hidden. Hiding worked while we had her. It will not work now." He set both hands flat on the table. "By this time next week I mean to be on the road to the capital. And I'll be taking the only two others who can power these wards with me. So decide quickly which side of that road you mean to stand on."

Viridia, watching from the wall, read them the way she read everyone, by the detail that did not fit the words. The woman in blue spoke of strategy, but her hands kept going to a small worn locket at her throat, opening and closing the clasp without her knowing she did it, and Viridia thought: she has children in this camp, or grandchildren, and every word she says about supply lines is really a word about them. Brutus folded his big sunburned arms and frowned at the table, and his fear was the simplest and the most honest: he had built something here, with his hands, the houses, the lines, the wards' anchor-posts, and he did not want to watch it burn the way Jazen's school had burned, and could not say so without sounding a coward, and so said *strategy* instead. The stately woman with the silver bun sat very straight and her grey eyes were not afraid at all, and the lack of fear in them frightened Viridia more than the others' fear did; she was the one weighing the thing coldly, the one who had already done the arithmetic of how many would die on the road and was prepared to spend them, and Viridia trusted her least and understood her best, because she did her arithmetic the same way.

None of them were villains. That was the thing Viridia took away from the room, the thing that would stay with her.

There were no villains here, only frightened people who loved different things and could not have all of them, which was, she was beginning to understand, the actual shape of every war that had ever been, under the banners and the speeches: people who loved different things, and not enough world to keep them all.

The two women exchanged an uneasy look. The stately woman opened her mouth. "Now, Jazen." And Jazen cut her off with a flat motion of his hand.

"No. You wanted me on this council because it is my magic that hides you. Fine. But all we have done with that magic is *hide*. I'm telling you it's finished. I will not stand by and watch them kill dark mages by decree, in the open, with the law's blessing, and do nothing but pull the dark a little closer over our heads."

It was the old man, Coram, who spoke at last, his voice soft, almost sorrowful. "So you mean to use our safety as a club. To make us do as you wish, or lose the wards that keep us alive."

"Not at all," Jazen said. "If Hiram and Abe wish to stay and keep you hidden, they're free to. I won't compel them. But I know they chafe under this council's caution the way I do, and I think you know it too, so don't be surprised when they choose the road." He held the old man's gaze. "I'm not threatening you, Coram. I'm telling you the truth, which is harder. The choice is real. I'd rather you made it with your eyes open."

Coram studied him for a long, troubled moment. Then he sighed, and the sigh was the sound of a man setting down a thing he had carried a long way. "We'll do as you ask."

The others started in surprise. The woman in blue began, "Coram."

"You know as well as I do," Coram said, turning on them, his soft voice gone hard, "that we cannot hold this place if

the three of them leave. And you know as well as I that half the people in this camp are tired of hiding, tired of growing old in a box, tired of teaching their children that the safest thing they can do is disappear. He speaks sense. I'm too old to pretend he doesn't because I'm afraid." He looked back at Jazen. "If it goes wrong, it goes wrong on all our heads, not yours alone. But it goes."

The stately woman had not moved. Now she laid her palms on the table, the way Jazen had, and Viridia braced for the cold arithmetic to come down against him. Instead the grey eyes went, for one unguarded second, to the window, to the sound of the children in the lane. "I buried two sons to the decrees," she said, in a voice with no warmth in it and no waver either. "I have spent four years deciding it was wiser to keep what was left. I find I no longer believe my own arithmetic. Go, Jazen. I will hold the line behind you until there is no line to hold." It cost her something to say; Viridia could see it cost her, the way it costs a person to lay down a thing they have made their whole self out of carrying. Then the coldness came back over her face like a shutter, and she was, once more, the woman who counted the dead before they died.

The sunburned man, Brutus, looked from face to face, and was the last to yield. "If this goes badly, Jazen," he said heavily, "remember that we told you."

"I'll remember," Jazen said. "I remember everything. It's the curse of my family." And he glanced at Viridia by the wall, and tipped his head toward the door, and she followed him out.

* * *

He walked her to the edge of the camp, past the last houses, to where the air shivered faintly with the great hidden

wards, and there, where no one could hear, he stopped and looked out at the forest and was quiet for a while.

"They're afraid," he said at last. "The council. I don't blame them. Patrols have come close to finding this place a dozen times. With the number of people we have, we couldn't move them fast if we had to. And here I am proposing to march half of them at the capital." He rubbed his face. "It isn't only my family. I want you to believe that. It isn't only Jan and my mother, though God knows that's in it. It's that I've watched us hide for two years and I've watched them hunt us anyway, and I've worked out that hiding only buys you the privilege of being killed later instead of now. Someone has to make them stop. If not us, no one. We're the only ones strong enough and the only ones with nothing left to lose."

"I think the council understands that," Viridia said, choosing her words the way she chose everything, carefully, turning them over first. "I think that's why they're afraid. Not because they don't see it. Because they do, and they know what it costs, and at least here, hidden, they have lives. Small ones. But lives."

"Lives I *gave* them," Jazen said, with sudden heat. "Before me they spent every day wondering when a patrol would find them. I gave them the wards. I gave them the bonfires at night. I gave them children playing in the lanes."

"And you can't see that they'd do anything not to go back to the before," Viridia said. "Even march on a capital. Because you handed them safety, and now you're asking them to hand it back, and that's the cruelest thing you can ask a person who's been afraid their whole life. You're not wrong, Jazen. But neither are they. That's the worst kind of disagreement there is. The kind where everyone's right."

Jazen looked at her, the recalculating look again, the one that had crossed his face when he first counted the blood on her arms in the moonlight. "How old did you say you were?"

"Fourteen."

"God help the capital," he said, almost to himself, and there was no joke in it. "For what it's worth, I agree with you. Both of you. Which is no help at all."

He was quiet a moment, watching the trees, and then he said, more carefully, the way a man approaches a thing he is not sure he should touch: "My mother kept you for something. I keep coming back to it. She didn't put your name in any letter, and she put a great many names in letters. The students she was proud of, she'd risk a line. You, she wouldn't risk even that. That's not how you treat a promising first-year. That's how you treat a secret." He looked at her sideways. "I'm not going to ask you what you are. You've earned the right to tell me or not. But I'll tell you what I think, and you can do with it what you like. I think you're the thing she was building toward. I think every risk she took these last two years, every line she crossed, was clearing a road for something, and I think the something walked into my camp last night with a dead man's blood on her arms and eight children behind her, and I think the reason she said *you were chosen* twice is that she chose you, for whatever's coming, and didn't live long enough to tell you for what."

Viridia said nothing. There was nothing safe to say, and Jazen did not seem to need her to say it; he had spoken it mostly to set it down, the way she set things down.

"You don't have to answer," he said. "You're fourteen. Amber's right about that, whatever she said to you this morning. Yes, I heard about it, this is a small camp and I make it my business to know things. You're allowed to be a child a little longer, if you can find a way." He turned to face

her. "But I don't think you can. I think that road closed behind you in a burning corridor. So I'll say the other thing instead. When you decide what you are, and you will, you'll have to, there's a place for it here. Whatever it turns out to be. That's the last thing my mother would have wanted me to tell you, so I'm telling you. There's a place for you here. You don't have to be small to be safe with us. We're done with small."

It landed in her somewhere deep, in the place that had wanted, six weeks ago, only to disappear. *We're done with small*. She did not have a reply that would not cost her more than she could spend that morning, so she gave him the only thing she had, which was the truth, plainly.

"Thank you," she said. "I'll remember that. I remember everything too. It's not a curse. It's the only thing that's kept me alive."

"Then we'll get on," Jazen said, and almost smiled. "Tell me if your people need anything. Clothes, supplies. You came with nothing; I haven't forgotten. There's no shame in it. Everyone in this camp came with nothing once."

"There is one thing," Viridia said.

* * *

She had been carrying it since the woods, the question, holding it the way she held everything, until the moment was right, and the moment was now, at the edge of a hidden camp with a war a week away, because she had learned that you do not wait for a better time to ask the thing you cannot live without knowing, because better times do not reliably come.

"When your people gather news," she said. "Survivors. From the school, or the roads, or the capital's prisons, if they keep any. Anyone who got out of Hazel, or was taken." She kept her voice even. She kept her face the careful face. Only

her hands, at her sides, had curled, and she made them uncurl. "There's a girl. A first-year. Her name is Alice. Alice Pembrook." The name came out of her steady, and cost her everything to make steady. "Long blond hair. Freckles. One tooth turned a little out of line when she smiles. She was a healer's helper, she was in the medical ward when it started. I never learned if she got out. Nobody saw. I couldn't reach the ward. I had to take the others and go, and I left her, and whether she's alive or dead I cannot say, and there's no bond between us, no way for me to feel it, no way to know." Her voice did not break. It went very flat, instead, which was the closest thing to breaking she allowed herself. "If your people hear anything. A name. A first-generation mage girl named Alice Pembrook. I need to know. Alive or dead, I need to know which. The not-knowing is—" She stopped. She did not have a word for what the not-knowing was. There was not one.

Jazen held her gaze for a long moment, and whatever he saw in the flat voice and the uncurled hands, he understood it, because he had a sister he had failed to save as well, and he did not offer her comfort or false hope, which she would have hated, which would have been one more door shut against the cold.

"Alice Pembrook," he said. Simply. Filing it, the way she filed things, somewhere it would not be lost. "First-year. Healer's helper. I'll put the word out on every line we have. If she's alive anywhere our people can reach, we'll hear of it. I can't promise you it'll be good news. I can promise you it'll be true news, when there is any, and that I'll bring it to you myself." He held out his hand, not to shake this time, but open, the offer of something. "That's the first thing I've been able to give anyone in two years that wasn't a wall to hide behind. Thank you for asking me for it."

She took his hand. It was the first time since the gates of Hazel that she had reached out and taken hold of a thing offered by someone she had not known a month, and it did not feel like nothing, and she filed that too.

* * *

He went back into the camp to begin the work of the war, and Viridia stayed at the edge alone, where the wards shivered, and looked out at the forest, and let herself, finally, in the grey morning with no one watching, take an accounting.

She had arrived at Hazel six weeks ago in the back of a motorcar, three days orphaned, with three suitcases and a stone she gripped when she was drowning and a silver focus she could not read and a single overwhelming want, which was to be unseen, to make herself so small and quiet that the grief and the world would both pass over her without noticing she was there.

She was leaving the wreck of Hazel with less than she came with, and more.

Less: her parents, three weeks dead and never grieved aloud. The spellbook, with her mother's letter and the family tree and the one name that did not fit, burned. The focus, burned. The school. The frightening table. The lamplit room. Alice, who might be alive, who might be ash, who was, either way, gone from her side, an empty space the exact size and shape of a girl that walked beside her now and would not leave.

And more, so much more, that she could hardly hold it: a sylvan tiger three hundred years old who told her the truth and called her *little one* only when it counted. A prismatic dragon at the far end of an unbreakable thread, alive, coming for her across miles he could not measure. The ancient language, the Moravian script, alive in her head

where no book could burn it out. The Dangris, who had named her Kor-toh and given her the Heart of the Spear. Four Damascus spears and a body that knew how to use them, and a long pale scar coming up along her left forearm where her own rune had fed on her in the dark, twin to the bare seam on Lor-ar's flank, the price of the one trick that had kept them both alive, a thing that would not heal however whole the one doing the mending, that she would carry the rest of her life as a reminder that she had not been protected, only quick, and only once. A core grown from a hearth to a furnace, and the knowledge of what she was, which was not broken, which had never been broken, which was the only whole thing in a world that had cut itself in half out of fear. The truth about the severing, and the frayed thread that might, one day, mend it. A thread in the oldest magic in the world with her mother's name on it, that she could not yet follow, that she would, someday, be strong enough to follow. A war. A camp full of people who would have her. A man who had promised to bring her true news of the only friend she had left.

She had wanted to disappear. She was not going to get to disappear. That girl, the one at the gates who only wanted to be small, had burned up somewhere in the halls of Hazel, and Viridia found, standing at the edge of the camp with the war coming and her friend lost and her dead ungrieved, that she did not mourn her. The small girl could not have carried any of this. The small girl would have died in the first corridor. It had taken the loss of nearly everything to make her into something that could not be made small. That was a terrible price. She had paid it. She was not going to waste what it had bought.

She thought, standing there, of her mother. Of the line she had carried six weeks and would carry for the rest of her life. *Be careful who you let see you do it.* She had taken it, all this

time, as a warning to hide, a key to the lock she kept on herself. She turned it over now in the grey light and heard, for the first time, the other half of it, the half a frightened child could not have heard. It was not only *hide*. It was *choose*. Be careful, yes; the world is dangerous and you are more dangerous than the world knows, and most eyes that fall on you will want to cage you or kill you. But you decide who sees. You. Not the school, not the Chancellor, not the fear. There would be people, her mother had been telling her, worth being seen by. There would be a tiger, and a dragon, and a sponsor with chipped black nails who recognized the shape of your grief, and a friend with calm hands, and a man at the edge of a camp who said *we're done with small*. The grief was the lock. But the line had always held a key as well, and the key was this: you get to choose the ones who see you do it. And she had begun to choose them, without knowing she was choosing, and they had cost her terribly, every one, and she would not for anything in the world give a single one of them back.

The thread in the well shone somewhere past her reach. The empty space the size of Alice stood at her side. The forest stretched out ahead, dark and endless and, she knew now, full of more life than anyone had ever told her, and somewhere out past it was a capital that wanted her dead and a war that would decide whether anyone like her got to exist at all.

Viridia Saeren stood at the edge of the hidden camp and faced forward, toward the trees, toward the war, toward the not-knowing and the work and whatever came next, and she did not look back at the glow of the burning school, which had gone out in the night, leaving only smoke. She had arrived with grief and a focus she could not read. She was leaving with a tiger, a dragon, a language no one else alive

could speak, a war she had not chosen, and no word of her friend.

She did not know if Alice was alive.

She only knew that she was alive, that she would not stop, that whatever the world had decided about girls like her, it had decided too soon, before it had met this one.

She took a breath, went to find her people, and began.

About the Author



Post Peleos writes character-driven fantasy about quiet people in loud worlds — stories that love to tease as much as they wound, and never quite stop wondering what waits out beyond the stars. *The Saeren Chronicles* is his debut series.

Acknowledgments

To my parents, for always believing in me.

The story continues in

THE SAEREN CHRONICLES

Book Two: The Resistance

On the fourth morning the camp put her to work, which was the kindest thing it could have done.

It was Brutus who did it, the broad sunburned man from the council, who found her standing at the edge of the lanes with nothing in her hands and the look on her face of a person who has run out of things to be useful for. He did not ask her how she was, which she was grateful for, because she had heard the question a dozen times since the burning school and had not yet found a true answer that did not cost more than it was worth to give. He simply looked her up and down, the way he looked at a length of timber, and grunted, and said, “You. You’ve got two arms. Come hold this.”

And running under all of it, under the washing and the games and the smell of bread, a thing she could feel the way you feel a clock in a quiet house: the count. *A week*, Jazen had said. *By this time next week I mean to be on the road to the capital.* Four days of it were already gone.

Viridia’s war is only beginning. The Resistance follows her from the hidden camp to the gates of the capital – and to the choice the whole of the first book has been quietly preparing her to make.

